**I 'Awoo' you!**

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# I 'Awoo' you!

by LoneCookie

Summary

> “Look, this might sound a little strange… but could you hear me out for a moment?” Phainon asks, his tone hopeful.
>
> Mydei supposes he signed himself to it. He gives a short nod. Phainon fidgets with the bandage between his fingers.
>
> “I wanted today to be special.” He pauses, his shoulders dropping slightly. “There’s someone I’ve wanted to ask out for a long time.”
>
> *Oh, by Nikador balls*. Mydei was really going to have to sit here and listen to Phainon gush about his undying crush on Cyrene, wasn’t he? He clenches his fists inside the costume, a wave of discomfort washing over him.

Mydei is working part-time as a mascot at the recently opened Chimera Park. While wearing his Fig Stew costume, he unexpectedly befriends a cheerful teenager, who happens to be both his classmate and his long-time secret crush for over two years, Phainon.

What could possibly go wrong?

Notes

Rated M mostly for language for now.

Welcome to two teenagers suffering because they can't sit down and talk: the fic.

Both Mydei and Phainon are 18 in this.

English is not my first language, so expect some errors. Sorry!

# Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*Chimera Park Grand Opening*

*Dear Citizens of Okhema,*

*We invite you, along with your friends and family, to join us for a day filled with games and fun. Come experience our themed attractions and meals, and even have a chance to play with the little Chimeras!*

*Throughout the opening month, we'll also be joined by some of the most beloved Chimeras from the hit show The Awoo Firm.*
*We look forward to welcoming everyone with excitement!*

*—The Awoo Team*

Mydei glances up from the pamphlet to the girl before him.

"What am I supposed to do with this information?" he asks.

Hyacine brings her hands together.

"They are hiring part-timers to play as mascots in the park," she replies.

Mydei blinks at her, cocking his head to the side.

"Yeah…?"

Hyacine's lips curve up in a grin.

"Me, Rice, and Ciphy are going to apply for the position." She pauses, shifting her weight from one foot to another as if she knew way too much. "We were wondering if you'd like to come with us?"

Mydei frowns. Why would he? Sure, he loved the cartoon and its characters—the Fig Stew charm on his phone was just one of the many pieces of merch he owned. But working as a park mascot sounded like a hassle.

"I'm not intere—…"

"Employees get yearly VIP park passes and can interact with the Chimeras as much as they want. Plus… we'll receive special merch autographed by *The Awoo Firm* writers," Hyacine says smugly, as if she's striking an irrefutable deal.

Damn. She'd make a fine businesswoman someday.

Mydei stops in his tracks. It isn't hard to see he's clearly interested—he bites his lip.

"… Fine," he concedes, successfully lured in.

Hyacine giggles as they discuss where to meet for the audition that weekend.



The part-time job, Mydei finds out, is rather simple. Not many people were interested in working as mascots under the scorching sun of the Month of Freedom. So when a group of high schoolers shows up for an interview, the manager—who introduced himself as Mr. Reca—almost drops to his knees in relief.

The mascot show only runs on Sundays for about thirty minutes. It involves some dancing and miming along to recorded music and the park's fanfare. After the show, the performers can interact with visitors, take pictures, and even accompany guests to attractions if they wish.

Each of the girls, along with Mydei, has their measurements taken. After a brief quiz, they are assigned their respective Chimeras. They also receive a digital manual on how to behave around children and what actions are forbidden.

Hyacine is assigned Krenabis, Castorice gets Butterfly Cake, Cipher receives Master Cat-Thief, and Mydei lands Fig Stew. What a coincidence—the only Kremnoan employee gets to play the Kremnoan Chimera.

On the first Sunday, Mydei arrives an hour early to pick up his costume. Castorice is already there, feeling a bit anxious since she's not really used to interacting with crowds. Mydei isn't exactly thrilled about the idea either, but his interest in the reward speaks louder.

They both enter the changing rooms and stare in confusion at the Chimera standing in front of a mirror, taking a selfie with a phone.

Mydei and Castorice exchange glances.

"Um… Excuse us…?" Castorice asks tentatively, her hands clasped awkwardly in front of her.

The black-and-red chimera turns toward them, placing a paw on its hip.

"Oh. Hello." Its voice is monotonous, almost uninterested. It puts the phone down on a table and extends a paw towards them. "I'm… what's the name again?"

"Gummy Roll," Mydei observes, recalling all of the characters by heart.

This seems to enlighten the memory of the person in the costume. Its large, round plush head nods.

"Oh, that's right. Nice to meet you."

Well, it seems their manager got another person hired at the last minute. As Castorice and Mydei greet the new mascot, Cipher and Hyacine arrive. They, too, look surprised by the

extra worker but warm up to them rather quickly as everyone picks up their costumes and heads to the fitting rooms.

Mydei can't say it's comfortable to wear a plush costume. The body feels like thick, heavy winter clothing, making moving a little difficult. The tail wagging is also a bit inconvenient, tugging at the fabric whenever it sways.

The worst part, however, is definitely the head. It's far too large and can get stuck in doorways if he isn't careful. His field of vision is also greatly reduced, allowing him to see only what's directly in front of him.

*The prizes are worth it*, he insists to himself as he walks out of the dressing room in all his glory.

"Aw, you look so cute, De!" Hyacine chirps. Her pink chimera costume is the smallest of the group, making her look almost like a cub next to the others.

"Imagine if the kids knew what was inside there," Cipher, now dressed as The Master Cat-Thief, mocks from her seat.

Mydei rolls his eyes. It's a running joke that some children are initially afraid of him at first glance.

Once they are all ready, their manager comes to check on them. He seems satisfied with the results and urges the group to pick some accessories for the show and the guest reception afterwards.

Mydei takes a pouch filled with candies and lollipops, perfect for handing out to children. There are also some Chimera-printed band-aids, since Mr. Reca guarantees that children always end up needing them in a park.

They are then given plastic instruments: Hyacine gets a little drum, Castorice a harp, Cipher a viola, and Mydei a guitar. The mysterious person inside the Gummy Roll suit now holds a flute.

The show starts at midday. A large crowd gathers around the main plaza of the park, many shouting and pointing at their favorite chimera as the group of mascots does their best to entertain them.

Hyacine is a natural. She waves, throws kisses, and fakes the drum beats with ease. Cipher's energetic movements attract the more hyperactive kids, while Castorice's shyness is seen as adorable as she dances with careful, guarded steps. Mydei, taller than the others, makes an imposing figure—his Fig Stew costume and red guitar stand out even from the back of the crowd, turning him into the "cool" Chimera. As for Gummy Roll… well, she's there, but it's almost as if she isn't, drawing mostly curious or puzzled glances from the audience.

After thirty minutes, Mydei feels like he's going to faint from dehydration. How do they expect mascots to keep interacting with guests all afternoon?

He retreats to a staff restroom, taking a few minutes' break before he has to go back out. After removing the immense Fig Stew head and pulling the costume down to his waist, he bends over the sink and splashes water on his face, sighing in relief.

"Uh… Hello?"

Mydei freezes. This voice, though muffled by the door, is oddly familiar. He stays quiet, the water still running down the sink.

"Is this really the restroom? Cyrene must have tricked me…"

Every alarm goes off in Mydei's head. The mention of Cyrene all but confirms that the person on the other side of the door is none other than Phainon Khaslana.

Under normal circumstances, that wouldn't pose a problem. Phainon is a classmate of his from high school—they interact ever so often, mostly picking on each other whenever they get the chance.

This also means the guy would never leave him alone about the part-time job if he found out.

"Hey… I know someone's in there. Can you please redirect me back to the guests' area?" Phainon asks in that earnest tone of his.

Mydei is still panicking silently as he thinks. He needs to conceal his identity; he can't risk speaking and being recognized. Glancing at his sweaty reflection in the mirror, he gets an idea.

Quickly donning the costume and Fig Stew's head, he straightens up and unlocks the door.

Phainon nearly jumps out of his flesh when a tall orange chimera greets him.

"*Titans!*" He clutches his chest, taking an instinctive step back.

"…" Mydei stares silently through Fig Stew's unmoving, happy face—what else can he do? If he weren't in the costume, he'd be laughing at the scare.

"I'm sorry, I wasn't expecting… a chimera," Phainon says, now sounding a bit embarrassed.

Mydei rolls his eyes, even though the guy can't see it. He points a paw to his side. Phainon follows the gesture.

"Are you… telling me where to go?" He tilts his head, uncertain.

Mydei nods, and Phainon finally understands.

"Oh! I see—thanks," he scratches the back of his neck. "And… sorry for interrupting."

Remaining silent, Mydei crosses his arms. Phainon takes the hint and heads back down the corridor toward the guest area.

As soon as he's out of sight, Mydei finally exhales. He leans back against the wall, fighting the urge to tear off the stupid costume.

Of course Phainon Khaslana was at the park. Just his luck. To make it worse, he's on a date with Cyrene. Even when Mydei tries to escape his one-sided crush, it finds a way to bite him in the ass. What a joyous day for a brokenhearted chimera.



With the knowledge that Phainon is in the park, it feels like the guy pops up everywhere he goes.

He takes pictures with families and children near the Dromases' ranch. A little farther ahead, two figures walk side by side as they watch the Dromas over the fence. One is clad in a white dress, with orchid eyes that twinkle like stars and long pink hair tied in a ponytail. She holds her date's arm, pulling him eagerly toward the animals.

"Look at that one, Phai! It's pink—it's so cute!" she exclaims. Mydei hates that he can't focus on what the kids around him are saying. It's as if his hearing has a filter tuned only to their conversation.

"I think the golden one is cuter," Phainon replies. Cyrene lets out a lighthearted laugh, as though he's just told the funniest joke in the world.

"Oh, of course you do…" Cyrene releases his arm and winks at him. Phainon smiles back, a faint blush coloring his cheeks.

Mydei's heart aches at the sight.

"Mr. Fig Stew, what's your favorite food? When I grow up, I wanna be as tall as you!" A kid suddenly shakes him out of his trance. He turns his big plush head towards the child.

While the mascots are allowed to talk to guests, he isn't confident that the distance between him and the couple is enough to keep him from being heard. After all, he's been eavesdropping on their conversation easily enough from where he stands.

"Mr. Fig Stew?" The kid paws at his fluffy legs, and all he wants to do is run.

Before he blows his cover, a paw lands on his shoulder.

"Didn't you know, little one? Fig Stew is under a spell… They lost their voice."

Startled, Mydei turns to Gummy Roll. When did it get so close?

Some of the kids around them let out a collective wail.

"Whaaat? Why?!"

"Is Mr. Fig Stew going to be okay?"

Gummy Roll removes its paw from his shoulder and crouches down to the children's eye level.

“They’re going to be fine. A witch cast a spell on them… but it can be broken with a kiss.”

*What*. Mydei scowls from inside his costume. A few of the kids let out an “Eww!” at the idea.

“Ohhh, like in the Clockie movies!” a girl in the group chirps, and Gummy Roll nods.

“Then why don’t you kiss them, Gummy Roll?” a boy asks.

“It doesn’t work like that. The kiss has to come from someone Fig Stew likes,” Gummy Roll replies smoothly.

Mydei is too afraid to look around and see if Phainon and Cyrene are listening to any of this madness.

“And who’s that?” another child asks, much to Mydei’s dismay.

“Who knows? Perhaps when they recover their voice… We’ll find out.” Gummy Roll pats some of the kids’ heads as it straightens up. “Until then, the curse only lets them say ‘*Awoo*.’”

Mydei’s head snaps toward it so fast his neck nearly cracks. Somehow, he can sense the smile inside that black and red chimera head.

The children keep questioning Gummy Roll about the curse, but the conversation soon shifts to another completely unrelated topic. Mydei tries to go along with it as best he can, handing out candies and taking more pictures. He’s almost too busy to remember his earlier worries when a familiar voice reaches his ears once more:

“Aw, poor Fig Stew… Isn’t that sad, Phai?” Cyrene’s overly sweet voice makes him wince.

“Yes… I hope this curse can be lifted soon,” Phainon agrees, and Mydei's stomach drops.

If it depends on who he likes, his curse may as well last forever.



“What the hell was that?” Mydei demands as soon as he and Gummy Roll are alone in the staff room. He immediately pulls off his headpiece, feeling suffocated after wearing it for too long. His hair is drenched with sweat, clinging to his forehead and neck.

“I was just entertaining them. It’s our job,” Gummy Roll replies, completely unfazed.

Mydei wants to believe this person. He really does. But almost everything they say feels painfully staged.

“Cut the crap. You made sure everyone around us heard it. Do I know you?” He crosses his arms, restraining himself from yanking the chimera's head off its shoulders.

Gummy Roll lets out a dry, humorless laugh.

“Not really. I just recognize a hopeless situation when I see one.” It brings its paws towards the headpiece and lifts it off its shoulders, revealing a mop of sweaty pink hair and a pair of blood-red irises. “After all, I’m pretty much in the same boat.”

She isn’t anyone Mydei recognizes. She simply sets the plush head on the table beside her and combs her damp pink strands away from her face.

“You keep glancing at that nerd even without realizing it. I do the same thing myself—with my dear sister, March,” she explains nonchalantly.

Mydei feels suddenly called out, a chill running down his spine. He didn’t know he was being that obvious. *If she noticed, maybe Phainon saw it too*? It should be hard to tell where a mascot is looking, but still… this girl nailed it. Mydei tries to play it off.

“What kind of look do you give your sister?”

The pink-haired girl offers him a faint smile in the mirror.

“A hopeless situation, indeed. I’m Evernight, by the way.”



It's the final minutes of their first day as mascots, and Mydei almost doesn't want to come back for the remaining Sundays. After such an exhausting routine—even putting aside the whole ordeal with Phainon and Evernight—he just wants to collapse into bed and not get up for an entire day. The mere thought of having to go to school tomorrow is already draining.

The sun is setting on the horizon, painting the park in shades of orange. Most guests have already left; the few who remain are taking their last shots at the game booths or buying souvenirs on their way out. Sensing there's not much else for Fig Stew to do, Mydei heads back toward the staff quarters to finally change out of the costume, which now clings to every inch of his sweaty skin.

As he passes the game booths, a sight catches his attention. On a bench near the plaza fountain, a familiar head of moonlight-colored hair is sitting alone. Mydei stops in his tracks. Cyrene is nowhere to be seen, and Phainon looks utterly dejected as he sighs at his phone screen, his shoulders slumped.

A knot tightens in Mydei's stomach at the sight.

The look doesn't suit his handsome features. It almost looks like he's been dumped—which is inconceivable to Mydei.

One part of his mind tells him to ignore it and keep walking toward the staff quarters. But the more insistent part—the part that still hopes—wants to approach Phainon and wipe that look off his face.

Normally, he would shut down that train of thought as soon as it emerged. It's not his place to meddle in the guy's love life, even if he's had a crush on him for two years. And yet…

He isn't really "Mydei" in Phainon's eyes today, is he? Clad in plush armor, he's seen only as Fig Stew. And as a mascot, it's his job to make the guests happy.

Before he knows it, Mydei is already heading toward Phainon. He has no idea what he's supposed to do, but his feet are moving faster than his thoughts.

When a shadow falls over him, Phainon notices a pair of fluffy paws standing before him. He lifts his gaze from his phone screen to the tall orange chimera.

"Fig Stew?" he mutters, more to himself than anyone, clearly bewildered. "Is… everything okay?"

*That's what I want to ask you*, Mydei thinks. But he can't say it—not without risking being recognized. So all he does is nod with the round chimera head, which only deepens Phainon's confusion.

Mydei can't speak, so he has to communicate through actions. The only idea that comes to

mind is inside his pouch.

Phainon watches as he fumbles with the accessory, struggling visibly due to the costume's plush, chubby fingers. When Fig Stew presents him a single chimera-printed band-aid, his blue eyes widen.

“Is this for me?” he asks. Again, Fig Stew nods. A little hesitantly, Phainon takes the item and examines it. “Do you… think I might be hurt?”

It’s a rather strange experience, having to communicate without words, but so far it seems to be working. Phainon understands what he’s trying to say. Mydei nods once more in silence.

Phainon’s bewildered expression softens into something more thoughtful as he studies the mascot.

“I’m not hurt… at least, not physically. But I get the feeling you might already know that.”

Mydei wants to roll his eyes, but of course, Phainon can’t see.

“Why don’t you take a seat? It must be tiring, working in the park all day,” Phainon suggests, and part of Mydei wants to comply. He is tired, even though he knows he shouldn’t indulge in the guy’s company for too long and risk his disguise.

Besides, listening in on someone’s private life in secret when you actually know them is, at best, unethical. If Phainon ever found out, it could end what little relationship they have as classmates.

Well. It’s not like Phainon actually cared about what he thinks, anyway. The guy has been unreachable for Mydei ever since day one.

He’s already stepped into this awkward situation—backing out now would probably seem even weirder.

Mydei gathers the costume’s tail and holds it to the side as he takes a spot at a safe distance. Phainon offers a small smile; the earlier melancholy seems to have vanished.

“Thanks for being so attentive. That’s the second time today you've helped me.”

*Oh, right. The bathroom thing.*

Mydei lets out a silent sigh and gives a small shrug.

“Look, this might sound a little strange… but could you hear me out for a moment?” Phainon asks, his tone hopeful.

Mydei supposes he signed himself to it. He gives a short nod. Phainon fidgets with the bandage between his fingers.

“I wanted today to be special.” He pauses, his shoulders dropping slightly. “There’s someone I’ve wanted to ask out for a long time.”

*Oh, by Nikador balls.* Mydei was really going to have to sit here and listen to Phainon gush about his undying crush on Cyrene, wasn’t he? He clenches his fists inside the costume, a wave of discomfort washing over him.

“…The thing is, I’m scared they might not be interested in me like that. So I always chicken out at the last second.”

*For fucks sake. They’re already together at school every single day—what more proof does he need? Does he want her to bring him a bouquet and a wedding ring?* If his tail were real, he would be batting it in irritation. Mydei bites back a frustrated sound and lets the guy have his monologue.

“Sorry, I must sound pretty pathetic, huh?” Phainon tries to shrug it off, though the earnestness from before still lingers in his voice. “Anyway, I thought inviting them to the park might be a good idea. They’re a huge fan of *The Awoo Firm*. Fig Stew is their favorite.”

Huh. Mydei blinks as he absorbs the information. Not once had it crossed his mind that Cyrene’s favorite would be Fig Stew. She seemed more like the type to prefer Cyrup, the cutesy, romantic chimera. Besides, she hadn’t acted all that enthusiastic when she and Phainon were near him at the Dromases' ranch earlier.

“So… I was wondering. Could I take a picture with you? Maybe I could use it as a way to… You know, build up the courage to confess.”

What the hell. He didn’t need a prop to confess to her—was he an idiot? Mydei has the sudden urge to flick Phainon’s forehead, but not only is it against park rules, it’s also impossible to control his fingers that precisely inside the costume.

The only thing he can do is nod again and hold his breath as Phainon pulls out his phone and comes closer, standing shoulder to shoulder with him on the bench. Even inside the thick fabric of the costume, Mydei catches a familiar hint of vanilla—a scent that brings back memories from two years ago. It makes him want to lean into it, but he refrains. He’s Fig Stew right now, and he’s taking a photo with a guest.

An infuriatingly handsome guest.

“Say cheese!” Phainon chirps, snapping a selfie with them both on the screen while flashing a peace sign. He angles the phone to show the picture to Mydei. “What do you think?”

What Mydei thinks is that this might be the only photo they will ever take together, and the realization stings. Phainon may be oblivious to what is actually inside Fig Stew’s costume, but all Mydei sees is a bright-eyed teenager next to a park mascot. Though Phainon’s smile is radiant, Fig Stew’s stitched happy face only adds to its misery.

Evernight’s words echo in the back of his mind. *A hopeless situation, indeed.*

“I know you can’t talk, so I’ll take that as an approval.” Phainon straightens up.

He tucks his phone in his back pocket, and as he does, he realizes something is there.

“Oh, right. Did I tell you? I won a game at one of the park’s booths. They gave me a monthly pass as a prize. I didn’t even know those existed,” he says. Mydei frowns, lost on why he was being told that.

“I’ll do my best to ask this person out. And I’ll bring them over to meet you properly. It’s a promise, friend!”

*Nikador, have mercy on me.*



When Mydei arrives home, it's already evening. After greeting his mother, he heads straight to his room and drops his bag at the foot of the bed. The park had employee showers where they could wash up after getting out of costume. His suit would be cleaned and stored there for the week.

Before going downstairs to join his mother for dinner, he reaches for his phone, which had stayed securely tucked away in his bag the entire day. The last time Mydei checked it was a few minutes before arriving at the park in the morning.

As he unlocks the screen, a series of notifications catches him by surprise.

**Phainon:** Hey, Mydei! How are you doing?

The first message was sent at ten in the morning. Mydei frowns. It is rare for Phainon to message him, unless it's something regarding school. His eyes drift down the chat.

*—this message has been deleted—*

At least three messages have been deleted within the span of an hour Maybe Phainon was reaching out about something and got it solved before Mydei could reply? That seems the most likely explanation. He met the guy after lunch in the park, so perhaps Phainon was busy with something else in the morning.

Still, curiosity gnaws at his core. He wants to ask what that was about, but then he would probably need an excuse for why he wasn't available earlier. Gripping his phone a little tighter, he scrolls down. The next message is from 5:43 p.m.

**Phainon:** I've made a new friend today. Aren't they cute?

*[photo attachment]*

It is the same photo Mydei took with him as Fig Stew. Why the hell was he sending it to him instead of Cyrene? Mydei wants to delete the photo—it wasn't meant for him. Yet the longer he stares at Phainon's cheerful expression towards the camera, the more a wave of butterflies swirls in his stomach.

No one needs to know he has it saved, right?

After downloading it, he pauses. What can he even say when he's the one in the costume? So he defaults to their usual dynamic.

**Mydei:** Are you a baby? Taking photos with a children's mascot like that.

Mydei almost startles at how quickly he receives a reply.

**Phainon:** No need to be mean. Just thought they reminded me of you.

Mydei freezes. He can't be suggesting that he knew who Fig Stew was, right? With trembling fingers, he reaches for the keyboard.

**Mydei:** What do you mean?

This time, Phainon takes a little longer to respond.

**Phainon:** Aren't you both Kremnoan?

"*HKS*," Mydei curses, though it carries a veil of relief within. There isn't much else to worry about when the guy is this dense.

**Mydei:** Cool.

**Phainon:** Wow, such a reaction. Careful not to fall asleep.

**Mydei:** It's hard to stay awake when you're the one talking.

**Phainon:** Oh, really? That explains what happened during our math lessons…

Fuck, won't he ever forget that? Heat crawls to his face as he recalls those from two years ago. Mydei is too damn tired to think of a way to change the topic, so he texts saying that he needs to go have dinner and leaves the phone on his bed for his own sanity's sake.

When he comes back, only a single message waits for him: "*See you tomorrow :)*"

Chapter End Notes

How's everyone's 2026 going so far? I already miss Amphoreus so much I couldn't even bring myself to play 3.8 yet :´)

I suck at commedy, so this may end up more angsty than what actually is. I hope you can still have fun.

This time I'm splitting it into chapters for my own sanity regarding formatting. It should not be very long, most of it is already written out as a safeguard that I'll not drop it in the middle lmao.

I do have a smut scene planned for later chapters, but I'm still on the fence about including it. We'll see how it goes!

As always, I appreciate every kudo and comment. Thank you very much for reading it!

See you soon ~

# Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Two years ago, under the cherry blossom trees... A warm feeling flourishes between two young students.

Chapter Notes

No warnings for this chapter.

First chapter was a really short introduction, so I bring this as a treat. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

*Month of Cultivation, 2 years ago*

When Mydei moved to Okhema with his mother, he didn't expect a warm welcome at all. Okhemans and Kremnoans were always treated like wine and water—two things that don't mix well together. What consoled him at the time was knowing it was only temporary, until he finished high school and returned to Kremnos.

So he spends the first days of school ignoring the pointed looks he gets wherever he goes. Okhemans may as well believe that Kremnoans eat their own children, and honestly, it's not his place to change that.

After all, Mydei is rather used to being alone, and he can still message his friends at Kremnos if he feels lonely.

That's why he finds himself annoyed when someone approaches him out of obligation.

It's lunch break, and as he gathers his belongings, a silver-haired student wearing glasses and a sympathetic grin stops at his desk.

"Hello. You must be Mydeimos, right? I'm Phainon Khaslana. Nice to meet you." The boy extends a hand toward him, and Mydei scoffs. Such a practiced act. As expected from the class rep. He waves the gesture off dismissively.

"No need to force yourself. Talking to me won't earn you any Good Samaritan points." Mydei knows he's being a bit harsh, but he can't bring himself to care.

Phainon Khaslana is practically worshipped at the school. Everyone looks up to him like he's some kind of saint, and it's so fucking weird to Mydei. On top of his good looks, the boy is always in pristine condition—uniform without a single wrinkle and smiles carefully measured. He's the top student in their class, and all the teachers adore him. In other words, a total nerd.

A picture too perfect to be real.

The most authentic detail about Phainon, at least to Mydei, is the out-of-place sun tattoo on his neck, usually hidden partially beneath the neat uniform. It can be seen better in PE class, which has Mydei wondering why a boy so worried about appearances would get ink on such a place.

"I was just being polite. You'll scare everyone off with that attitude." Phainon's tone is patient yet hollow, though his eyelids narrow slightly. Mydei rolls his eyes.

"Everyone is already scared of me. I'd prefer you to join them." He walks past the stiff boy without even glancing back, already heading toward the hallway. Mydei is not wasting his break with someone who's just talking to him for appearances' sake.

If he had looked back, though, he would have seen the moonlight-haired student crouched beside his desk, picking up a small item Mydei had dropped in his hurry. Phainon holds it curiously, turning it over in his palm. He can't help but wonder why someone so intimidating would carry around a cute orange chimera phone charm.



It only takes the first math exam since arriving in Okhema for Mydei to be summoned to the teacher's office.

The words "*disappointing*" and "*pitiable*" are thrown around repeatedly by Mr. Ratio as Mydei silently listens to the man dissecting every single mistake on his exam. And boy, there are plenty.

The truth is, math has been a lost cause for Mydei ever since they started mixing letters with numbers. He barely scraped through elementary school, and now it comes to bite his ass again without mercy.

"I will assign you tutoring classes," comes the verdict, and Mydei wants to roll his eyes. He refrains, knowing Mr. Ratio would not hesitate to give him an earful for it.

But which student would be willing to teach him math? Most are either intimidated by him or simply don't wanna mingle with a Kremnoan more than necessary.

The answer shouldn't surprise him, yet it does.

As if Mr. Ratio has calculated the timing perfectly, a knock sounds at the door. The teacher calls for them to enter.

"Excuse me… You wanted to see me, Mr. Ratio?" Phainon Khaslana opens the office door, poking his head inside. His blue eyes widen as they land on Mydei, standing cross-armed beside the teacher's desk.

"Yes. Khaslana, you will be tutoring Mydeimos in math this semester. He desperately needs it."

What a jab. Well, it isn't a lie—but did it have to be Phainon? Mydei grits his teeth but remains silent.

Phainon takes the cue step fully into the room, scratching the back of his head. His gaze flickers between Mydei and the teacher.

"Oh… sure," is all he says.

Mr. Ratio assigns them a study room in the library twice a week, until the next exam period where they will evaluate Mydei's progress.

The first tutoring session takes place that very same day, after classes.

Mydei has already taken a seat and is fiddling with his phone when Phainon arrives a few minutes later.

“Hey.” Phainon greets, and Mydei only nods without giving him a second glance. He just wants to get it over with and head home.

To his surprise, Phainon doesn’t sit across from him. Instead, he takes the seat right beside him and drops his bag on the table.

“Mr. Ratio showed me your test,” Phainon says. “Didn’t know someone could do that badly at once.”

“Math sucks,” Mydei snarls. Out of respect, he puts his phone away as Phainon takes out his notebook and pen.

“It sounds more like you suck at math.” Phainon points out.

“Whatever. It’s not like those calcs are gonna be useful outside school.” Mydei shrugs.

Phainon’s lips curve upward slightly.

“No way. Tell me anything you like, and I’ll prove math has some use in it.” Phainon challenges, sounding confident.

Mydei eyes him skeptically.

“Cooking.”

The look on Phainon’s face is almost comical.

“You like to cook?”

“Is that a problem?” Mydei crosses his arms, waiting for any snarky comment.

Phainon opens his mouth but hesitates. At the last moment, he seems to change his mind, adjusting his glasses.

“No. But cooking and math are closely linked. Any recipe has measures and portions you must follow. There are also timers, temperatures, and scales.”

“None of those use awkward formulas, though,” Mydei counters, unimpressed.

“Maybe not, but that was not the point. Math is present in every aspect of our lives, whether you like it or not.” Phainon concludes.

“Sounds like you enjoy way too much,” Mydei shoots back.

Phainon scratches the back of his head, a nervous habit by now.

“Well, my goal is to become an engineer, so… maybe you’re right.”

Huh. So nerd boy does have his own personal dreams. Mydei shifts in his seat.

“Are you used to tutoring, then? Spreading the gospel of math and all that.” Mydei asks, propping his chin on his hand.

Phainon chuckles at the remark.

“Not really. It’s the first time Mr. Ratio has asked me. Guess he’s really worried about you.” He replies.

Mydei isn’t ashamed of being bad at the subject, but the thought of Mr. Ratio worrying about it is kind of amusing. The man is known for being rather stoic, after all.

“I doubt you can make me learn anything, though,” Mydei scoffs. He’s already bored out of his mind.

Phainon studies him for a brief moment, twisting a pen between his fingers.

“If you’re so sure, why don’t we make a bet?”

Now that gets Mydei’s attention. He perks up.

“What are the terms?”

“I bet that by the end of our tutoring sessions, you’ll score above 80% on Mr. Ratio’s next exam.”

That’s a wildly optimistic take when Mydei barely managed 20%. Nerd boy must be really confident in his teaching skills. It sounds almost too easy a win for Mydei.

“And what do you offer if I win?” Mydei asks, a skeptical edge to his voice.

Phainon thinks for a moment.

“I’ll do your math homework for a month. And if I win…” He smiles brightly. “I want you to cook lunch for me for a week.”

Given that they have math homework twice a week, and there are five school days for lunch, the deal seems fair enough.

“Deal.”

“I trust you will not sabotage your own test. Right?” Phainon asks, scratching his chin.

“I honor my word. If I actually learn how to solve it, I’ll solve it,” Mydei says, a smirk playing on his lips. “That makes the responsibility all yours, Mr. Tutor.”

Phainon averts his gaze, looking slightly flustered as he turns his attention to organizing his notes.

“Okay… let’s start, then.”

As Phainon begins reviewing the topics from Mr. Ratio's class, Mydei has to admit—the guy is good. His explanations are clear and concise, and whenever Mydei makes a mistake, he patiently walks him through the correct steps until he’s sure Mydei understands.

Maybe it’s Phainon’s genuine enthusiasm for the subject, but soon enough, Mydei finds himself settling into a comfortable rhythm. He doesn’t say it out loud, of course, but every time Phainon leans in a little closer to check his exercises, a fluttery feeling stirs in his stomach.

There’s no way he’s losing that bet.

… Right?



As the weeks go by, the next exam period draws nearer. Mydei continues to be tutored by Phainon, and the model student never hides his pride in their progress. Each word of praise for a correct answer makes Mydei a little self-conscious, leaving him worried about whether he will truly remember everything when the exam day arrives.

Lately, however, Mydei has found himself focusing more on the tutor than the subject. Phainon still sits unnecessarily close, leaning over his shoulder and letting their hands almost brush whenever he points out a mistake.

Phainon's scent lingers in the small room—a soft, vanilla trace that Mydei still catches on his own clothes long after they've parted. He may have grown attached to it, as the memory of its owner keeps drawing him back to their private hours in the library.

Phainon has also started bringing snacks, insisting it's no good to study on an empty stomach. He has tried nearly every flavor in the vending machine until finally discovering Mydei's favorite—the pomegranate one. From then on, he pampers the Kremnoan with it whenever Mydei scores at least 60% on their mock exams. It's the bare minimum to avoid failing, and still a long way from the 80% Phainon's bet on, but already a significant improvement.

"You did well today, Mydei! Here," Phainon says, handing him the flavored candy.

Mydei accepts it proudly and takes a bite. Phainon watches him with a soft, unreadable smile.

"What?" Mydei asks, pausing mid-chew.

Phainon tilts his head slightly, his tone gentle.

"Next tutoring will be our last." A muted emotion flickers in the depths of his blue eyes, leaving Mydei searching for its meaning. "I'm sure you'll do great on the exam."

Somehow, it almost sounds like a farewell. After all, they would have no reason to meet here anymore if Mydei truly overcame his struggles with math. He should feel relieved, but a sense of dread quickly floods his thoughts.

If he does well, there will be no more tutoring sessions. The small, cozy moments he's been sharing with Phainon would be gone. Whoever wins the bet claims their prize, and then… they'll return to being the model student and the intimidating outsider—two opposites in everyone's eyes.

Before he knows it, he's grimacing.

"Mydei?" Phainon calls, and he nods absentmindedly.

"Yeah," Mydei replies to the earlier statement.

There's a beat of silence, each of them lost in their own thoughts. Phainon moves first, rustling through his bag.

Mydei's gaze shifts curiously toward it. His eyes widen when a familiar item is pulled out.

"The day we met, you dropped this after brushing me off," Phainon says, holding up the small Fig Stew charm Mydei had been certain he had lost weeks ago. "I wanted to give it back, but you're not easy to approach outside class."

Mydei accepts the charm in awe. It's a limited-time exclusive merch—he had stood in line for hours just to buy it. He had spent the last few weeks mourning its loss, convinced he'd dropped it on the way home. It's still in pristine condition, a sign that Phainon had kept it safe with care.

"Why only give it back now? We've been having lessons for quite a while," Mydei asks, bewildered.

Phainon's smile carries a trace of guilt.

"I… wanted to keep an excuse to talk to you even after the tutoring ended," he admits. "It's silly, I know. I was being selfish."

Warmth blooms in Mydei's chest, spreading quickly. It is a silly excuse, indeed, but knowing Phainon has been thinking about what would become of them after the tutoring leaves him feeling giddy. It's true that, in the beginning, he wanted nothing to do with the boy. However, after spending this much time with him, something has changed.

Mydei hasn't stopped to think about what, exactly, has changed. All he knows is that the more time he spends around Phainon, the less he wants to go home.

A lump forms in his throat as the realization hits.

He has a crush on Phainon, doesn't he?

"T…Thanks," Mydei replies awkwardly, clutching the charm in his closed palm with a little too much force.

"Is this character from a cartoon? It's pretty cute," Phainon asks. If he notices Mydei's sudden out-of-orbit state, he doesn't comment on it.

"It's Fig Stew from *The Awoo Firm*," Mydei says.

Phainon seems intrigued.

"Oh, I've heard about that one. Some of my friends love it. Must be really good if even you like it." There's a tentative hint of teasing in his tone, but Mydei simply shrugs it off.

“It is. You should watch it.”

“Only if you watch it with me.”

Mydei hopes he isn’t blushing. His face feels way too hot. That invitation is… not doing him any good. Phainon’s eyes look like little stars twinkling in the room’s light as the boy stares expectantly at him.

By Nikador, he’s lost it.

Averting his gaze, he clears his throat.

“Yeah, sure.”

Mydei will worry about the details later. Right now, all he can think about is going home with Phainon and spending the evening watching his favorite cartoon with him. Whatever might happen beyond that, he slams a stop sign in the back of his mind to keep his dignity intact.

“It’s settled, then! Give me your number so we can arrange a day for it,” Phainon chirps enthusiastically.

They exchange numbers, and Mydei feels his heart leaping against his ribcage. He’s painfully aware of his own feelings, and although Phainon does seem to enjoy his company, it’s by no means a green light for anything more.

As they part, Mydei fastens the charm back onto his phone, brushing it lightly with his fingers. Fig Stew has been lucky, spending all those days at Phainon’s side. Mydei almost wishes the charm could speak, to reveal what it had witnessed. What does Phainon truly think of him? Could he ever let these feelings be known?

Mydei wishes he could.



It’s the day before their final lesson when everything comes crashing down.

Mydei and Phainon have been exchanging messages—idle talk about their routines and hobbies, mostly. Then Phainon invites him to have lunch with his friends. Mydei doesn’t know any of them, but he supposes it will not be that bad if they’re not afraid of Kremnos' reputation like Phainon.

Phainon has left class early, summoned by one of the teachers. Mydei makes his way to the school gardens, where Phainon said everyone usually gathers.

Surprisingly, the group consists only of girls. He recognizes Castorice from their class —a shy girl who usually sits in the back. Spotting him, a pink-haired girl with ponytails waves enthusiastically.

“Oh, hello! You must be Mydeimos,” she chirps. “I’m Hyacine. Nice to meet you!”

“Just Mydei is fine,” he says, greeting the group.

“Name’s Cipher. And you must know Cas, right?” A gray-haired girl says, nudging Castorice playfully. Castorice blushes and partially hides behind her notebook.

“U-uh, hi, Mydei…” she murmurs.

Mydei almost feels bad for her. He settles onto the grass, the group forming a circle as they resume their lunch.

“Phai told us a lot about you! We’re glad to hear he made a new friend,” Hyacine says cheerfully.

“Sure, friend…” Cipher snorts, and Castorice immediately brings a hand to her mouth.

Mydei arches an eyebrow, uncertain of what that means.

“We heard you like *The Awoo Firm*! Cas and I love the cartoon too,” Hyacine continues. She pulls out her phone, showing off a Krenabis charm—the same edition as Mydei’s own Fig Stew.

That sparks a lively banter about their favorite episodes and chimeras. The only one without a charm is Cipher, who chose to sell her Master Cat-Thief. The price had skyrocketed after it sold out, and she preferred the profit over keeping it.

“It paid for my driver’s license. No regrets,” she sneers.

“Poor Master Cat-Thief…” Castorice laments, clutching her Butterfly Cake charm.

Mydei finds the group pleasant to be around. He was initially worried about being out of place, but all the girls warmed up to him rather quickly as if he belonged there.

“Where’s our golden boy, by the way? Kind of surprising for him to be this late,” Cipher asks between bites of her tuna sandwich.

“Phai said Rene is coming back today. They’re probably dealing with transfer papers in the principal’s office.” Hyacine explains.

“Oh, really? Thought she would be spending more time at Charmony’s High.” Cipher muses.

“It’s way too expensive—even with a scholarship,” Castorice replies.

Mydei doesn’t know who they’re talking about, so he remains silent as he eats.

“Oh, they’re here,” Cipher announces, glancing past Mydei’s shoulder. The Kremnoan turns his head toward the direction of a very familiar mop of moonlight-colored hair.

And suddenly, something in his stomach drops.

Beside Phainon walks a pink-haired girl with small elf ears. She’s the very picture of feminine grace and delicacy—manicured nails, a ribbon tying her ponytail, and light makeup that makes her orchid-colored eyes glimmer like stars. Normally, her appearance wouldn’t have caught Mydei’s attention—if not for the way her hand rests around Phainon’s arm, as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

They walk together, radiating happiness. When the girl's eyes find the group, a smile graces her lips, and she rises on the tip of her toes to whisper a secret into Phainon’s ear. Mydei is almost certain she glances at him in particular, but it’s the faint blush blooming on Phainon’s cheeks that makes his heart clench painfully in his chest.

From every angle, they look like one of those perfect couples straight out of a TV drama.

“Hi guys! Missed me?” The girl sings as they approach the group. She untangles herself from Phainon, bowing down to give Hyacine, Castorice, and Cipher a hug.

“Took you long enough, Peach. Golden boy was miserable without his childhood friend around,” Cipher teases.

“I was not,” Phainon protests, settling down beside Mydei on the grass. Even though he’s physically close, Mydei feels there’s now an immense gap between them.

“Don’t I know it. Phai still has a phone, and my ears haven’t been spared,” the girl sighs dramatically, earning a pout from Phainon. She then turns to Mydei. “Hey! You must be Mydeimos. I’m Cyrene—it’s a pleasure!”

Mydei takes her hand. It’s so small compared to his, a delicate and soft thing he can easily

imagine fitting perfectly in Phainon's. Up close, he catches her peachy scent—syrupy and cloying enough to make his stomach churn.

"Hi." he says, a little out of it.

Cyrene doesn't seem bothered as she continues talking about her time as a temporary student at Charmony High. It was a famous and notoriously strict school. At some point, Mydei tunes out, no longer interested. He's lost his appetite and just wants to get back to class.

"Are you alright?" Phainon asks eventually in a volume only they both can hear, and Mydei has to fight the urge to grit his teeth.

"I'm fine."

It may have come out a little too harsh, because it's the last thing Phainon says to him before they part ways.

Well, just his luck. His crush has a beautiful, perfect childhood friend who clings to him as if she owns him —and perhaps she does, judging by how freely Phainon lets her do as she pleases, holding on to her like she's something precious.

The only thing consoling him is that at least he discovered it before making a fool out of himself in front of Phainon.

So all he needs to do is swallow those feelings, right? Eventually, the jealousy will fade, and he'll move on soon enough. To help with that, he'll put some much-needed distance between himself and Phainon once the tutoring ends.



Mydei can't say he slept well that night. He keeps replaying the lunch scene in his head, leaving him feeling bitter and cold. As a nail in the coffin, Cyrene has been transferred to their classroom. From now on, he's doomed to watch her and Phainon grow all touchy with each other every damned day.

It's not difficult to picture, really: two very good-looking childhood friends, growing together and eventually falling in love. A perfect, cliché romantic story.

The final day of tutoring with Phainon arrives. It's spring, and the cherry trees in full bloom only sour Mydei's mood further. The color alone is enough to remind him of a certain pink-haired girl.

Mydei lets out a heavy sigh. He's too exhausted for tutoring. He spent most of the night tossing and turning, replaying the previous day over and over in his mind. He hadn't even replied to any of Phainon's texts.

That must be why Phainon seems hesitant when he arrives—like he's dealing with a large, dangerous feline.

"So… last day, huh?" Phainon says, trying to lighten the mood as he takes out his notes. Mydei is still staring out of the window, his face resting in his hand.

"Mm," he grunts.

"You look tired… Do you want to call it off?" Phainon asks, uncertain.

"Let's just get it over with," Mydei says, stifling a yawn. He leans back against the chair and turns to face Phainon. Somehow, the model student looks stupidly good today.

"Okay… then, about that last formula…" Phainon begins, picking up where they left off and explaining how to solve the exercises.

Mydei tries to pay attention, but his eyelids betray him. Phainon's voice is soothing, and his warm, familiar scent only loosens the tension in Mydei's muscles until he can no longer stay awake. His eyes drift shut, and at last, the tormenting thoughts of jealousy fade into silence.



Phainon's accelerated pulse rings in his ears. He had noticed the dark circles under Mydei's eyes, but since the Kremnoan insisted, he thought it might be better to comply.

He knows Mydei isn't paying attention—the blond keeps leaning forward the longer Phainon talks, his head drooping. Phainon considers shaking him awake, but stops when Mydei's head finally comes to rest on his shoulder.

Kephale above.

Mydei is sleeping on him.

*Mydei* is sleeping on *him*.

The sight is so adorable, Phainon feels he might burst. Mydei's long eyelashes flutter as small cherry petals, carried by the wind, settle on his face.

Phainon's fingers twitch. He wants desperately to brush the petals away and smooth the strands of wild golden hair from Mydei's face. But what if it wakes him?

Mydei's breathing remains slow and steady, and against his better judgment, Phainon lifts his thumb to the boy's cheek, dislodging the petal. He stiffens as Mydei shifts slightly, nuzzling closer against his collarbone.

Phainon's heart races so fast he fears it might stop altogether.

He has done his best not to reveal his feelings until now. After all the subtle things he's been doing—learning about Mydei's favorite show and snacks, insisting on staying in touch outside of tutoring, using that stupid bet as an excuse to taste his cooking, standing far closer than necessary— he was sure that sooner or later Mydei would notice.

The past few weeks have been all about Phainon doing late-night calls to Cyrene, talking about his crush on Mydei and taking her advice. It has become a joke between his friends the way Phainon stares at Mydei with heart-shaped eyes.

Ever since the day they met, Phainon was drawn to the gorgeous Kremnoan boy. Most of the students were intimidated by his appearance—blond hair tipped with crimson, ear piercings, silver chains draped over his pants, tattoos along his body and even on his face—combined with his outsider status and the fear that he might be a delinquent. Phainon, however, thought he was so unbearably hot it made him feel feverish.

The initial dismissal back then had stung a little. Still, Phainon's gaze kept searching for Mydei at school—always alone, always looking like he didn't want to be there. Phainon found himself wanting to change that, even if it was difficult given the close-mindedness of Okhema's people. That was why he waited until he could have a better opportunity to approach Mydei without inviting piercing stares.

He would be forever grateful for Mr. Ratio's idea of tutoring.

The more time he spent with Mydei, the more drawn he felt to him. He had been afraid Mydei wouldn't welcome the tutoring, but the boy had been surprisingly laid-back about it after their bet. It gave Phainon the space to get to know him better, all while a quiet longing bloomed in his chest.

Still, Mydei seemed indifferent to everything Phainon did. The only thing that had truly cracked his stoic demeanor was returning the Fig Stew charm.

So Phainon had thought that maybe—just maybe—things were finally starting to shift in a better direction.

And now, with the boy's warm weight resting against his shoulder, Phainon feels both panicked and elated. He knows it may have been accidental, but still—he wants to indulge in it, if only for a moment.

Leaning back against the cushioned chair, he carefully slips an arm around Mydei's waist and adjusts his posture so the boy can rest more comfortably against his side. Mydei exhales softly, yet remains fast asleep.

Phainon holds him gently, wishing the moment could last forever. He rests his cheek atop Mydei's soft hair, inhaling its faint cinnamon scent, realizing how perfectly they fit together —like matching pieces of a puzzle. It feels right.

Maybe Cyrene was right—he should confess soon. He's been so afraid of driving Mydei away that he's kept silent. Yet now, finally able to be this close to him… Phainon can't help but want more.

He promises himself he will confess during their date to see *The Awoo Firm*. Because, really, isn't that exactly what this feels like?

Smiling, Phainon has another idea. He wants to commit this moment to memory, and maybe someday, he can show it to Mydei, too. He pulls out his phone and frames them in a selfie, snapping the picture and nearly giggling at how cute Mydei looks, tucked into his embrace like that.

Phainon saves the photo, hoping it will be the first of many.

Around twenty minutes pass before Phainon finally senses Mydei stirring awake. He blinks sluggishly, yawning, still unaware of their current position. Phainon can't resist a quiet chuckle.

"Morning', sleepyhead," he says softly.

Mydei's gaze slowly lifts to meet Phainon's. A few beats of silence pass, and then—

Mydei's eyes widen, and in the span of a second, he's out of Phainon's reach. The color drains from his face, his chest heaving like a deer caught in headlights.

…Isn’t that a bit of an overreaction?

“*HKS*, sorry. I…” Mydei mutters flatly, sounding like he’s done something wrong.

Confused, Phainon tries to swallow the upsetting feeling that Mydei might be disgusted by the situation. Coldness seeps into the spot where Mydei had been pressed against him only moments ago.

“It’s alright. You didn’t sleep for too long.” Phainon says with a smile, hoping to calm him down.

It doesn’t work. Mydei averts his gaze, his voice trembling slightly.

“No, it’s not…” He bites his lower lip, frustration edging his tone. “I should get going.”

Phainon blinks.

“Huh? But we still have time…” He doesn’t mean time for tutoring—just time to talk, if Mydei wants to.

Mydei shakes his head, running a hand back through his bangs.

“I don’t feel well. Sorry.” Mydei stands and hurriedly gathers his belongings.

“I can accompany you—”

“*Phainon.*” The tone makes Phainon stiffen. It almost sounds like a plea—but a plea for what? “I’ll be fine. Don’t worry about me.”

Phainon does worry, though. He grimaces, watching the Kremnoan already making way to the door.

“At least text me when you get home. Please?”

Mydei doesn’t look back as he grips the doorknob.

“… Sure.”



After that day, their relationship became only a shadow of what had once been flourishing between them. Mydei knows Phainon is out of reach—he belongs to Cyrene. And he can't trust his own heart when close to the boy, not after even falling asleep to the soothing sound of his voice.

He can't imagine what he would do if they actually ended up watching cartoons together at his home.

So he comes up with an excuse, then another… until eventually, Phainon stops asking. Their messages grow sparse, dwindling down to little more than homework reminders.

They still have lunch together sometimes with the girls. With others around, Mydei feels more grounded. If anyone notices the growing distance between the two of them, no one says a word about it.

He tries to ignore the hurt in Phainon's expression. Sadly, he can't be the friend the model student wants—not when he's hurting too, stuck on the thought of Phainon's crush on his childhood friend.

When Mydei receives his math exam results, Mr. Ratio wears a satisfied look. He had managed to score above 85%. That means Phainon won the bet, and Mydei owes him a week of home-cooked meals.

He wants to follow through. He gave his word.

But wouldn't it be strange to do it in front of the girls… especially Cyrene? It's not like they talk the way they used to anyway, so maybe Phainon has already forgotten about the bet now that his childhood friend is back to keep him company. And yet, part of Mydei wants to show the results to him. Phainon would surely praise him, and Mydei misses the bright smile that always comes with it.

His fingers hover over his phone at the last second before he can send a text, and he curses his own selfishness. He deletes the message. The Fig Stew charm seems to stare back at him in silent judgment, and his heart aches.

Mydei tells himself it will get better someday. But as weeks turn into months, and months bleed into years, he still finds himself longing for the days when Phainon's gaze was only his —even if the boy never felt the same.

Graduation couldn't come soon enough.

Chapter End Notes

Well, so that's what happened two years ago. Don't you love some teenager drama? :´)

Next chapter we'll go back to the present; I'll do my best to get it out until next weekend.

Thank you for every kudo and comment. I read every single one of them and get all fuzzy inside <3

See you!

# Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

The rumor about Fig Stew's curse blows out of hand. Meanwhile, Mydei discovers that Phainon relationship with Cyrene is in a rough spot.

Chapter Notes

Every misunderstanding is crucial to this fic.

:´)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei discovers that news, even unfounded ones, spreads like wildfire.

Apparently, telling a bunch of children something can give rise to the wildest rumors. The story of Fig Stew's curse was blown so far out of proportion that even streamers were talking about it.

"It's for sure an Easter egg! This will be the plot of the next arc." Lilgui, a famous influencer, was determined to convince everyone that it had been created by *The Awoo Team*. With thousands of viewers, it has now reached even the official *The Awoo Firm* forums.

**notrashnogain12:** is this the first time they're writing romance in the Awoo universe???

**nogainnotrash21:** couldn't they pick a cuter chimera for this? Lol Cyrup would fit so well

**Clara●ω●:** How does a chimera even kiss? (•́ ᴗ •̀?)

**Lilgui:** Guys, let's ask the real question: Who the fuck does Fig Stew like?

**RedHerring:** duh, it's obviously Vigethos

**Cloudsknightbeauty:** No way! They're just friends. Fig Stew would be so cute with Butterfly Cake…

**RedHerring:** yeah, because taking three baths together a day and biting your friend affectionately is *totally* not a couple thing

**Cloudsknightbeauty:** You're delusional. Vigethos just likes to annoy Fig Stew.

**RedHerring:** we'll see who's right in due time, pipsqueak ;)

**Lilgui:** … Either way, I'm coming to the park to see it myself. Maybe we can find some clues!

Mydei feels like he lost a brain cell reading all that.

It's still Monday, and he already doesn't want to think about Sunday. What would their manager even say about it? Mydei could simply start talking while dressed as Fig Stew and get this over with. The issue is that due to the growing popularity of the rumor, the chances that he might have his voice recorded are high.

Both he and the girls agreed not to dox themselves to their family and friends. While relatively innocent, the job could easily turn into some uncomfortable situations regarding their private lives. Mydei can't even begin to imagine what his father would say about it.

He massages his forehead. There's no way he's adhering to Evernight's story and only saying *Awoo* until the last Sunday. He needs to think of a way out of it. Maybe Evernight could come up with a new story that solves this curse?

Mydei is so absorbed in his own thoughts that he doesn't notice someone approaching him.

"What's going on in that thick head of yours?"

*Fucking great*, Mydei thinks as he turns to face Phainon. The guy has a curious look towards him, one eyebrow arched.

Over the span of two years, Phainon's features have lost some of their boyish glow. When Mydei moved to Okhema at sixteen, they were about the same height, with Mydei having far more muscle thanks to his athletic life back in Kremnos. Nowadays, however, Phainon is at least a few inches taller, and somewhere along the way he started working out, which did wonders for his physique. No one would ever take him for a nerd if not for the thick dark dark-rimmed glasses that he uses to read.

In conclusion, his crush got even more handsome over time. And Mydei is definitely *not* thirsty when he thinks about how much Phainon can lift these days.

"Personal issues," Mydei answers, not wanting to give away too much.

Phainon's smile falters a bit. He's used to being shut out by now.

"I see."

"What do you want?" Mydei asks impatiently. It's rather unusual for Phainon to seek him

alone during lunchtime.

Phainon fidgets a little, his gaze dropping to his shoes for a moment.

“Yesterday, at the park… I won a free monthly pass.” He clears his throat. “It includes a companion. I know you like the show, so I thought you might want to go this weekend?”

Mydei’s jaw drops. Why was Phainon inviting him so out of the blue?

“Going with *you*?” Mydei asks incredulously.

Phainon winces.

“… Yeah? Is it so strange to invite a friend out?”

He doesn’t sound convinced of his own words.

Mydei wants to argue that yes—specifically when the friend is *him*. They barely talk, just conveniently interacting only through their mutual friends. And when they do talk, it’s usually to pick on one another.

Besides, yesterday he was at the park with Cyrene. It’s literally a perfect opportunity for another date. Something must have happened between them if Phainon’s inviting him instead.

*Are they fighting?* he wonders. Well, he won’t take part in any kind of fight; they can solve it themselves. It’s not like he can go out on the weekend anyway.

“I’m busy this weekend,” Mydei replies nonchalantly.

The dejection that flickers in Phainon’s cerulean irises doesn’t go unnoticed, and it always sends a pang through Mydei’s chest. They’re in the second-floor hallway, and he averts his gaze toward the school courtyard to distract himself—then freezes.

A very familiar girl is sitting on a bench, cross-legged. She has pale pink hair and blood-red irises—Evernight. Was she lying when she said she didn’t know him?
“I suppose you’ll also be busy next weekend?”

Mydei almost forgets Phainon is still there. His tone is a hollow one.

“Yeah. I need to go.” Mydei pockets his phone and turns quickly, already heading for the stairway.

“Mydei—”

“You should invite Cyrene,” Mydei cuts in.

He hopes that will be enough to get Phainon off his back about the park thing. He doesn’t allow himself to look back or to entertain any ideas about going out with Phainon in this

situation.

Mydei reaches the courtyard and scans the area for Evernight. She's still on the same bench, watching a group of students in the distance. He stops hurriedly at her side.

"Hey," he greets a bit too dryly.

Evernight lifts her blood-red irises to him, unfazed. She doesn't look anything close to surprised.

"Hello, Mr. Fig Stew."

Mydei almost jumps out of his skin, glancing around to make sure no one is close enough to hear. Luckily, her voice is very low.

"*HKS*, don't call me that outside of the park," he snarls.

Evernight tilts her head.

"Okay."

Mydei frowns. Something is unsettling about this girl, yet he can't quite put a finger on what it is. She wears a blue ribbon alongside her uniform shirt, meaning she's a year younger than him. That must explain why he never paid attention to her before.

"Did you see what your dumb story turned into?" he asks.

"Ah, yes. It got loud really fast, didn't it?" Evernight chuckles. "People are so gullible."

"That's not the issue. You need to undo this."

"Do I?" She taps a black-nailed finger against her lips, grinning. "I think it can be positive for you."

"*What?*"

"Being a chimera has its advantages. You can do things you normally wouldn't as yourself." She grins wider. "Isn't this a perfect opportunity to create good memories while you can?"

"… I'm not sure I follow," Mydei says, shaking his head.

Evernight stands up, dusting off her uniform.

"Of course you don't." She steps suspiciously closer, her lips nearly brushing his ear as if she's about to whisper a secret. "If you did, you would already have noticed the 'dawn' that watches your every step, big boy. Even now, I fear it's trying to burn me alive."

Her voice tickles Mydei's ear. He lifts a hand to shake the sensation off as Evernight walks

away toward a group of students from the same year as her. One of them is a girl almost identical to her, but with cherry-pink and baby blue-hued eyes, alongside a tall, black-haired guy and a duo of gray-haired students.

*So fucking weird.* Evernight always speaks in riddles. What the hell did she mean by that?



Sunday arrives way too soon in Mydei's opinion. He's still keeping track of the shitstorm surrounding the Fig Stew rumor when Mr. Reca enters the room, demanding to know which one of them started it.

The teenagers can't hide their glances in Evernight's direction. Contrary to their expectations, however, the man takes her hands in his and shakes them enthusiastically.

"We've sold almost fifteen percent more tickets than last week. There are so many visitors interested in that Easter egg! A genius move, my dear!"

"Isn't that false advertising, though? This has nothing to do with the cartoon," Cipher asks from her chair, mildly amused.

"*The Awoo Team* has been following the online feedback. They seem to be studying the possibility of adapting it into an animated special."

*What the fuck.* This madness really reached the cartoon's creator?

"That means…" Hyacine's voice trails off as everyone in the room turns to stare at Mydei.

Their manager beams as he claps his hands together.

"Mr. Fig Stew will have to play along, yes!"

Mydei scowls. By Nikador, he did not sign up for this. He crosses his arms defensively.

"I can stay silent, but I'm *not* Awooing."

"That's good enough." The man rests a hand on his chin. "However, we'll need a love interest for Fig Stew to conclude the curse."

"Shouldn't this be decided by the writers? We don't have the entire cast as mascots…" Castorice interjects, clearly worried about where this is heading.

"This indeed poses a problem. I'll be in touch with the team, and we might come up with a solution," He ushers the group toward their dressing rooms. "Until then, keep the act up!"



The park is indeed more crowded today. After the mascot's show at the main plaza, every chimera is endlessly dragged around to answer questions about the Easter egg. Mydei has to stay in the company of another mascot, since he can't talk at all.

This time, he's with Master Cat-Thief near the roller coaster queue, being interrogated by a very familiar-looking streamer while a group of visitors gathers around them.

"Please give us any hints—we're all dying to know which chimera Fig Stew is interested in!" Lilgui pleads, phone in hand, broadcasting the encounter to her followers.

"I can't tell you that; even I don't know who it is!" Master Cat-Thief puts its paws on its waist, its playful tone erupting. "But I can tell that they've been in love for quite a long time. Years, maybe!"

Mydei pays only half attention as he dutifully hands out chimera-themed balloons to the children around him. It seems like every girl he works with has a lot of creativity.

"I knew it! It's Butterfly Cake!" a brunette girl with twintails standing beside Lilgui chirps. "They've been close friends ever since the underworld arc—it aired years ago!"

*Oh.* Those episodes were fun, Mydei recalls.

"Hmm, good friends they may be… but Fig Stew is way too stubborn to like someone as shy as Butterfly Cake. Just my opinion," Master Cat-Thief adds, shrugging.

The crowd erupts into discussion again. Some of the guests head off to look for Butterfly Cake to question her about it, and Mydei already feels bad for her.

"Damn, they're like hawks. People are really obsessed with this cartoon, huh?" Cipher says once they have a little room to breathe at an off-limits area near the food court.

"It's a passenger thing. The hype will die down eventually." Mydei replies, hoping that will be the case.

Among the girls, Cipher is the only one who isn't particularly interested in the show. She does enjoy watching it with Castorice, but she prefers indulging in the monetary aspect of things. The only reason she took this part-time job is to sell the exclusive merch for thousands of credits later.

"If you say so." Cipher stretches, groaning. Wearing those costumes all afternoon is exhausting. "Hey… wait. Isn't that—?"

She points toward the guests' area, and Mydei follows her gaze. He freezes.

It's Cyrene, without a doubt—but she isn't with Phainon. She's carrying an enormous Mem plushie, her hands linked with a slightly taller, gray-haired girl Mydei barely recognizes from

Evernight's group of friends at school. Cyrene is all smiles, her long hair flowing freely in the breeze as they talk animatedly about something Mydei can't hear.

Mydei's mind races. It's not that unusual for girls to hold hands. Maybe they're just friends. There's no way Cyrene would be dating anyone else instead of Phainon.

…Right?

At that exact moment, a distracted guest bumps into Cyrene. Before she can stumble, the grey-haired girl steadies her, drawing her a little closer, an arm lingering at her waist as they murmur something under their breath. Cyrene laughs softly, leaning in for a little peck on the girl's lips.

Alright.

She *is* dating that girl.

Anger boils in Mydei's core. How could she dump Phainon and already be seeing someone else in the span of a single week? That explains why he'd been so miserable—miserable enough to ask *Mydei*, of all people, out. Thinking it was just a temporary fight, Mydei had even suggested that he invite Cyrene instead.

*Holy shit.* He's an asshole.

Guilt gnaws at him. Maybe he shouldn't have dismissed Phainon so harshly. Phainon might not be interested in him, but he still had every right to be upset about being dumped and seek a distraction.

"What the hell. Cyrene's dating?" Cipher comments. "That explains why she's been so annoyingly happy lately."

The remark only fuels Mydei's rage.

She spent years *happy* beside Phainon, and now she tosses it all away like it meant nothing.

That girl has absolutely no fucking idea how much Mydei wanted to be in her place all this time.

"Hey, dude… you alright? You're giving off a really menacing aura." Cipher observes, taking a small step back.

"I'm fine," he lies.

"Yeah, sure… Careful not to boil inside the costume. I'm not dragging your big-ass corpse back by myself."

Mydei only grunts in response.

They part ways soon after. Most of the preying crowd had dissipated by now, their attention shifting to the park attractions. That leaves Fig Stew to deal with his audience alone,

communicating through gestures.

He tries to avoid trailing after Cyrene. The last thing he wants is to dwell on how messed up the situation is in the middle of his shift. So when he rounds a corner near the teacups and spots the girl and her date heading straight toward him, Mydei performs the fastest, most panicked 180-degree turn of his life.

Unfortunately, there is a person directly behind him.

They collide and fall, with Mydei ending up on top of the person.

Both groan from the impact, and Fig Stew's tiny, cursed field of vision only allows Mydei to register that he's face-planted against what can only be described as an extremely solid chest.

"Ow! Hey—are you okay?"

Mydei freezes. *Can this day get any worse?* He lifts the enormous plush head to meet apologetic cerulean irises.

Of all the scenarios he has imagined himself on top of Phainon—*exclusively* in dreams, and very much against his will—, doing it in broad daylight and in public while wearing a chimera costume was never one of them.

He's very tempted to lie down and let Thanatos take him already.

"Oh. It's you…" Phainon finally seems to process what just happened.

"Is Mr. Fig Stew okay?!" a child from the surrounding crowd asks.

That snaps Mydei out of his stunned state. He scrambles upright and gives an enthusiastic thumbs-up to the onlookers. Relief washes over the kids' faces, while their parents look thoroughly amused. He hopes no one got a picture of the fall—unlikely, but a man can dream.

Phainon is already back on his feet, dusting off his yellow t-shirt. He lifts one elbow with a hiss, inspecting a rather nasty scratch that clearly came from the collision. No band-aid in the world would cover that.

*Great.* Now Mydei is also a physical hazard to his crush.

"What's the rush?" Phainon asks lightly, apparently unbothered as he lowers his arm. "Must've been something scary to have you running off like that."

*If only he knew…*

Wait.

That's when it hits Mydei. Does Phainon even know about Cyrene's new girlfriend?

All Mydei knows is that he was dumped at the park last Sunday. At the time, he hadn't thought much of it, but looking back now… over the past week, he can't really recall seeing

Phainon and Cyrene together at school like usual. She's gone as soon as classes end, and she didn't show up to talk with the girls during lunch.

Even if Phainon did know… wouldn't it still hurt to see them together like this? After all, he'd been sulking alone at the park the last time Mydei saw him. Mydei knows the feeling too well—he's been dealing with it for the past two years. It's not something he would wish upon anyone.

Moreover, he still feels guilty for brushing Phainon off so easily earlier this week. Having a crush on Phainon should not excuse him for being a dick when the other is clearly going through rough times.

"Ew, that mister is bleeding!" A girl passing by squeals, pointing at Phainon's arm.

"Oh—uh, it's fine! It's not that bad," Phainon tries to reassure her.

*Being a chimera has its advantages. You can do things you normally wouldn't as yourself.*

Mydei's body moves before his brain can catch up. As Fig Stew, he grabs Phainon's wrist and yanks him forward—away from the direction he'd seen Cyrene coming from and straight toward the infirmary.

"Whoa, what—?" Phainon stumbles, nearly tripping over his own feet. "You want me to come with you?"

Fig Stew nods feverishly. To emphasize his point, he tightens his grip on Phainon's wrist.

"Okay, okay! No need to dislocate my good arm! I'm coming," Phainon says, quickening his pace and falling into step as Fig Stew marches him off toward wherever the chimera has decided they're going.

Luckily, the infirmary isn't very far from the scene of the incident. When Phainon spots the small building tucked away in a corner, he almost trips.

"Hey, I said I'm fine—"

Mydei stops without warning. Phainon walks straight into his fluffy back with a "*hmph!*".

Fig Stew slowly turns his oversized head to face him. With his free paw, he casually rubs a plush finger against Phainon's scraped elbow, not caring if it would stain the fabric. It's almost the end of his shift anyway.

"*Ow!* Shit," Phainon yelps, jerking his injured arm away.

Mydei's silence speaks volumes. Phainon's cheeks acquire a faint, frustrated blush. He lets out a nervous laugh.

"Okay… guess I can't fool you, huh…"

*Then shut up and come,* is what Mydei wants to say. Still gripping Phainon's wrist, he gives it a small, pointed tug.

Message received. Like a scolded child, Phainon follows Fig Stew toward the infirmary without another word.

Just as Mydei pushes open the glass entrance doors, a figure emerges from the back of the room.

"Fig Stew?"

Mydei doesn't recognize the woman, but from the ID badge clipped to her uniform—which reads Natasha—he can tell she's the nurse in charge. Her red eyes flicker between the duo. "Is either of you injured?" she asks.

Mydei gestures toward his companion, who lifts his elbow a bit timidly. Natasha's expression softens.

"I see," she says, already moving as she grabs a small medical bag and slings it over her shoulder. "I have to attend to an emergency near Aquila's Sky Drop. I'm sorry—could you take care of this for me? There's gauze and antiseptic on the foyer counter."

*Are you serious?* Mydei scowls. He can feel Phainon's uncertain stare burning into the side of his plush head.

"Natasha, where the hell are you? This kid is about to vomit her soul out," a woman's voice crackles from the radio clipped to her bag.

Natasha flashes them an apologetic smile as she mutters another "Sorry" and flies out of the building.

The silence that settles in the room is awkward.

Mydei finally releases Phainon, who immediately starts massaging his wrist.

"For a chimera, you're pretty strong…" he remarks, and Mydei rolls his eyes inside the costume.

As if anyone could actually get hurt being grabbed by Fig Stew's plush exterior.

Almost as if sensing his mood, Phainon chuckles.

"You know, you don't have to do this. I can just apply some antiseptic and go," he offers.

Unfortunately for him, Mydei is far too stubborn to let it slide. He heads to the counter at the back, grabs the necessary supplies, and returns with a clear plan in mind.

He gestures for Phainon to sit in one of the cushioned chairs in the foyer.

After a moment of hesitation, Phainon complies. Mydei kneels in front of him and holds out a paw in a very clear *hand it over* gesture.

“You’re going to do it while wearing a mascot costume?” Phainon asks, surprised. Mydei nods. “Is it really necessary to stay in character the entire time you’re inside the park?”

*Obviously not*, Mydei replies mentally, sneering. However, there’s no way in hell he’s taking off any part of Fig Stew’s costume and risk revealing his identity to Phainon. So all he can do is nod again.

“Alright, then…”

Phainon finally lifts his arm, and Mydei gets to work with visible difficulty.

*HKS, these damn chimera fingers,* he curses silently, ignoring how Phainon is very politely not trying to laugh at his struggle.

After several seconds of wrestling with the antiseptic spray, he manages to get some out. Phainon lets out a small whine as Mydei follows up with cleaning the scratched area with a cotton and makes sure it’s not bleeding anymore. He gets the gauze, wrapping it carefully around his elbow.

It’s far from his best work, but given the circumstances, Mydei decides it’s acceptable.

“Hey, that’s pretty good,” Phainon says, genuinely impressed.

Mydei feels a surge of pride over it.

The mascot straightens up and puts the supplies back where he found them. When he turns around, Phainon is watching him with an oddly curious expression.

“Thank you, friend,” Phainon says, offering an earnest smile. “All of this almost made me forget why I came here today.”

The melancholy seeping into his voice makes Mydei uneasy. He tilts Fig Stew’s oversized head. He couldn’t have come here to look for Cyrene… could he?

After a brief silence, Phainon continues.

“Actually, I came to the park to see you. Care to lend me an ear again, friend?”

*Does he not have anybody else to talk to?* Mydei can’t help thinking. He had the suspicion that sooner or later Phainon would want someone to vent about his latest romantic frustrations. He’d tried with Mydei himself first—and after being brushed off like that… now only “Fig Stew” remains.

The thought is depressing, really.

Still, it’s the least Mydei can do. After all, he’s responsible for both being a dick at school and literally injuring the guy today.

The mascot takes a seat beside him, crossing his paws. He stays silent in an attempt to communicate he's all ears. Mydei fixes his gaze on the opposite wall, decorated with colorful chimera stickers.

A small chuckle comes from his side.

"Like I promised, I tried approaching the person I like this week. It went… awfully bad." Phainon says with a dry laugh. "They told me they already have plans for every weekend this month. A pretty clear rejection, right?"

*That girl wastes no time…* Mydei fights the anger bubbling up in his stomach again. Since Cyrene is already at the park with another person, it makes sense. She probably already had plans lined up with her girlfriend for the weeks ahead.

"You know, it wasn't always like that. We were becoming pretty close until I think I did something that upset them. And they never gave me the chance to fix it. They stopped replying to my texts and started avoiding me. It hurt—a lot." He sighs, running a hand through his bangs. "A friend even started calling me 'sad puppy.'"

Mydei's heart tightens. Phainon's situation is so similar to his that it's almost uncanny. Even if he's talking about someone else, Mydei can hear the hurt woven into every word. If Phainon's feelings were directed to him, he would do everything in his power to make sure the guy never felt like that again.

*What a cruel world.*

"The funny thing is, I already expected the rejection. But…" Phainon's voice drops to a murmur, shoulders recoiling. "For the first time since I met them, I saw them with someone I didn't recognize… a girl from another class."

Wait. So Phainon actually saw Cyrene and her girlfriend during the week? Mydei doesn't have time to process this properly.

"I watched from a distance and… they seemed strangely close. I'd never seen that person act that way with anyone before." He pauses, shoulders dropping. "That's when it all made sense. They'd finally moved on, while I was still holding on to something that never really existed."

It doesn't make sense. Cyrene had seemed genuinely happy with him all this time. How could it have ended like this?

Another moment of silence stretches before Phainon lets out a heavy sigh

"Have you ever had a one-sided crush, Fig Stew?" Phainon asks bitterly, not waiting for an answer. "It's a devastating feeling, really. All the signs telling me to give up have been screaming at me for so long. And yet… it feels like if I stop liking them, I'll be betraying my own heart. I'm an idiot, aren't I?"

*If Phainon is a lost cause, then what does that make me?* Mydei thinks. Listening to his own crush being so devastated over his childhood friend while wearing a mascot costume and being forced to stay silent. It's almost torture by now.

When Phainon turns to him, it almost feels like he's searching Fig Stew's permanent smile for answers.

"Sorry for dumping all of this on you when you can't even talk," Phainon adds quietly. "I just… needed to vent, I guess."

*It's fine,* Mydei tells himself. It's the closest he's ever been to understanding Phainon's feelings, too—even if he can't do anything about them.

"Hey, Fig Stew… your arm." Phainon's voice pulls Mydei back to reality.

He follows the student's gaze and spots a small rip in the costume's fabric. There's still a thick layer of foam beneath it, which explains why Mydei hadn't noticed anything earlier.

"Looks like I wasn't the only one who got hurt," Phainon says softly.

Mydei watches as Phainon reaches into his back pocket. His eyes widen when he recognizes the chimera-printed band-aid Fig Stew gave him a week ago.

Phainon gently takes Fig Stew's "injured" arm, peels off the bandage, and carefully presses it over the tear.

"I kept it as a good luck charm," he admits. "But now… I fear it doesn't have a use anymore."

Phainon's smile is a pitiful thing, though he tries to act cheerful still. There's a clear sign of moisture in his eyes. "I hope it brings you more luck than it did me, friend."

*Please don't look at me like that,* Mydei thinks. *Or I might forget I'm supposed to stay silent —I can't just stand here watching you suffer.*

Mydei's pulse pounds loudly in his ears. Seeing Phainon like this hurts more than he expected. Even now, the boy manages to be so sweet while he's breaking apart on the inside.

*I like you.* The thought echoes. *I like you so much. Why can't it be me?*

He wants to scream. The unfairness of it all burns in his chest. He wants to feel Phainon's hand on his arm without layers of foam and fabric between them. But he can't.

Even if they weren't meant to be, if Phainon never forgets Cyrene… Mydei wants, from the bottom of his heart, to at least comfort him somehow. A task that would prove much harder if he were out of this costume and tangled in their strained relationship.

Phainon isn't looking at *him* right now. Maybe that's enough.

Mydei steels himself. In Phainon's eyes, he is Fig Stew.

And, for once, he allows his feelings to speak for him in the only way he can.

He gently pulls his paw free from Phainon's grasp and wraps him in a hug. The oversized plush head muffles the student's face at first, until Phainon shifts in Fig Stew's arms just enough to breathe.

"*Hmph*—hey… are you consoling me? That's very kind," Phainon lets out a small laugh, a shadow of his usual brightness breaking through the gloom like sunlight after a storm.

The moonlight-haired student accepts the embrace, hands settling against Fig Stew's fuzzy back.

Even with the costume, it's so warm. Can Phainon hear the plummeting rhythm of his heart through those layers of plush? Can he feel when Mydei buries Fig Stew's head on his shoulder, chasing the scent he misses so much? It brings Mydei back to those afternoons in the library—of Phainon's lingering gazes, the closeness they shared that always felt as if it wasn't enough.

If he had allowed himself to close that distance back then… would anything be different now?

He wants to tell Phainon how he makes him feel—to let him know how precious he is, even if Mydei will never be the one he longs for.

Still, he can't. It wouldn't be right to take advantage of Phainon while he's hurting over Cyrene. And if he's officially rejected, Mydei doesn't know how he will deal with it.

Mydei may not be able to confess. But maybe… Maybe Fig Stew could do it for him. No one would ever find out. Not when they're alone like this, and he's sure Phainon never would suspect who's inside the costume. Otherwise, he wouldn't have been hugging him back in the first place.

Fig Stew doesn't know what cowardice means. They're strong-willed, honest, and reliable. Mydei borrows it from the chimera for a moment. His voice drops to barely more than a breath, something that could not be heard if he wasn't buried in Phainon's shoulder. He hopes it doesn't sound like himself.

Hidden behind layers of plush and fur, a sound slips from the depths of Fig Stew's throat, recited as a secret:

"A… Awoo…"

*I like you.*

Phainon stiffens at first, as if he didn't understand where the sound came from. Then, a second later, he relaxes and rests his cheek against Fig Stew's fluffy neck fur as a quiet laugh escapes him, a genuine and warm sound that makes Mydei's heart soar.

"Thank you, Fig Stew," he murmurs. "You're really the best."



Mydei is still thinking about it by the time he gets home. He's so distracted he barely remembers to greet his mother, and once he reaches his bedroom, he collapses face-down onto the bed.

What a rollercoaster of a day.

He still can't believe that he quite literally abducted Phainon and confessed to him through Fig Stew. He's completely lost it.

Just thinking about it makes his face burn.

It shouldn't matter. Phainon will never find out he's Fig Stew.

And yet…

Mydei knows he's been a shit friend to the other due to his selfishness. Phainon was the only one in Okhema who actually welcomed him and even went out of his way to include him in his friend group.

And what did Mydei give in return? Because he couldn't bear watching his crush be happy with someone else, he pushed Phainon away every time the boy reached out.

Now, though, his crush is hurting because of someone else. And surprisingly, it hurts way more than the first scenario.

Phainon doesn't deserve to suffer like that. The bright, cheerful smiles he used to wear suited him so much better. They were what made Mydei's chest flutter whenever they were directed at him.

Mydei doesn't know if he can help mend his heart, but he can at least try to be a better friend during such a fragile moment.

Sighing in his sheets, he wonders. How could he possibly begin to make up for years of stubbornness and cold dismissals?

He turns onto his back, pulling out his phone. Instinctively, he opens the only photo he has with Phainon and stares intently at it like it will give him an answer. To no one's surprise, it only makes him feel even more guilty over everything.

When he's about to give up, the Fig Stew charm hovers into view when he shifts the phone slightly, the tiny character staring back at him as if it knew too much.

A very specific memory resurfaces alongside it—and with it, an idea.

It could be a starting point. After all…

He still had a bet to honor.

Chapter End Notes

Everyone saw that coming, right?
I swear I did not write an entire fic just to have Mydei say awoo. Blame hoyo and the "Mydei turns into Fig Stew" brainworms.

Thank you very much for reading! Your kudos and comments make my day and keeps me motivated <3

Next chapter we'll take a peak at how Phainon is keeping up in all this mess. See you soon ~

# Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

While Mydei is set on amending their strained friendship, Phainon's inner turmoils spiral out of control.

Chapter Notes

We're finally here with some Phainon POV. He overthinks a lot, so be prepared.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Phainon. Are you paying attention?”

It is so rare to hear Principal Tribios use a stern tone that it makes him wince. He finally gazes at her, adjusting his glasses in shame.

“I’m sorry, Ms. Tribios.”

Ms. Tribios wears an empathetic expression as she looks at him. She leans back in her chair, gesturing toward her desk—and the reason he’s here: his exams from last week.

“It’s such a huge drop in your recent grades.” She shakes her head, grimacing. “Tell me, is everything alright? You know you can confide in me.”

*Is everything alright?* Well, that depends. His life has mostly been the same as always. However…

The mere thought of Mydei and that mysterious pink-haired girl being together makes his blood boil.

Jealousy was, until now, something Phainon had only seen from afar in the romcoms Cyrene invited him over to watch. It had always seemed like a silly notion—that someone could be so deeply affected by seeing their love interest close to another person.

That’s why it caught him by surprise how dark the feeling actually was.

In two years, he had been keeping his distance from Mydei. There had been no other choice, since the Kremnoan seemed to have started hating being around him ever since their final

tutoring session. It squished his heart the way Mydei chose to shut him out without ever telling Phainon what he had done to deserve it.

This made him feel guilty over something he had no understanding of.

Still, it was Mydei's right—he had no obligation to explain himself. They were just classmates at best. Even if Phainon wanted more, there was nothing he could do about it.

Eventually, he was able to smile again around his friends. The scar was still there, and Phainon thought it might close with time if he focused on other things. So he doubled down on his studies and even started to hit the gym.

It helped to some extent. He spent less time moping over what he might have done wrong, and convinced himself he was satisfied enough just to maintain some kind of contact with the Kremnoan at school.

It had never bothered him to see Mydei interacting with the girls before, Castorice being the one he talked to the most nowadays. They both were introverts, so it only felt natural. All of the girls knew about Phainon's crush on Mydei, and they supported him whenever he thought about giving up.

"Give him some time," Castorice suggested.

"I'm sure everything will sort itself out eventually," Hyacine reassured him.

"Have you tried getting on your knees and begging for forgiveness, golden boy?" Cipher joked.

In truth, he had tried to reach out and ask for forgiveness. But every single time he did, Mydei vanished from his field of vision in mere seconds.

After two years, no one comments on it anymore. It is almost an unspoken agreement that the situation will never change, no matter what they say.

Two years flew by in that state.

Until one day, with only about six months until graduation, Cyrene invades his room in the middle of the weekend.

"Phai, hear me out!" she chirps, hopping happily.

"Mhm?" Phainon doesn't lift his gaze from his notebook. The exam period is approaching, and he has been studying like there's no tomorrow.

"Look at me, you dummy!" Cyrene spins his chair forcefully, and he tries to hide his annoyance at the enormous pen stroke he ends up dragging across his notes.

"*What?*"

"*Look!*"

Cyrene practically shoves the pamphlet into his face. He takes it from her, frowning.

"Chimera Park Grand Opening?" he reads aloud.

Why, in Kephale's name, is she showing this to him?

"Yup!" she puts her hands behind her back cheerfully. "You know who loves *The Awoo Firm*, right?"

*Oh. Of course is about that.*

"I'm not inviting him, Rene."

"Phai…" She wilts a little.

Of all his friends, Cyrene has been the only one who consistently insisted that he try to confess to Mydei all this time, without success.

"I already told you he doesn't like me. There's no way he's going to accept."

"Phai… you've been assuming that without any proof for *years*!" she whines.

"I do *have* proof, Rene."

The way Mydei looked at him that day at the library still hurts. It was easier to assume he simply wasn't into guys, and that the situation had thrown any chance of friendship right out the window.

Cyrene puffs out her cheeks, annoyed by his endless stubbornness.

"No, you don't! Phai… are you really going to let this drag out until graduation?"

"Mydei will probably be glad to never see me again." Phainon shrugs.

"But what about you? Are you really okay with never seeing him again?"

This has Phainon thinking.

Would he?

Until now, he has managed to endure being nothing more than Mydei's classmate. Somehow, stealing glances at him has become routine. It is almost a vice by now, and seeing the ultra-rare smiles Mydei shows around the girls still has his chest squeezing with affection.

On weekends, when he cannot see his face, he always ends up opening that photo Phainon

took of them together at the library.

And then he spends the day imagining how things might have been if Mydei had ever returned his feelings.

“I… don’t know,” Phainon admits, nervously adjusting his glasses.

“I think you know very well, sir!” Cyrene says. Her voice softens. “Instead of locking yourself in your bedroom the rest of the summer like the sad puppy you are… why don’t you give yourself a chance to be happy, Phai? Who knows? It could turn into a very romantic story.”

“It could also end in irreparable heartbreak,” he points out.

Cyrene stomps her foot.

“We are already there! Soon there won’t be a heart left to feel anything,”

That earns a small laugh from him. Cyrene has always worried far too much about him.

Regardless, she is right. What is there to lose if Mydei already despises him? Perhaps he has simply been too afraid of being officially rejected while still having to attend the same school for years. With graduation so close, even if Mydei ends up shredding his heart to pieces, at least he can recover far away from the places that hold their few shared memories.

Then, maybe, he will finally gather the courage to delete the photo.

“Alright… I’ll think about it,” he concedes.

“Promise me, Phai. Promise that you *will* invite him out.”

The girl holds out her pinky. Even after all these years, she still does these childish things.

That is only one of the reasons she is such a dear friend to Phainon.

“It’s a promise, Rene.”

They link pinkies, and Cyrene seems finally satisfied. She winks at him.

“Don’t forget to invite me to the wedding!”

Though he doubts it, Phainon laughs along with her.

Turns out it was hopeless all along.

Mydei is not only totally uninterested in him—he is already dating someone else.

How could Phainon not have noticed it before? Over the past few weeks, he had been so

caught up trying to invite him out that he never even considered the possibility that Mydei might already be in a relationship.

Whatever chance he had has been smashed altogether.

He feels so hollow that he couldn't even bring it up with Cyrene yet. His childhood friend is having a wonderful time with her first girlfriend She had already gone out of her way to keep him company for a while on the park's inauguration day, especially since Mydei never saw any of his messages about it. Phainon knows she would move sky and earth to hear him out, but this time, he cannot bring himself to reach out to her.

Funnily enough, the only one he feels he can confide in lately is the park's mascot—Fig Stew. What a strange coincidence it is for Phainon to befriend Mydei's favorite chimera from *The Awoo Firm*. Maybe that's the reason he feels such a strange connection to the mascot—he recalls holding onto Mydei's little phone charm for a while two years ago, poking its head sometimes during late-night study sessions in his bedroom.

It was the first time he had actually talked to an object.

"Did you see how gorgeous he looked today?" Phainon asks the charm as if it could reply. The fact that it cannot is what keeps him going.

"I almost forgot what we were supposed to be studying during the tutoring." Phainon laughs, twirling the small charm between his fingers.

"I envy you, little one… I'm sure your owner cherishes you a lot." He props his chin on his hand, a dreamy look overtaking his features. "I wish he would let me cherish him, too."

The poor charm is forced to listen to every affectionate thought of this hopelessly smitten teenager.

Even now, Fig Stew cannot say anything back to him because of its curse. It's almost as if the small charm has truly turned into a living being—if Phainon did not know there was someone inside the costume.

Naturally, the identity of whoever that might be makes him curious. Fig Stew is being played by a real person this time, and the chimera can now comfort him through his frustrated attempts with Mydei. For that, Phainon is deeply grateful. He swears that once things settle down—for better or worse—he will properly thank the kind person behind Fig Stew someday.

That small, shy '*Awoo*' brought much-needed comfort to his scarred heart, even if he is not sure what it truly means.

It is Sunday night, the same day he poured his heart out to the poor mascot. Their small adventure in the park earlier almost made him forget the dread that seeps into his mind every time he is left alone these days.

Because every time he's alone, he thinks about it—and it *consumes* him.

He thinks about the mysterious pink-haired girl. About Mydei. About how close they were that day at school. Phainon thinks he must be going crazy when it almost feels staged—like the girl knew he was watching and chose that exact moment to stake her claim on Mydei.

From his angle on the second floor, when she brought her face that close to Mydei's, it looked almost like a kiss.

A destructive feeling nests at his core, threatening to burst out.

*Why? Why does she get to have him?*

Who *is* she? She had never been anywhere near Mydei in all these years.

*Is that really the kind of girl he likes?*

Blood-red eyes, black fingernails, and a large black flower clip in her hair. Did Mydei always like gothic girls?

*How far have they gone already?*

And that is when things get ugly. Barely seeing them kissing already made him nauseous. If they did more than that—

His hands clench into fists, his heart plummeting as a lump forms in his throat while his imagination runs wild. Mydei's body looming over hers, her arms wrapped around him intimately. Her blood-red irises glow in the dark, mocking him.

"A loser like you never had a chance," the illusion taunts, wearing a victorious grin.

It is the first time he ever punches something out of sheer emotion, trying to make the image disappear. His fist slams into his study desk—fortunately—but the same cannot be said for his desk lamp. It flies off and shatters on the floor with a crash.

Darkness seeps into the room, along his heart.

*Fuck.*

So *this* is jealousy.

Phainon entertains the idea of finally deleting the photo of himself with Mydei. What use does it have, if not to upset him over something that never happened? He tries once, then twice. Part of him wants to hate Mydei—that way, maybe it would be easier to get over the Kremnoan. But as his thumb hovers over the "delete" button, his breath catches.

He could not hate Mydei even if the guy stomped all over his already broken heart. One single look into those deep, golden irises is enough for Phainon to forget every cold thing

Mydei has ever said to him.

It is almost as if Mydei owns a part of him that Phainon can never get back, no matter what.

All of this happens during exam season, and it reflects in his grades. Unable to concentrate on his studies or on the questions themselves, combined with a string of sleepless nights, he ends up performing terribly for the first time.

“If your grades don’t improve by the last exam period this year, it may be very difficult to secure you a recommendation letter to the Belobog Institute, Phainon.” Ms. Tribios's tone is clearly worried.
Oh, right…

That had been his goal. Belobog is the dream of every aspiring engineer—they build literal *mechas* there. Maintaining excellent grades would ensure a full scholarship to college, a necessity since his parents cannot afford college tuition.

But even that thought has grown dull lately.

“It won’t happen again,” Phainon assures, his voice devoid of emotion.

“You don’t look well, Phainon. You should go home and rest. I’ll let the teachers know.”

“There’s no need, Ms. Tribios. I’m fine—just a little tired,” he lies, hoping to win her over with a half-smile.

Going back to the quiet of his own room would not do any good for his spiraling thoughts.

Ms. Tribios still wears a worried expression as she dismisses him reluctantly.

His feet carry him back to the classroom. It is Monday morning, just before classes begin. His head throbs, and his body feels heavy as he walks. He feels sluggish and overheated—it is normal, it is summer, or so he forces himself to believe as sweat gathers on his palms and forehead. His vision starts to blur, making it hard to focus, so at first he does not pay much attention to his surroundings.

That’s until he hears a strangely familiar voice around the corner.

“You’re giving me that funny look again, Dan Heng.” Monotonous, almost bored. Where has Phainon heard it before?

Something compels him to stop. Phainon peeks into the corridor and realizes he is in the first-floor hallway, where the second-year classrooms are located.

A jolt runs through his spine when he sees *her*.

The mysterious pink-haired girl.

She has her back turned to him, speaking with a tall, dark-haired student. They have not noticed him yet.

“They’re still really curious about your relationship with that third-year.” Dan Heng says.

*Third-year? Are they talking about Mydei?* Phainon’s pulse quickens. What is this about?

The girl lets out an almost inaudible chuckle.

“It has to do with our little *secret*.”

It does not make sense to Phainon. Are they keeping their relationship a secret for some reason?

Dan Heng scoffs, shaking his head.

“… I assume you’re going there this Sunday too?”

“Yes. All my weekends this month have been consumed by it.” She sighs dramatically.

*Oh… So that’s how it is.* Mydei’s weekend plans for the entire month involve going out with her. It should not surprise Phainon—yet it still leaves a bitter taste in his mouth.

Dan Heng sounds exhausted as he sneers.

“Must you be so secretive about it, even with March?”

“No need to give March something to stress her pretty little head over.” The girl shrugs.

“I’m sure she’d be thrilled about it, though…”

“Some things are better left unsaid, Dan Heng. This *thing* will only last two more weeks, anyway.”

*Huh?* Did Phainon hear it right? Why does it sound like she’s talking as if her relationship has an expiration date?

“… I never would imagine you doing something like that, Evernight.” Dan Heng sighs.

Phainon can hear the amused tone in the girl’s voice.

“It’s been entertaining, at least.”

*Entertaining.*

Going out with Mydei has been *entertaining.*

While Phainon spent two whole years trying to come to terms with being hated by his crush,

this girl gets to treat it as something as trivial as entertainment.

Phainon turns around so quickly he fears he might have revealed himself to the duo. A few students in the hallway stare at him in confusion as he rushes past them. It does not matter. Even if they noticed him, he is already out of reach as he hurries up the stairs.

That girl—Evernight? Is she toying with Mydei? The way she spoke made it sound as if she were planning to end whatever they had in two weeks, laughing about it all the while.

If Mydei is serious about her and she ends up breaking his heart… Phainon knows he would never harm another human being, but the thought is disturbingly tempting right now.

His dizziness worsens with every step, and he is so lost in his inner turmoil that he can no longer tell where he is. His head feels on the verge of exploding, and if he does not lie down and rest for a while, he might collapse onto the floor at any moment.

Phainon finds the first place he can to set his bag down and closes his eyes, hoping the pain in his head will be enough to drown out those horrific thoughts.



Mydei's plan begins before the sun rises. He is out of bed at the first alarm, making his way to the kitchen with renewed vigor.

It has been a long time since he last cooked for someone other than his mother. Back in Kremnos, he used to gather his group of friends and make meals for all of them, but there has been no similar opportunity since. He also never mentioned this hobby to any of the girls at school.

Mydei does not know Phainon's favorite dishes, so he plays it safe with grilled fish, rice, and vegetables for a starter. He also hopes Phainon is not allergic to anything in the dish. Maybe he can learn more about Phainon's tastes as the week goes by.

When Mydei arrives in the classroom, he is surprised to see Phainon is not there yet. Usually, as class rep, he arrives much earlier to assist the teachers. Well, maybe he is dealing with that right now.

So, without giving it too much thought, Mydei takes his seat by the window and greets Castorice.

"Hi, Mydei." She replies, but there is something off about her tone. It makes Mydei frown.

"Did something happen?"

Castorice averts her gaze, as if unsure whether she should be talking about it. She shifts uncomfortably.

"Haven't you heard?" Her voice drops. "Phainon bombed almost every exam last week. Principal Tribios summoned him to her office a few minutes ago."

*What?*

"How?" Mydei echoes more to himself than to her. Phainon has been top of the class for years. To do that badly out of nowhere—

Well, maybe entirely out of nowhere.

He is heartbroken because of Cyrene.

"I don't know either… but he looked really worn out earlier." Castorice presses a hand to her chest, her brows knitting together. "I was afraid he might faint at any moment."

Mydei would not have believed it if Castorice were not so earnest. Her concern seems genuine enough to make him shift uneasily in his seat.

Yesterday, Phainon had seemed perfectly functional—or at least as much as his sadness over Cyrene allowed. But he didn't look *that* bad. Had anything else happened in the meantime?

As the minutes pass, Mydei grows increasingly uneasy. When Cyrene enters the classroom, she is wearing a grim expression. Her orchid-colored eyes sweep across the room before finally landing on him.

If looks could kill.

*Why is she angry at me?* Mydei wonders, narrowing his eyes, completely taken aback.

Cyrene shakes her head, though her expression remains stiff. She takes her seat and starts fiddling with her phone until class begins.

Even after the bell rings, Phainon still does not show up. Some of their classmates begin murmuring about what might have happened.

“Isn’t this the first day Khaslana has missed a class in literal years?”

“I’ve known him since elementary school, and this has never happened before.”

“Yeah, dude shows up even during snowstorms. Total freak.”

“He had a bandaged arm too. Did someone finally grow the balls to punch the perfect boy?”

Mydei’s fists clench on top of his desk. Before he can do something he might regret, the teacher for their philosophy class—Anaxagoras—arrives.

The man unceremoniously drops his thick books onto the desk with a loud thud.

“I hope all of you can redirect that enormous interest in Khaslana’s private life toward our upcoming lecture on nousporism.”

The students shut their mouths almost instantly.

It is still not enough to ease the growing worry in Mydei’s gut about Phainon’s—and Cyrene’s—unusual behavior. He can feel a few sidelong glances from Castorice as well, but he does not try to search for its meaning yet. There is too much going on in his head already.

When lunchtime arrives, the pink-haired girl nearly jumps out of her seat and heads straight toward him.

“Mydei.”

Somehow, her stern tone makes him nervous. He looks up at her.

“What?”

“Do you have anything to do with this?”

“Anything to do with what?” Mydei tilts his head, completely lost.

Cyrene’s frown deepens. She opens her mouth, closes it once, then twice, before finally pressing her lips into a firm line and rubbing her forehead.

“Never mind.” She seems less angry now. “Have you seen Phainon?”

“… No?”

It almost feels like the wrong answer, even though he has no idea why. Why on earth should he know where Phainon is when Cyrene is his closest friend? Surely they must be in a rough spot in their relationship, but assuming that *Mydei*, of all people, would know anything is almost insane. Even Castorice sounds like a better option.

“He’s not answering my calls or texts,” she says.

Well—did she ever consider the possibility that it might have something to do with Phainon being heartbroken over her new girlfriend?

“Stelle said some second-year students saw him on their floor a while before classes,” Cyrene continues. “Then he ran off somewhere else.”

“So he’s still at school, then?” Castorice asks, unable to hide her concern as she speaks from her desk.

Cyrene nods. “I assume so. No one saw him leave through the school gates.”

“Have you tried the infirmary?”

“I did.” Cyrene sighs. “Can you contact Cipher as well? If any of you see him…”

She trails off, placing her hands on her waist, suddenly looking exhausted.

“Just let me know if he’s alright, okay?”

“Of course, Cyrene…” Castorice agrees.

Before turning to leave, Cyrene throws one last pointed look at Mydei.

“You two are going to be responsible for my newest white hairs. I swear to Mnestia.”

*What the hell does that mean?* Mydei arches an eyebrow as she walks away. He glances sideways, where Castorice already has her phone in hand.

“Cipher said she and Hyacine will be looking for him as well.” Castorice turns to face Mydei. “Are you coming too?”

What a mess.

It’s not that Mydei isn’t worried—he is—but he is fairly certain he is not the person Phainon needs most right now. If Phainon is really hiding, or if something has happened, the best he can do is report it to his friends or the teachers.

“If I see him, I’ll let you all know,” Mydei assures her.

Castorice nods and leaves the now-empty classroom. Mydei exhales heavily, pinching the bridge of his nose.

*Where are you?* he wonders silently, a dull ache settling in his chest.

It seems his plan to honor their bet will have to be postponed again.

Maybe he underestimated how deeply Phainon was suffering over Cyrene's new relationship. He gathers his belongings and heads out.

Mydei tries to convince himself that he is not going out of his way to look out for him. It is obviously a lie—he spends every minute of lunchtime wandering through places where he remembers seeing the moonlight-haired student pass by.

When he is certain he has run out of options beneath the courtyard staircase, a familiar voice calls out to him from above.

"Did you lose something today, big boy?"

Evernight. Mydei is not in the mood to deal with her riddles right now.

"None of your business," he snarls.

Evernight grins as she leans against the stairway handrail.

"Really? I thought I had seen it earlier… your precious dawn."

Mydei is on the verge of walking away when it finally clicks.

*Dawn?*

Phainon's sun tattoo flashes through his mind. All this time—was Evernight talking about him?

"Oh. Something in that oblivious head finally clicked, didn't it?" she teases, and Mydei is one step away from climbing the stairs and shaking her for a straight answer.

"Where is he?"

"Wouldn't you love to know…"

"Evernight." Mydei knows Evernight wouldn't ever feel threatened, but he is out of patience. The corners of her blood-red irises crinkle with amusement as she looks down at him.

"Sorry. That intense display of emotions is always very entertaining," she chuckles. "The last time I saw him, he was heading toward the fourth floor."

The fourth floor? There is nothing up there except the rooftop. Most of the floor is occupied by storerooms and—

The library.

Evernight seems delighted by the shocked expression on Mydei's face. She lets out a dramatic sigh.

"He looked very sluggish. I hope he's still in one piece by the time you find him." She pauses pointedly as Mydei gathers his thoughts. "What are you waiting for, big boy?"

That's the million credits question. After all, Mydei has just learned where Phainon might be. Wouldn't the logical thing be to report it to Castorice and Cyrene? They would take care of him regardless of his condition. That had been the plan, after all.

But a small part of him—the selfish part, the one still clinging to a few sweet memories from years ago—slowly begins to override his rational judgment.

*Why the library?*

He wonders.

*Could he be… waiting for me to find him?*

He hopes.

A foolish train of thought. The library had never been exclusive to the two of them; it could mean absolutely nothing.

Still, as long as that possibility exists… Mydei decides to see it for himself.

He hurries up the stairs. Evernight waves at him as he passes by, and he makes a mental note to ask about the other things she implied in earlier conversations once everything is solved.

By the time he reaches the fourth floor, the bell is already ringing. Well—he will not be going back to class anytime soon. Mr. Ratio can throw a piece of chalk at his forehead later.

Stopping in front of the library's large wooden double doors, he pushes them open with a creak.

The place seems empty; it must be the librarian's break time. Mydei scans the room, confirming there is no one inside.

*Is he somewhere else on the fourth floor, then?* he wonders, frowning. As he turns to leave, a slight glimpse of an ajar door in the corner catches his attention.

It leads to one of the library's lecture rooms—one he remembers all too well.

His breath hitches.

*Why?*

Mydei steps toward the lecture room slowly. He pushes the door open just enough to peek inside.

Indeed—Phainon is there. He is slumped over the desk, lying atop his bag, apparently asleep. His glasses rest folded at his side. He does not stir as Mydei fully enters the room, trying to get a clearer sense of his condition.

Phainon's face is deeply flushed, his skin slick with sweat, his bangs plastered to his forehead. His brows are drawn together, and his breathing is heavy. Castorice and Evernight were right—Phainon is clearly not in good shape. He must have felt far too unwell to return to the classroom earlier.

Of all the places… he chose to faint right in their old lecture room?

While Mydei desperately wants to know why, there is a more pressing concern. Phainon needs to go home and rest properly instead of worrying all of his friends—and Mydei himself.

He steps closer, placing a hand on Phainon's shoulder and giving it a very gentle shake.

"Hey. Phainon," Mydei calls hesitantly, but the student does not budge in the slightest. Phainon remains trapped in a restless sleep, his pained expression a clear sign of distress.

Mydei's chest tightens at the sight. *Is he having a nightmare?*

"Phainon, wake up," he tries again, putting more pressure into his touch.

It gets some response at least.

"…n't go…" Phainon murmurs through his unconscious state.

Unable to make out his words clearly, Mydei leans closer, worry etched into his features. He is almost certain Phainon cannot hear him, but he keeps trying.

"What are you babbling about? Hey—"

"D… Don't go. *Please*…"

Mydei's heart catches in his throat as a tear slips down Phainon's cheek, his shoulders trembling. He knows it is about Cyrene. He also knows Phainon has no idea who is in the room with him right now.

*If you believe I'm her, will you stop crying?*

Maybe Cyrene from the reality can't return Phainon's feelings. But if Mydei's affection can reach him—even for just an instant…

"I'm here. I'm not going anywhere," Mydei murmurs, lifting a hand to gently brush the tears away. Only then does he realize how close he is—close enough that his lips nearly graze Phainon's ear.

Phainon sniffles, and it's a pitiful thing. His skin is feverishly hot beneath Mydei's fingertips.

“…Mi… missed y-you…”

*It’s not meant for me,* Mydei reminds himself. *It isn’t.*

Still, the words that leave his own mouth could belong to no one else. A pained smile curves his lips.

“Missed you too,” Mydei whispers, pressing a kiss to a freshly fallen tear, the salty taste lingering on his lips.

Phainon inhales shakily, and finally—*finally*—he seems to break free from the nightmare. Slowly, a pair of moist cerulean eyes opens, unfocused at first, then settling on the figure hovering above him through a haze.

Mydei freezes, keeping perfectly still, afraid that any sudden movement might startle him as Phainon tentatively tries to make sense of what’s happening. His eyes blink sluggishly, still heavy with exhaustion, and his rough voice barely rises above a whisper.

“Am I… dreaming?”

Mydei can’t help but wonder who Phainon is seeing through that feverish haze. Judging by the fond look that softens his features, it certainly isn’t him.

*If only…*

“Think again. Welcome back from the dead,” Mydei scoffs, now certain the other is awake enough to register his surroundings. He takes the chance to straighten up, earning a cute, confused frown from Phainon and silently hoping he hasn’t thought too much about how close they were just moments ago.

The distance gives Mydei room to breathe, to steady the frantic pounding of his own heart.

“Mydei…”

Oh. So he does recognize him. Phainon lifts a hand to his forehead, using his uninjured elbow to prop himself up slightly. Slowly, he reaches for his glasses and settles them back onto the bridge of his nose.
“Why are you here…?”

“You gave everyone a scare. Cyrene and the others are looking for you,” Mydei explains softly.

It’s almost as if Phainon’s headache worsens. He casts a sideways glance at Mydei.

“You were looking for me?”

Mydei swallows. There isn’t really a way to deny it, is there?

“Like I said, everyone’s worried,” he replies, hoping it’s clarification enough.

Phainon narrows his eyes toward him. Mydei is starting to miss his slumbering self.

“Right. And you suddenly care about me?” Though it sounds more tired than angry, the bitterness is unmistakable.

Well. Mydei supposes he deserves the suspicion.

He crosses his arms defensively over his chest. He isn’t about to argue with someone who’s clearly unwell. Maybe it’s better to give in this time.

“… Yeah.”

Phainon nearly loses his balance, barely stopping himself from face-planting into the desk.

“H-huh?”

Mydei shifts his weight, feeling out of place.

“Look, that’s not important right now.” He tries to steer the conversation away. It’s not like he’s about to admit that meeting Phainon as Fig Stew shed some light on just how awful he’s been treating him. “You look like shit. You need to go home and rest.”

It takes Phainon a few moments to let the subject drop. He closes his eyes and pinches the bridge of his nose.

“I *feel* like shit. I think I’ll faint if I get up.”

Mydei shuts down the idea of offering to carry him to the infirmary as soon as it crosses his mind. Not going there now.

Still, Phainon looks pale as a ghost despite his burning-hot skin.

“Have you eaten?”

Phainon shoots him a surprised glance. He seems on the verge of agreeing, but stops at the last moment.

“…I had dinner yesterday.”

Under normal circumstances, Mydei would flick his forehead.

“Dumbass. No wonder your body’s so weak.”

As he says this, Mydei sets his bag down on the desk. Turns out his plan wasn’t completely in vain. Phainon watches in silence as he pulls out a Tupperware and a pair of plastic utensils. Mydei is glad he chose something easy on the stomach, considering how long Phainon has gone without food.

“Eat first. Then we’ll get you on your way home.”

Phainon’s gaze flickers between him and the accusing meal.

“Mydei, that’s your lunch… I can’t take it,”

“I already ate. I made this one for you,” Mydei replies without missing a beat. He’s not accepting any excuses.

Phainon’s jaw drops.

“You… Made this for me?” he repeats dumbly.

“Yeah.” Mydei tries to shrug it off, pushing aside the upsetting thought that Phainon might refuse anything that comes from him. “It’s not poisoned or anything.”

“That’s not—” Phainon frowns and shakes his head slightly, but the motion only seems to worsen his dizziness. He groans, forcing himself to focus. “It’s just… why?”

Mydei figures they won’t be leaving anytime soon. With a sigh, he takes a seat across from Phainon, crossing his arms.

“I told you before: I honor my word.” Albeit really late. He swallows as Phainon blinks at him in confusion. “That bet from two years ago… You won.”

Phainon’s wide cerulean eyes stare at him as if Mydei has grown a second head. The silence grows so awkward that Mydei ends up clearing his throat.

“I get that it’s weird after so much time, but if you can just ignore that detail—”

His words are cut short when Phainon suddenly picks up the cutlery, opens the plastic container, and takes a generous bite. Mydei almost worries he might choke on such a big mouthful.

When Phainon finally gulps down, Mydei’s heart does a little leap around his ribcage. There it is—albeit exhausted and dulled by sickness. Phainon’s radiant smile pierces through for the first time in what feels like ages—and it’s directed at him.

“I wish I could taste it properly without being sick,” Phainon says, chuckling weakly but earnestly. “It still tastes amazing, though, Mydei. Better than I have ever imagined.”

*You imagined it?*

What a silly coincidence. Mydei has imagined it too, more than once, during better days—what Phainon would think of his cooking, what expression he’d make. He’s used to being praised for it; it’s the skill he takes the most pride in, and the career he wants to follow when back in Kremnos.

But having his crush taste it—seeing him so genuinely happy because of it—makes his chest feel light, giddy in a way he’s not quite prepared for.

He hopes it doesn’t show in his face, even though he can feel a smirk tugging at his lips.

“Then get better and taste it again tomorrow,” he says.

Mydei knows Phainon is flushed because of the fever—but he's almost certain the moonlight-haired student's cheeks deepen into an even stronger shade of red at the comment.

*He's so cute.*

"O… Okay…" Phainon mutters, turning his full attention back to the meal and eating in flustered silence.

As Mydei watches him, he remembers he's supposed to let Cyrene and the girls know that Phainon is alright. Well, mostly alright. He nearly reaches for his phone to message her, but hesitates at the last moment.

Would Phainon be upset if Cyrene learned about his condition? If he's been hiding his sickness from her, there has to be a reason.

It obviously has nothing to do with Mydei wanting to keep him to himself.

"What are you thinking about?" Phainon asks quietly. That's when Mydei notices he's finished eating—and that he looks a little more lively now.

Mydei remembers how sad Phainon had looked yesterday at the park. He doesn't want to bring Cyrene up now, and he certainly doesn't want to see Phainon upset again. Maybe… he could help distract him from it.

"That Chimera Park pass of yours…" Mydei starts, trying to sound as nonchalant as possible, but Phainon is already squinching his eyes at him. He swallows. "Do you… still want to go?"

Phainon's shocked expression isn't unexpected.

"I… I thought you already had plans?"

*Well, fuck.*

Looks like he's calling in sick this Sunday.

"They got cancelled."

"Oh," Phainon says. He seems troubled as he scratches his chin, and Mydei wonders if he's already given up on the idea of inviting him. After a long, stretched moment of silence, Phainon nods curtly. "Sure, I would love to."

Mydei tries not to make too much of it. After all, he's just comforting a friend after his latest romantic frustration.

They agree to discuss the details later in the week, since Phainon isn't really in good shape right now. Mydei walks him to the school gate, where Phainon says his father will be there to pick him up in a few minutes. He explains that Principal Tribios already suggested he leave early and authorized his exit beforehand.

“You can go back to the classroom. I’m not going to faint again,” Phainon teases lightly, well aware that Mydei has already missed an entire class by now.

Even though Mydei believes him, he’s still bothered by the idea of leaving him alone. Or rather… he doesn’t want to part ways just yet, not when they’re finally able to talk normally again after so much time. There’s no way to say that without sounding weird, though, so all he can do is sigh.

“You better not,” Mydei mutters. “You don’t get to invite me somewhere and bail on me—not even if you’re almost dead.”

The corners of Phainon’s eyes crinkle as he laughs wholeheartedly, a sound Mydei is never tired of hearing.

“I wouldn’t miss this for anything, Mydei. It’s a promise.”

The butterflies in his stomach flutter at those words. Mydei needs to leave before he does something he might regret, so he finally turns to go.

Still, that insistent, hopeful part of his mind is far too happy to be contained.

Because if he ignores the small detail that Phainon doesn’t reciprocate his feelings, it almost feels like it could be called a date.

As the thought sinks in, he feels the urge to look over his shoulder. It’s the first time he actually does so before leaving Phainon behind.

To his surprise, the moonlight-haired student is already watching him. When Phainon notices Mydei’s stare, a beautiful smile graces his features as he lifts a hand and waves goodbye.

Mydei turns away, red-faced and with his pulse racing, quickening his pace back toward the classroom.

*Can Sunday come sooner?*

Chapter End Notes

I like to think Phainon's jealousy tends to be way more destructive (ahem) than Mydei's, who prefers to avoid thinking about it.

I had so many power shortages while writing this chapter. I now click the save button every time I write a new sentence.

Thank you so much for sticking with me. I hope you enjoyed it! Knowing you had fun pays out all of the suffering I went through <3

See you soon ~

# Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Phainon's name is now being associated with the Fig Stew curse. Surely that won't affect their trip to the Chimera Park...

Chapter Notes

The only warning I have for this chapter is that it's huge.
Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

On Tuesday morning, Mydei is out of bed again as soon as the alarm rings. Before heading to the kitchen, however, he realizes he isn't sure whether Phainon is feeling well enough to show up at school.

Against his better judgment, he opens the messenger app. The last time they exchanged messages was two weeks ago.

Mydei quickly types, hoping he's not disturbing Phainon if he's still feeling sick.

**Mydei:** Hey. How are you feeling today?

He taps his finger against the back of his phone as he waits. The message soon changes to read, and then a reply comes through:

**Phainon:** I feel better. Good morning to you too :)

Mydei rolls his eyes.

**Mydei:** Are you coming to school today?

**Phainon:** I'm already on my way. It's a bit of a long trip by bus.

Mydei can imagine him sitting with his notebook in hand as the track goes on. It would be nice to watch.

**Mydei:** What do you want for lunch?

**Phainon:** I get to choose? :0

**Mydei:** You won the bet. Seems fair to me.

**Phainon:** Hm…

**Phainon:** I want something spicy.

Mydei snorts. Could it be any more vague?

**Mydei:** How spicy?

**Phainon:** As much as the chef ;)

Mydei stares at the message for a full minute. He's almost sure Phainon is just teasing him, but he can't help feeling his face grow hot as he rereads it a couple of times.

*Calm down. He's not flirting with me,* Mydei thinks. *He's just being a prick.*

Mydei types the only thing that comes to mind as he pulls his phone away and starts thinking of a recipe for the day.

**Mydei:** *HKS.*

When Mydei arrives at the third-year hallway, he's surprised to see that the way to his classroom is crowded with students from all years.

*What the fuck?* he thinks as he tries to get a look inside the room. Luckily, he's much taller than most of the students, so he manages to catch a glimpse of what's happening all the way at the front.

"Oh my Phagousa! Khaslana, are you really connected to the Chimera Park easter egg?!" a first-year girl exclaims, circling the class rep along with several others.

"Are you appearing on the special? I want an autograph!" another nearly shouts.

Phainon is at the eye of the storm, trying to get everyone to calm down with his palms raised.

"It's just a coincidence—I have nothing to do with Fig Stew's crush!"

*Oh, shit.*

Panicked, Mydei pulls out his phone and checks his social media, searching for the "Chimera Park" tag.

What he sees there makes his mind stall.

**Lilgui:** A very trusted font of mine shared this photo yesterday!

*[totallytrustworthyproof4.jpg]*

**notrashnogain12:** by Aklivii, isn't that Fig Stew??

**d4zzlingninj4:** it's not very ninja to be seen hugging someone so intimately!! (ಠ_ಠ

**RedHerring:** forget that… isn't that guy's color scheme suspiciously similar to Vigethos?

**cutestofall✿:** what are you even talking about? since when do humans have a color scheme???

**Cloudsknightbeauty:** Oh no… That's not Butterfly Cake D:

**notrashnogain21:** the hell. I know him, he's from my school. think his name is Kevin or something

**cutestofall✿:** omg! Stelle, you can't dox anyone online like that!

**notrashnogain12:** you just did that though March lol and his name is Khaslana

**Lilgui:** *ahem* guys! Remember to be civil—don't go and importune the poor soul. Or if you do, at least don't mention my name; I don't want to lose my account!

**Lilgui:** Either way, it seems like we saw a glimpse of Fig Stew's possible crush. Let's stay tuned to see if we get new details this weekend!

Mydei stops scrolling, feeling faint.

*Can Nikador's big fucking sword hit me already?*

It takes Principal Tribios's presence to settle things down. When she appears in the hallway, the crowd slowly falls silent.

"Dear students, our school is in no way linked to any show or studio. Please refrain from disrupting school activities during class hours. Additionally, it is expressly prohibited to use personal information to expose any of our students' private lives."

Though her tone is patient, the fiery-haired woman carries an imposing posture as she waits for the students to return to their classrooms. She then approaches the classroom door and signals for Phainon to step outside, asking him to accompany her to her office.

Mydei watches as the student is already apologizing for the turmoil, and he can't help but feel guilty.

He hadn't thought about the consequences of letting his emotions show so openly as Fig Stew.

When Mydei is finally able to reach his seat, he notices Castorice staring at him.

"Morning," he says, sounding more tired than he expected.

"Good morning, Mydei…" She seems on the verge of saying something, but then changes her mind. "I assume you know about Fig Stew's new rumor?"

Mydei never wanted to hit his head on the desk that much before.

"Yeah."

Castorice glances around, making sure nobody is paying attention to them—most of their classmates are yapping about Phainon's involvement with *The Awoo Firm*.

"Shouldn't we tell him about the mascots?" When Mydei squints at her, she continues. "I-I mean, he got involved accidentally… I think he at least deserves to know by whom…"

Though Castorice's suggestion makes perfect sense, there's no way Mydei is accepting it. He's not going to admit to being Fig Stew and literally *awooing* to Phainon.

"Over my dead body," he says, more to himself—though it makes Castorice recoil a little. Poor girl.

A few minutes before class starts, Phainon returns to the classroom. Though everyone is looking at him funnily, he doesn't seem to take notice, glancing toward the back and offering Mydei a brief smile before taking his seat.

*What are you so happy about?* Mydei can't help but wonder.

Just after the bell rings, Cyrene arrives in a rush. Mydei hasn't really spoken to her since yesterday—he'd notified Castorice about Phainon being on his way home, and she must have passed the information along to the other girls. Cyrene's behavior toward him had been odd, but honestly, he couldn't bring himself to care what she thought of him.

She and Phainon seem to have started talking again. Mydei doesn't know to what extent, but he supposes Phainon is handling his childhood friend—and eternal crush—dating someone else a little better now.

Mydei only hopes he won't eventually spiral into another breakdown.

When Ms. Aglaea's English class ends, most of the students are already leaving for lunchtime. Mydei only has the time to stand up when Phainon approaches him.

"Hey, Mydei. Care to accompany me for lunch?" he asks expectantly.

Though Mydei has been preparing his meals for the week, he hadn't been sure Phainon would want to spend lunchtime with him. He had thought that maybe Phainon wouldn't want to be seen eating something the Kremnoan made— even though Cyrene is likely nowhere around for the time being, having already dashed out the door. He side-glances at Castorice, who's been flickering her eyes between the two of them with widened eyes and one hand covering her mouth.

Well, he can understand the shock to some extent.

As Mydei takes too long to answer, Phainon's expression wilts a little.

"Unless you already planned to go with someone else—"

What is he even talking about? Mydei always ate alone if not with the girls.

"Sure," he cuts in, hanging his bag over his shoulder. Phainon's features brighten as he leads the way. Mydei notices that as soon as they start moving, Castorice immediately pulls out her phone and starts furiously typing.

Seems like the girls will have a lot to gossip about.



Surprisingly, Phainon leads them to the fourth floor. They stop in front of a locked door as Phainon fidgets with his back pocket, pulling out a key.

“Where did you get that?” Mydei asks curiously, unable to picture the student snagging a key to some prohibited school place.

“Ms. Tribios said it would be a good place to hide from the other students until things settle down,” Phainon chuckles. “I guess she’s confident that I wouldn’t jump off the building.”

Wait. Principal Tribios let him have a private place during lunch, and Phainon chose to bring Mydei of all people with him?

*It must be because of the meal,* Mydei thinks, not wanting to let his mind read too much into the situation. It’s perfectly normal behavior to invite a friend over. If Phainon were on better terms with Cyrene, she would probably be here instead.

The rooftop is, as expected, very plain, but as they enter Mydei can’t help but find the view of the city pretty amazing.

It’s the first time he realizes he’s never gone out of his way to actually learn anything about Okhema; the return date to Kremnos was always a certainty to him. It’s by no means as big and glorious as everything Kremnoans like to express—even in their architecture—however, Okhema has a more classical, eye-catching charm of its own.

“Breathtaking, isn’t it?” Phainon’s voice carries over a soothing tone.

“Mhm.” Mydei grunts.

They sit down near the rooftop entrance, where the wall casts a stretch of shade. Mydei busies himself with taking out today’s meal as Phainon watches, arms tucked behind his head.

“What’s on the menu today, chef?” he teases.

Mydei rolls his eyes as he slides the container toward him. He then takes his own portion, toned down in spiciness—he doesn’t want to end up with an upset stomach so early in the day.

“Potato and carrot cooked in curry broth,” he replies monotonously. “With extra spice, just for you.”

Phainon is already taking his first bite as Mydei speaks.

“It tastes divine, as expected from you,” he praises earnestly. “Thanks for the meal!”

Mydei scoffs, feeling giddy from the praise.

They spend lunchtime in comfortable silence, until Phainon speaks up again.

“Aren’t you curious about this Fig Stew thing?” Phainon asks once they finish eating.

Mydei stiffens as he replies, “Why would I be? Sounds like a baseless rumor over a single photo.”

Phainon studies him in silence, resting a hand on his chin.

“I thought you’d be interested in your favorite chimera having a love interest,” he points out. “From what I hear, it’s something never seen in the cartoon.”

*Well, shit.*

Under normal circumstances, he would be very interested—but when he’s the one playing Fig Stew in that story, he can’t help feeling awkward. Mydei shrugs, trying to sound nonchalant.

“I’ll only believe it if it actually becomes a special,” he says. “Unless you know something about that?”

He hopes playing dumb is enough to keep Phainon from growing suspicious about his lack of interest in the topic.

“Not really,” Phainon shakes his head. “I just happened to befriend Fig Stew during a rough time. They’ve been really kind to me, although…”

As Phainon trails off, Mydei arches an eyebrow.

“What?”

“It’s kind of funny, actually,” he says as he brushes his fingers over the bandage around his elbow. It’s probably almost entirely healed by now, and this certainly isn’t the same Fig Stew wrapped on Sunday. “You two have a very similar way of showing kindness. A very imposing one.”

Mydei blinks. He should be more worried about the comparison, but he’s more baffled than anything else.

“The heck is that supposed to mean?”

Phainon laughs quietly.

“Fig Stew wouldn’t let me go until it treated my injury.” he says, cerulean-blue eyes settling on Mydei’s, the color incredibly bright under the open sky. “And you made sure I ate yesterday when I was feeling unwell. It leaves no room to complain.”

Mydei crosses his arms defensively over his chest.

“Maybe they’ve also identified your lack of self-preservation,” he shoots back. Mydei is used to looking after his friends, and it was not different even if Phainon happened to be his crush.

“Mhm, maybe…” Phainon hums, a bit too casually for a comment about his lack of self-care. “I’m glad you will finally be able to meet them, though.”

*Damn it.*

Guilt gnaws at him. Phainon truly thinks Fig Stew will be present there this Sunday. It brings another point of attention to their scheduled trip to the park.

“About that… are you sure it’s a good idea to go there when you’re caught up in this Easter egg mess?” Mydei asks, recalling how exhausting dealing with the fans can be. “There’s a high chance people will bother you about it.”

“No way—as I said before, I’m not missing it, not even over being harassed by Fig Stew’s fans,” Phainon replies decisively.

Though Mydei feels giddy over Phainon’s being so set on keeping his promise with him, he wouldn’t be opposed to going somewhere else instead of the park. Still, it feels too awkward to suggest that when Phainon is being so laid-back about it.

“Unless… you don’t want to go anymore because of it?” Phainon’s tone shifts into a dejected one.

“No—that’s not it, I still want to,” Mydei replies honestly with a sigh. “I’m just worried those people might ruin the trip.”

“Ah… that’s fair,” Phainon concedes, falling into thoughtful silence. “Then… if I come up with a plan to clean my name off Fig Stew’s rumor, it should be all right, no?”

Mydei squints at him, suddenly uneasy.

“What kind of plan?”

The half-smile Phainon gives him doesn’t do any good to his heart.

“One that would ensure we aren’t bothered.”



The week goes by rather quickly. Phainon keeps dragging Mydei up to the rooftop and refuses to share any details about his so-called foolproof plan to stop being associated with Fig Stew's crush. Though some students still insist on questioning him about it, he patiently reiterates that he has nothing to do with the *Awoo Studio.*

Mydei keeps honoring his bet. He asks Phainon what kind of food he wants first thing in the morning, and each day is more random than the last—from desserts to Kremnoan cuisine.

On Friday, Phainon tells Mydei to choose something he thinks he'll like, based on his reactions over the week.

It's really hard to do when Phainon devours everything like a starving man and praises Mydei's cooking skills every time.

Mydei is almost sure that if he feeds him a piece of burnt meat, Phainon would still eat it with a smile on his face. But he would never do that—not without a good reason, at least.

So, Mydei ends up baking golden honeycakes, one of his own favorite dishes.

When Phainon takes the first bite, it's almost as if he melts.

"Titans, Mydei… this tastes so good," he whines in awe, licking the remaining syrup off his fingers—a gesture Mydei pays more attention to than he'd like to admit. "I don't think I can live without your cooking anymore."

Mydei's chest tightens at the comment. If it means getting such earnest reactions from Phainon, he finds the idea appealing. He can't say that out loud, though, so he averts his gaze for the sake of his own sanity.

"Too bad. My debt is already paid off," he says.

"Can't we make another bet then? Please?" Phainon bats his eyelashes at him, all the while devouring the dish.

Mydei scoffs, casting him a sideways glance. "You would have to win again."

"A feat I can absolutely repeat!" Phainon chirps.

"Fuck off," Mydei elbows his side, though a smirk tugs at his lips as Phainon lets out a lighthearted laugh.

It's nice to finally be able to interact with Phainon so casually after so long. If Mydei ignores the part of him that yearns for something more, he can almost convince himself that Phainon could fit among his best friends if circumstances were different. He can picture it vividly—introducing him to Hephaestion, Leonnius, Perdikkas, Ptolemy, and Peucesta. They'd surely

start by picking on him, but once they warmed up, Phainon would be treated like a member of the group in no time.

A dull ache settles in at the thought. Sadly, that reality is nothing but a dream.

He would consider himself lucky if he ever saw Phainon again after graduation.



It's Saturday night. Mydei and his friends have just finished their last session of *Chrysos Wars 2*, a common activity for them and the usual way he keeps in touch with them while in Okhema.

After Leonnius, Peucesta, Ptolemy, and Perdikkas leave the call for the night, it's just him and Hephaestion.

"So, tomorrow you're going on that super-ultra-secret part-time job again?" Hephaestion asks over the mic. His friends have been pretty insistent on knowing what he's doing every Sunday instead of showing up to play with them.

"Actually, I'm not going tomorrow," Mydei replies, staring at his screen absent-mindedly.

"Oh? You're finally gracing us with your royal presence, then?" Hephaestion teases.

"Like I was not present the entire year before," Mydei scoffs.

"Everyone's just curious. Leonnius is certain I know what this is about and won't stop pestering me."

Mydei rolls his eyes. Theoretically, hiding the park mascot thing from his friends shouldn't be an issue—but he can already imagine the endless comments about "that part-time job when you were a furry" being used endlessly on repeat.

"It's no big deal. In two weeks, I'll be free again," he assures.

Hephaestion hums.

"So what's got you so busy tomorrow, then?"

Mydei shifts in his seat. He would be lying if he said he wasn't at least a bit anxious about it.

"I'm going out with a friend."

Obviously, Hephaestion wouldn't be satisfied with just that.

"What? Who is this warrior who got you out of your house and part-time job?" his friend presses.

*I asked for it, haven't I?*

Mydei tries to sound as nonchalant as possible, though the mention of the name already has his stomach fluttering.

"It's Phainon, from my class," he replies.

The shock is clear in Hephaestion's voice.

“Huh? Phainon? *That Phainon*? The one you used to blabber about on every call two years ago?” He rattles on, recalling more details as he goes. “The same one you said had the fluffiest snowy-white hair ever, a smile as radiant as the morning sun, and the pool of bluest eyes you ever gazed upon?”

*Holy shit. Why does everyone around me have such a good memory?*

“I did not say all that,” Mydei protests with a frown—he most certainly did not use those exact words—but Hephaestion isn’t having any of it.

“Yeah, no shit. You’re lucky I’m the only one here right now—I’m only bringing up the cute things you said,” Hephaestion replies. His smirk can almost be felt through the mic.

Mydei’s cheeks flush red. Can he go back in time and slap his younger self?

“But… didn’t you give up on him because he already had a girlfriend?” Hephaestion continues. “You never brought him up again after you found out.”

Indeed, Mydei shut down every mention of Phainon his friends made until, eventually, they accepted that he’d moved on.

It had been easier to fool them while living in another city.

“She dumped him last week,” Mydei says. “Phainon needed some distraction from it, so he invited me out.”

He doesn’t go into detail about how he found out—or about the way Phainon had nearly collapsed over it.

Hephaestion snorts.

“Oh, you sneaky bastard. The guy’s been single for a week, and you’re already back on the dating market?”

“What—It’s not a date,” Mydei says, trying to shrug it off after spending far too much time convincing himself of that. “It’s just two friends hanging out, dumbass.”

He’s been trying to associate Phainon with the word friend more lately. Their relationship has regained some of its foundation, and he’d rather not strain it again over his own feelings.

“Mydei, my dear, you’re many things—but a *distraction* isn’t one of them.” Hephaestion’s voice softens. “If he’s single, what’s stopping you?”

“Well, for one, he already said he can’t stop liking her,” Mydei says, remembering the breakdown Phainon had at the park. There’s also another issue that’s been etched into the back of his mind lately. “Besides, there’s no point in investing in something here when I’ll be going back to Kremnos in a few months.”

Hephaestion sighs.

“You realize you’re coming up with excuses that will only leave you miserable, right?” he says, voice dropping. “If that’s really how you feel, why not give it a shot? Even short relationships can create lifelong memories. I’m sure Phainon has eyes—as you *very lovingly* described—and he’d be crazy not to find you attractive, at the very least.”

His friend’s words make that giddy feeling bubble up in his stomach again.

“Well, he wears glasses, so that might not be the case…”

“*Mydeimos, for fucks sake.*” Hephaestion groans. “When you’re back, I’m going to hammer some sense into that thick head of yours. Mark my words.”

Mydei lets out a soft chuckle over the mic. He isn’t doubting Hephaestion on that one.

Though Mydei tries to avoid thinking about the possibility of actually dating Phainon, he can’t say he isn’t fond of the idea. After all, Phainon seems to be warming up to him far more quickly than he expected after two years of Mydei giving him the cold shoulder.

But what if Cyrene breaks up again and decides to go back to him? Mydei is fairly sure Phainon wouldn’t hesitate to return to the girl’s embrace. The thought of being reduced to a band-aid on Phainon’s heart makes him hesitate.

So he decides to at least enjoy Phainon’s company while he can—even if it means staying just a friend.

It's what he forces himself to believe when Sunday arrives, and Mydei definitely didn’t spend almost an entire hour wondering what to wear.

He ends up choosing his favorite rock band shirt—black, printed with a large, flaming red lance adorned with lightning bolts, the title *Lance of Fury* written in big, jagged letters. He pairs it with dark jeans, slightly torn at the thighs and knees—not enough to be inappropriate in a family environment, but enough to draw lingering glances from anyone interested. Knowing that some of the park’s attractions involve getting guests wet, he opts for his combat boots to avoid spending the entire day walking around in soaked sneakers.

Normally, he would also throw on some jewelry like necklaces and rings, but it doesn’t feel very fitting for a place that can send those flying away in the most radical rides. He then braids a few strands of hair at the side and lets the rest fall freely over his shoulders.

Concluding he looks decent enough—to hang out with a friend, obviously—he grabs his phone and heads toward the subway station.

Phainon lives on the other side of the city, so they plan to meet at the park’s entrance. When Mydei arrives at the station around ten in the morning, he’s immediately greeted by endless waves of guests and the screams coming from the attractions inside.

Mydei takes a moment to observe the enormous gates leading into the park. It’s his first time there as a guest, and the sensation is very different from coming here to work. Giant chimera sculptures stand alongside other secondary characters, like small, fluffy fairies and colorful

dromases. The cheerful song playing from the gate's speakers is loosely based on *The Awoo Firm's* opening, but it's getting old after having to perform it every weekend.

He settles onto one of the few benches near the entrance and pulls out his phone, slipping in his earbuds to listen to some music while he waits for Phainon—and to ease some of the anxiety about the day ahead.

When Phainon does arrive, though, Mydei has to take a double look to confirm he's the same person.

The only times he's seen Phainon outside of school were when he was dressed as Fig Stew, and although his field of vision hadn't helped much, he had noted that Phainon usually dressed pretty normally for a nerd—except that sponge yellow shirt he chose last Sunday, but Mydei thinks it was because he was too upset to care about his wardrobe choice that day. So he didn't expect anything too out of the ordinary.

Or rather, he didn't expect Phainon to show up dressed like he's about to attend a vampire meeting.

He's dressed in black from head to toe: a leather jacket over a black undershirt and matching pants. Hints of silver accent his belt and choker—the latter leaving a clear view of the sun tattoo on his neck. His moonlight hair is spikier than usual, styled slightly to the side, wild bangs framing his face freely, and it's a wonder how it still manages to look fluffy.

Phainon looks like he's stumbled into Evernight's wardrobe. And really, Evernight's wardrobe shouldn't suit him this well. It leaves Mydei's throat suddenly dry.

It only takes Phainon a few seconds of scanning the entrance area to spot Mydei frozen on the bench and walk over to him with an unfairly handsome smile.

"Hey. Did you wait long?" Phainon Mydei snaps himself out of his dumbfounded state and stands up, taking out his earbuds and slipping them alongside his phone into his back pocket. The very obvious once-over Phainon gives him does nothing good for his heart.

"No, I just—you're wearing *eyeliner*?" Mydei blurts out, eyebrows arching now that Phainon is close enough. He figures Phainon didn't bring his glasses since they're mostly for reading—and could easily get damaged on a ride.

Phainon lifts his gaze to Mydei's face—Mydei pointedly refuses to think about how long that look lingered on his thighs—his lips curving into a sheepish smile.

"Does that mean I exaggerated?" he asks, scratching the back of his neck.

"It means you look like a lost member of *My Chimerical Romance*."

Phainon tilts his head almost cutely—a sharp contrast to his current look.

"Should I take that as a compliment?"

Mydei bites the inside of his cheek. Of course the nerd has no idea what he's referring to. Sure, he'd thought their style was cool a few years ago, but he'd stopped caring once he got older.

Still, seeing his crush dressed like that definitely awakens some long-forgotten corner of his brain. He fidgets slightly.

"… It looks fine." Mydei manages to mutter.

Phainon lets out a lighthearted laugh.

"Thank you. You look good, too," he shoots back, and Mydei has to avert his gaze to keep his cool.

This is way worse than interacting with him as a chimera.

*It's just a totally normal compliment,* Mydei reassures himself. *A very normal thing for friends to do.*

"Are we going in or not?" Mydei crosses his arms, jerking his chin toward the park gates. He hopes they can move on and stop exchanging flattery already.

"As you wish," Phainon chuckles.

They head to the gates, where Phainon presents his monthly pass. The park attendant picks up a small, round stamp and presses it onto the backs of their hands—a simple procedure to show the staff that the guests have already presented their tickets and lose their right of reentry once they leave.

Mydei is glad he never went out of his way to talk to any staff members besides Mr. Reca or the other mascots; visiting as a guest could easily expose him otherwise. He knows the manager spends most of the day inside his office, so he feels fairly safe in that regard.

The same can't be said for Phainon.

As soon as they reach the main plaza, a few eyes are already drawn to him.

"Now might be a good time to put that plan of yours to use," Mydei says as he watches a small group start to gather.

Unsurprisingly, Lilgui is at the forefront again. She'd been broadcasting her visit and immediately stops when someone points in their direction.

"Mhm, better to deal with that issue right away, right?" Phainon seems a bit too relaxed for Mydei's liking. It makes him crease his brows in suspicion as Lilgui approaches them.

"Oh my gosh, guys, take a look at who's here again today!" Lilgui exclaims, framing herself with Phainon in the background. Mydei steps aside, careful not to get caught in the stream.

She then turns to Phainon directly as a crowd of curious onlookers gathers around. Lilgui cheerfully introduces herself as a streamer—it wouldn't surprise Mydei if Phainon has no idea who she is. The redhead keeps going.

"Excuse me, you're Khaslana, aren't you?" Lilgui barely gives him time to answer. "Can you give me a quick interview about your involvement in Fig Stew's Easter egg?"

"Hey, everyone." Phainon smiles at the phone's camera with a small wave, then turns that same smile toward the streamer. Mydei can hear a few girls in the crowd swooning over it. Well, it seems he's become a celebrity for more than just Fig Stew's rumor.

Now Mydei wishes he had dressed a bit more nerdy today.

"I'm sorry to disappoint, but I have nothing to do with the Easter egg," Phainon begins, drawing a chorus of disbelieving noises from the crowd. "Fig Stew is just a good friend of mine. I'm not its crush by any means."

Wow. So he really plans on reaffirming what he already told the fans at school? That clearly didn't work last time.

"No way! No one hugs someone that intimately if they're just friends!" the brunette with pigtails who's always hanging around Lilgui exclaims.

"Yeah! There has to be something you're not telling us!" someone else accuses.

Mydei certainly chose a good day to call in sick.

"Well…" Phainon trails off, scratching his chin thoughtfully. "I was not expecting to reveal it like that, but if it'll calm you guys down a bit…"

Everyone around them falls silent, waiting expectantly.

"Fig Stew was kindly consoling me that day because I was heartbroken," Phainon says so casually that it leaves everyone—including Mydei—slightly stunned. "But things have already settled down. I couldn't be his secret love interest when I'm already dating someone."

*What?*

Mydei snaps his head toward him so fast his neck almost cracks, eyes wide with disbelief and jaw hanging open. What in the world is Phainon talking about? He surely isn't back together with Cyrene!

It has to be a lie.

But the way Phainon sounds so earnest sends a knot of dread tightening quickly in Mydei's gut.

The crowd erupts in murmurs.

“I don’t believe it!”

“It’s clearly a distraction…”

Mydei’s stare pierces Phainon just as those cerulean eyes land on him with a mischievous glint.

“It’s not a lie,” Phainon says calmly. “In fact, my date is right there.”

*What?* Mydei repeats mentally as he looks around—because surely Phainon can’t be gesturing toward him. Surely there must be someone beside him, or behind him…

When every pair of eyes settles on him instead, Mydei’s mind grinds to a halt.

*By Nikador’s immortal corpse.*

Phainon has just declared to everyone—*including Lilgui’s thousand viewers*—that they’re dating.

The realization hits so fast it leaves him lightheaded, the world tilting beneath his feet.

“Who is this guy?”

“Hey, he’s pretty good-looking…”

“Huh?? So it was really a fake clue?”

“Guys! Calm down, the day barely started!” Lilgui tries to restore order by ringing her signature gong. How she manages to carry it around everywhere remains a mystery. “There’s still hope! We can accompany Fig Stew again after the show and search for new clues.”

If only they knew Fig Stew would be partially absent today.

“So there’s still hope for my Butterfly Cake ship to sail…” the brunette girl sighs in relief.

“It would be weird for Fig Stew to be interested in a human, anyway,” someone shrugs.

“That being said, I’m sorry to bother you and your date, Khaslana. I hope you understand how eager we are to see the curse’s conclusion!” Lilgui gives Phainon a small bow, and he answers with a half-smile.

“It’s fine. I get it,” Phainon says before excusing himself from the crowd, stepping toward a still-frozen Mydei. “Now, if you’ll excuse us, we’ll be on our way.”

As he speaks, Phainon unceremoniously places a hand on the small of Mydei’s back. The touch sends a jolt straight up his spine, and Phainon guides him deeper into the park with ease—mostly because Mydei’s body has turned into a near-lifeless husk after the reveal.

Phainon planned to escape Fig Stew’s curse spotlight by claiming they were on a date. Every damned second Mydei spent convincing himself not to call their hangout a date now makes

him feel utterly stupid.

How is he even supposed to react to that?

It takes a few seconds for Mydei to recover his voice.

“Phainon. Do you want to get punched?” he says in resignation, still unable to believe his friend would resort to such measures just to shut down the rumor about his involvement in the Easter egg.

“I’m sorry, Mydei… If I had told you beforehand, I’m sure you would’ve never agreed,” Phainon says. His tone is apologetic, though there’s a faint hint of playfulness underneath.

He’s right. Mydei would never have agreed—because the last thing he wants is to pretend to be on a date with his own crush.

*I’m dealing with some divine punishment here.*

“You can drop the act,” Mydei says, even though he makes no move to pull away from Phainon’s touch. “They’re already far behind us.”

Phainon stays quiet for a moment. Then, instead of backing off, he leans closer—close enough that his voice drops into a whisper.

“I don’t think so,” he murmurs. “Someone’s still following us. Looks like not everyone bought it.”

“What—” Mydei tries to look over his shoulder, but Phainon stops it with a hand to his chin.

Mydei’s breath hitches, his pulse quickening by the second. They’re close. *Too close*. Phainon’s usual vanilla scent mingles with something else Mydei can’t quite place—something stronger, huskier, enough to cloud his senses.

“Don’t look,” Phainon murmurs. His palm moves on Mydei’s back, tracing slow, soothing circles as if to calm him down. It almost distracts him from the more pressing issue. “Mydei… do you think you can play along for a while? Maybe they’ll give up if they believe I was telling the truth.”

*No,* Mydei thinks. *Because I wouldn’t be lying.*

“I can’t,” Mydei says firmly, turning his gaze away from those impossibly blue irises.

Phainon wordlessly retracts his hand from Mydei’s chin, the motion on his back stopping altogether.

“Is the idea really that disgusting to you?” he asks, his voice unable to fully hide the dejection beneath it.

*No.* The problem is the exact opposite.

*It's everything I want.*

"Phainon, you just announced live that we are on a date," Mydei tries to reason. "It could reach people we know."

He's sure Castorice and the girls accompany Lilgui's content. The gossip surely will fall on Cyrene's ears sooner or later, and it might erupt in a new fight between her and Phainon—this time the pink-haired girl would be certain in directing her anger toward Mydei for entertaining such folly.

"Ah…" Phainon's voice drops to something almost unsettling.

The shift makes Mydei look at him again, surprised to see a darker glint overtaking his usually radiant features.

"You're worried about being found out by—"

He trails off, cutting himself short. Then Phainon shakes his head, wild silver bangs falling over his eyes, as if whatever name he was about to say no longer deserves to be spoken.

"Never mind." Though his lips curve into something resembling a smile, it carries none of its usual cheerfulness. "I understand. But look—I'm not asking us to do anything intimate. If we at least look like we're having fun together, I'm sure we can pass as discreet in front of those fans."

He hesitates, then adds, "And if we're found out… well, you can blame me."

Phainon pauses, as if weighing Mydei's silence. Then he offers him a half-smile—a pale echo of his signature brightness.

"What do you say, Mydei?" he asks softly. "Just for one day… can we be happy together?"

It's a strange choice of words.

It almost doesn't sound like Phainon is still talking about the Fig Stew situation. Yet it has to be. There's no other context in which it would make sense—because Phainon doesn't like him that way. This is just an act.

So why does Mydei want to cling to those words so badly?

Until now, he had never thought he would have the chance to be close to Phainon like this—like he belonged there, even if it was just a lie on Phainon's side.

Because Mydei could never pretend his feelings weren't real.

*Even short relationships can create lifelong memories.*

Surely Hephaestion hadn't meant this short. But if this is all Mydei will ever get, can he be selfish just this once and tend to his restrained heart? If Phainon is really offering him this chance…

Is it so wrong to want to accept it?

“O… okay,” Mydei says so quietly he’s almost unsure if his voice actually went through.

“… Really?” The storm clouding Phainon’s expression slowly drifts away, as if Mydei's acceptance brought the sunlight back with it.

Mydei closes his eyes and creases his brows. He can’t look at him right now—not when his heart is plummeting this hard.

“Already backing down on your own proposal?”

“No—!” Phainon nearly shouts, catching Mydei off guard. He quickly lowers his voice, a faint flush creeping up his cheeks. “I mean— I’m glad. Thank you, Mydei.”

“You owe me one,” Mydei can’t help but scoff.

“Sure, I’ll do anything you want!” Phainon replies eagerly, and the urge to ruffle his hair hits Mydei all at once.

*Wait a minute.*

If this is a date now…

Doesn’t that mean he has the right to do it?

Phainon freezes when Mydei slowly and gently lifts his hand and places it on top of his head. The strands are smooth and silky beneath his fingers, even styled like this—just as Mydei had imagined after all this time. He threads his fingers through the wild bangs, combing them back slightly.

“Good,” Mydei says, voice low but steady. “Now let’s get going, mhm?”

The dumbfounded look Phainon gives him makes Mydei huff out a chuckle. He lowers his arm and slips his hands into his pockets, resuming his walk at a pace slow enough to give Phainon time to recover and catch up with hurried steps, whining about the “surprise attack.”

Well. Mydei, at least, would try to enjoy it while he could.

The first thing they do is queue for the Dragon’s Lair—a rollercoaster themed around Toasty’s Dragon home, a large cave beneath a sleeping volcano that sprouted an enormous tree with golden leaves in its slumber. Mydei has been eager to try it ever since he first saw the park map on his first day as a mascot.

The ride starts at the base of the volcano, plunging into a cave section before climbing up around the tree in sinuous drops and loops. There are fewer people at the moment, since most guests are still gathered around the main plaza for the mascot show, but they still have to wait a while in line.

“Isn’t this a bit too much on an empty stomach?” Phainon asks as they watch the colorful carts run along the track, the guests’ screams echoing as background noise. He looks a little paler than usual.

“Getting scared already?” Mydei teases, leaning on the metal fence with a smirk.

“I’ve never been more than two meters off the ground…” Phainon replies, sounding a bit anxious.

Mydei tilts his head, arching an eyebrow at him.

“I thought you had already been to the park.”

“Well, I didn’t go on any extreme rides. I mostly visited the animal’s area and played at the game booths…”

“Oh, really…?” Mydei can already feel a grin forming on his lips.

“I’m not sure I like your tone, Mydei…” Phainon fidgets, flicking his gaze between him and the coaster.

To his misfortune, Mydei is very fond of extreme rides. Kremnos has some large parks, and he used to visit them quite often with his friends.

“Don’t worry—you’ll survive,” Mydei assures him, though he’s very interested in seeing how Phainon will react to the ride.

The queue moves forward a little more, and as Mydei steps ahead, he nearly trips when Phainon puts both hands around him on the fence he was leaning onto.

“What’s that about?” Mydei asks confusedly as Phainon pouts at him.

“I don’t like the way some people are staring at you.”

Mydei’s heart skips a beat. Was Phainon always this possessive? No wonder he was so affected by Cyrene dating someone else. He’s awfully invested for someone who’s just pretending to be his date.

“Are you sure they’re not looking at you?” Mydei suggests, because in his opinion, his companion is far more eye-catching than he is.

“They’re staring at your thighs, Mydei,” Phainon clarifies with a grimace.

Ah.

“Well, what do you expect me to do? It’s not like I can stop them from looking,” Mydei shrugs. Besides, the initial idea was to see if he could draw Phainon’s attention. Other people staring is just collateral damage, and he can’t say he cares about that.

Phainon doesn't look pleased with his response. He inches a little closer, and Mydei almost feels like caged prey.

"…Do you mind if I hug you?"

Mydei releases a breath he hadn't realized he was holding. The warmth seeping into his body definitely doesn't come from the artificial volcano around them. They've been talking so casually that he almost forgot they should pretend to date.

And a little touching should be fine in those circumstances, right?

Mydei gives a small nod, trying to sound unwavering. "Watch your hands."

Phainon's grim expression softens, an amused hum escaping him.

"Yes, sir."

However, nothing could have prepared Mydei for the way Phainon chose to do it. He slips his arms loosely around Mydei's waist from behind, pressing his back against the silver-haired student's firm chest. It makes him painfully aware of how broad Phainon's shoulders are, his head spinning at the realization. Both of Phainon's hands come to rest clasped just above his stomach.

"Is this alright?" Phainon murmurs, his face settling between Mydei's neck and shoulder. The sensation sends a shiver down Mydei's spine that he silently prays Phainon doesn't notice.

Mydei is almost glad he's being partially held; otherwise, his legs might give up on him. It's far from alright—having Phainon against him like that is way different from hugging him through layers of plush from Fig Stew's costume.

It's infinitely better, warm and cozy to the point that he thinks he might be purring if he were a cat. He has to stop himself from leaning into the touch, suddenly unsure of what to do with his free arms. There's a growing urge to place his palms over Phainon's, but he shuts it down by burying his hands in his pockets.

Phainon's heartbeat against his back is fast in a way that almost mirrors his own.

*Why are you so nervous?* Mydei wonders, because until now, Phainon has been treating the date as a trivial necessity. Maybe he hadn't expected to actually need physical closeness to this extent. It's far from inappropriate, but anyone looking their way could tell this position isn't exactly fitting for two friends.

He only hopes it will not turn their friendship into something awkward afterwards.

"Mhm," Mydei grunts, not trusting his voice right now. He also hopes that, from this angle, Phainon can't see the rosy tint on his cheeks.

Phainon lets out a shaky breath, something filled with relief. Mydei can't bring himself to read too much into it, too caught in his own thoughts.

They stay like that for what feels like a long time—still, it isn't enough. Mydei is almost getting *too* relaxed in the position when a voice catches his attention.

"How many are you?" The park attendant in charge of the queue is speaking to a group of guests just ahead of them, apparently a family.

"There are five of us," a man replies. The attendant nods and politely asks them to wait for the next cart before glancing at the next people in line.

"There are still two seats available. Can the couple come forward?"

*Couple.*

Holy Titans, Mydei is not surviving this.

Phainon has to let him go so they can move forward, and Mydei tries to ignore the way his fingers linger a moment longer than necessary as they graze his hips. Though his mind is spiraling in silent panic, his pride won't let him show how much it affects him, so he follows the attendant, with Phainon close behind.

They're seated in the last cart of the ride. Phainon's uneasiness returns in full force as the attendant warns them about loose accessories and reminds everyone to keep their arms and legs inside the cart at all times.

"Mydei… Are you sure this is safe?" Phainon asks, his voice trembling slightly.

He looks so scared it's almost cute. It grounds Mydei a little, pushing their recent interaction in the queue to the back of his mind.

"We can drop off if you want," Mydei offers, because while he does find the idea of dragging Phainon onto extreme rides amusing, he's not about to take responsibility for any heart attacks.

"No," Phainon says in a small voice. "You wanted to ride it… I want you to have fun, too."

Mydei's chest lurches with affection. How can he be so sweet while terrified? The thought makes him want to comfort Phainon, but his thoughts are cut short when the coaster's bell rings, signaling that departure is imminent.

The big cart harness comes down and locks the passengers securely. Some are already praying out loud for their lives. A thunderous rumble echoes through the cave, and the artificial smoke thickens as if an eruption is imminent.

"No backing out now, haha…" Phainon laughs nervously beside him.

Mydei casts a side-eyed glance at him. He can't move much because of the harness across his chest, but his arms are free. Against his better judgment, he reaches for Phainon's hand between them and holds it tightly

*I'm here. Don't be afraid.*

Phainon immediately jolts, his wide-eyed gaze dropping to their linked hands. His skin is slightly cold to the touch—a sharp contrast to how warm he had been against Mydei just moments ago.

It works like a spell. Phainon's uneasiness melts away, replaced by an expression so tender it almost seems as if his eyes are glowing with adoration. Mydei's chest tightens; that's not the reaction someone who's merely pretending to date should have.

Is it his own desire for it to be real, making him imagine things that aren't there?

There's no time to ponder it, because the next second the cart is propelled forward along the track at enormous speed. Through harsh drops, sinuous curves, 360-degree loops, and piercing screams, Mydei and Phainon never let go of each other.



Turns out Phainon discovers he really enjoys radical rides.

“Can we go again? Please?” he pleads with a praying motion as they leave The Dragon’s Lair.

“There are other coasters in the park. We can come back later,” Mydei says, running his fingers through his hair to smooth it back to its natural form after the ride. Miraculously, Phainon’s hair has maintained its style.

Phainon pouts, following him like a kicked puppy. Mydei also enjoyed it, but sticking to the same queue for so much time isn’t very entertaining.

By the exit, there’s a photo booth. The image captures both of them on the steepest descent: Phainon screaming at the top of his lungs, while Mydei laughs, his wild hair flying across his face and even into his mouth.

Well, sometimes having long hair isn’t all that cool.

The image angle doesn’t reveal their linked hands, and Mydei thinks it's another photo he can keep with no prejudice.

“You’re spending fifty thousand credits on a photo?” Phainon asks in shock as the shop clerk receives the payment and handles the file transfer to Mydei’s phone.

“So what? It’s a good memory to keep,” Mydei shrugs, not wanting to delve too deeply into the real meaning behind it.

“You’re literally eating your hair!” Phainon whines, pointing at the monitor. “And I look like I’m about to spit my soul out there.”

“I think it looks cute.” Mydei blurts out without much thought, ignoring Phainon’s first remark and too focused on the image now safely stored in his gallery. He smiles, thanks the clerk, and heads out, leaving a red-faced Phainon behind.

They manage to ride the Styxian Boat—an attraction themed around Gurgling Fish’s undersea reign—before lunchtime arrives. That means the mascot’s show is starting, and news of Fig Stew’s absence begins to spread, even to those not in the main plaza.

Though Mydei did tell the girls he wasn’t going to attend today’s shift, he hopes it doesn’t weigh too much on them.

“Uwahh! I want Fig Stew!” A small child cries out to their parents, who do their best to console them.

Mydei feels bad for the kid. Among Fig Stew’s fans, the children were always the ones he felt more at ease dealing with. Perhaps he should have thought twice before skipping.

“Huh? Fig Stew isn’t here?” Phainon asks mid-bite, surprised.

They are sitting near a food stall, filling their empty stomachs before heading to the next attraction. While Mydei chose to try the Imperator Dux Crépe, Phainon is digging into a Candied Apple pie.

*They’re right in front of you,* Mydei thinks.

“Did your friend ditch you?” he plays dumb, determined not to give himself away.

Phainon shoots him an awkward look.

“That sounds weird coming from someone who loves that chimera, you know,” He points out.

*Shit.*

Mydei is so used to being Fig Stew that he forgets he should act like a fan. He stiffens, swallowing his portion of the crépe.

“I do like it,” he says, taking a sip from his water bottle. “But the mascot is a real person. Something unexpected might have come up.”

Phainon stares at him intently, tapping his finger on the table.

“Mhm, maybe you’re right…” he takes another bite. “I just hope they’re alright.”

*They’re more than alright,* Mydei thinks.

After all, he’s on a—fake—date with his crush.

And he’s enjoying it way more than he imagined.

“Say, Mydei…” Phainon begins, bringing him back from his thoughts. “What do you think ‘*Awoo*’ means for a chimera?

Mydei almost chokes on his food. He coughs, hastily grabbing his water to gulp it down.

“Are you alright?” Phainon asks, concern creeping into his tone. Mydei raises a hand, asking for a moment to collect himself.

“Yeah,” Mydei replies, though his throat still feels raspy. “Where does that come from?”

He knows very well—but he can’t say it. Phainon scratches the back of his neck, seemingly unsure of how to explain.

“Well… Fig Stew said ‘*Awoo*’ to me last Sunday,” he says. “It sounded… kind of shy for some reason. I’ve been wondering what it means. From your reaction, is it something I should be worried about?”

Damn it, Phainon wasn't supposed to be curious about it. Mydei hoped he would eventually forget about it.

He clears his throat, shifting uncomfortably.

"It can mean many things," Mydei explains, trying to sound casual and not give too much away. "It depends mostly on the tone. Kind of like how a cat tries to communicate with humans."

"I see…" Phainon hums thoughtfully. After a brief pause, his lips curve into a small smile. "You really are a chimera expert, Mydei."

Mydei crosses his arms, averting his gaze from those bright cerulean irises.

"Finish your food already. We still have a lot of places to go."

Phainon laughs, the sound always pleasantly echoing in Mydei's ears.

"Okay."

They rode two more coasters, including the one themed around Butterfly Cake's underworld, Sea of Flowers. The line is the longest they've faced yet. The track wasn't as extreme as The Dragon's Lair, but the thrill made the wait worthwhile. They also stopped at the Aquila's Sky Drop, where Phainon took his time retelling the story of a kid who nearly fainted there last Sunday, and tried smaller attractions like Gummy Roll's Mirror House and Cyrup's Teacups.

This last one had them both competing to see which one could spin the teacup faster, and they had to take a fifteen-minute break to steady their dizziness afterwards.

Between rides, Mydei caught a glimpse of Krenabis—or rather, Hyacine—near a balloon stall, snapping pictures with some children. For a moment, he wondered if they had noticed him and Phainon pretending to be a couple, but he wisely stayed back. Any approach could reveal too much; Phainon might recognize them, and Mydei already has a lot of explaining to do later.

Mydei buys photos at absurd prices for every ride that offers the option, set on filling his phone with memories from their date. After the third one, he stops in his tracks when he hears a photo click from his side.

"What are you doing?" he asks, arching an eyebrow at Phainon, who has his phone out and aimed at him.

"I'm taking pictures of you—for free," Phainon says with a grin, clearly amused by Mydei's bewildered expression.

"… Why?"

"Because I'm tired of seeing my date being extorted by those booths," Phainon says, lowering his voice just a little. "And I want some for me, too."

Though Mydei's insides flutter, he somehow manages to keep his composure.

"You could've asked for it. I can share the ones I bought," he says.

Phainon hums, staring fondly at something on his phone screen. Mydei's curiosity spikes, but Phainon pockets the device before he can get a peek.

"Why not both? We can go through all of them after." Phainon suggests. Mydei thinks it's a good idea. Phainon might be oblivious to why he's keeping the photos in the first place, but he doesn't see a reason to deny the offer.

As the day goes on, Phainon keeps finding excuses to steal touches here and there, supposedly because "someone could still be watching." Except for his possessiveness over Mydei's rather eye-catching choice of pants, it's all bullshit. Mydei knows it by now, but he doesn't have the heart to call it out when he's enjoying the attention.

When they visit The Master Cat-Thief Ghost Tower, the track consists of a walk around the building filled with jump scares and even some employees dressed as monsters and ghosts.

"Those are from the Halloween special years ago," Mydei explains as they wait for their turn in line. The entrance is a large reception room in the tower's lounge. "Master Cat-Thief heard there was an immensurable treasure hidden in the depths of the tower and sneaked in to steal it. Turns out the tower was haunted, and the treasure was nothing more than a lure for her to play with ghost chimeras."

"That sounds adorable." Phainon chuckles beside him, their shoulders touching. He has a fond smile gracing his features as he looks at Mydei. "You sound so happy when you talk about the show. I love hearing about it."

It's becoming increasingly hard to ignore the way Phainon makes Mydei forget how to breathe. The more time passes, the more he wants this to be real.

They enter the tower, the path poorly illuminated as the ambience tries to recreate a full moon night. Through monsters creeping from open holes, mice screeching, and projections of ghosts, Mydei isn't afraid—he's more interested in how faithful the recreation is to the show. Phainon, however, clings to his arm, swearing that those things are too scary for him to let go.

Mydei saw how Phainon is when really scared—The Dragon's Lair is a perfect example.

"Dumbass," Mydei eventually says, motioning for Phainon to come closer as he puts an arm around his shoulder.

"My hero." Phainon bats his eyelashes at him in a dreamy tone.

Mydei tsks, resuming their walk along the dark path. The only thing haunting him is when this dream will end.

It has Mydei wondering why Phainon is being so insistent in treating it as a date when everyone has already been fooled—including his own heart. Maybe he's just being too

stubborn after saying they should do it for the entire day around the park.

As sunset approaches, the weather changes drastically. It's summer, so it isn't rare for the sky to cloud over the span of a few minutes before heavy rain.

They are on their way to the game booths—set on competing over it—when Phainon notices a loud thunder.

"Seems like it will rain soon. Do you want to go back, Mydei?" Phainon asks softly.

Mydei glances at one of the clocks around the park, and a feeling of dread crawls over his stomach. There isn't much time before it closes, even if they choose to wait for the rain to pass somewhere.

It means that their day together is coming to an end.

*So that's it, huh?*

Tomorrow things will go back to normal. They will be back into the world where Mydei and Phainon are just friends, and the person whom Phainon likes isn't him anymore.

Well, it never was actually. From the very start, Phainon made it clear how it was just a pretend act—even if he got a little too invested along the way.

The truth is that there was never a future beyond this date for them.

All that will be left are the memories of a sweet lie.

Before Mydei can think of an answer, the first droplets start to fall. It takes only a few seconds for the rain to turn into a downpour.

"Shit," Mydei curses.

They quickly take cover under the closest shelter, a closed-off cotton candy stall. It's small and doesn't offer much protection once the rain reaches full force.

How ironic that Mydei avoided religiously every single attraction that could get them wet only to end the day like this.

"Damn… That's summer rain to you." Phainon chuckles beside him.

"Mhm," Mydei grunts, crossing his arms and leaning against the stall. They managed to avoid getting drenched just in time.

The rain turns the park into a wasteland. Most of the guests gather in the indoor food court while it pours heavily, since most of the attractions have had to pause their operation for safety reasons. Only the restaurants and a few booths remain open.

"Do you think it will stop soon?" Phainon eventually asks, having pulled his phone out. It's as if he's worried about the time.

“In a hurry?” Mydei teases, though his heart feels heavy. To think their date—fake, he reminds himself—would end like this.

“No,” Phainon shakes his head. “I just wanted to beat your ass at the shooting stall before we leave.”

“Like hell you would.” Mydei scoffs, rolling his eyes.

“Well, at least I’m not like a cat afraid of the rain. You ran here in record time.”

“I’m not afraid of the rain.” Mydei frowns, baffled at the accusation. He just doesn’t like walking in wet clothes.

“Sure, sure…” Phainon grins.

A funny feeling begins bubbling in Mydei’s guts.

He hums thoughtfully. “What about you? Are you fine with walking under a storm?”

Phainon tilts his head at him. “Of course. I’m not made of sugar.”

Mydei’s plan is set. Without warning, he grabs Phainon’s hand and pulls him outside the stall—into the heavy rain.

“Hey—!” Phainon yelps, almost tripping as he hurriedly pockets his phone before it gets wet.

When Mydei steps out, the rain almost instantly soaks his clothes.

“If the rain isn’t a bother, let’s get going then,” Mydei says with a smirk, pleased at the shocked expression on his date’s face.

“You’re enjoying this way too much, aren’t you?” he mutters weakly, stunned.

“Maybe a little,” Mydei admits teasingly.

Phainon’s hand is still linked in his as they fall into step toward anywhere—it doesn’t really matter right now. The park’s lights flicker to life, signaling that the day is winding down—and with it, their pretend date.

Mydei had more fun than he expected. Even if they’d stopped being followed way earlier, the experience was too nice for him to put a stop to. So he decided to let it drag on until Phainon called it quits.

But it never came.

Now, having spent such a joyous day with the person he’s longed for after all this time, it’s only natural that he doesn’t want it to end.

He eventually stops, and with him so does Phainon. The summer rain keeps pouring over them, sticking his hair onto his eyes and nose. It surprises him how warm it is, and how it

doesn't bother him in the slightest getting wet from head to toes for once.

"Mydei…" Phainon calls quietly, and even though the rain makes it hard to hear, Mydei turns to him almost instantly.

He can't contain a smile at the sight of the eyeliner stain coming down Phainon's cheeks. His hair finally lost its carefully styled shape, now falling closer to its usual form. Mydei lifts a hand to his face, gently rubbing away the smudge from his face with his thumb.

Even under the rain, Phainon's skin is so tender. He already misses the closeness they shared, something he'll never be able to taste again.

It hurts, thinking it's coming to an end. But at the same time, he's happy to have Phainon for himself—even if for only a day.

Phainon's palm comes up and rests over his cheek in a featherlight touch, just above the diamond tattoo beneath his eye. Mydei instinctively leans onto it. Is he pretending still? He's too good at it, really. If Mydei didn't know it was all a lie, he would have fallen for it completely—just as his heart has already done.

"Mydei, I…" Phainon's voice trembles, faltering as he continues, but an alarm rings sharply in the back of Mydei's mind.

*Don't fall for it. Whatever you think is happening, it's not real.*

Phainon is too gentle to end it now. And Mydei is too selfish to stop himself. Yet he can't bear to hear words meant for someone else—words he knows are never truly his.

Outside this park, Phainon doesn't belong to him.

*Do you see me?*

*I'm not her. I'll never be.*

But here, now, Phainon is with him. For him. Just for today. And if he can grant himself one last selfish wish…

Mydei leans in before Phainon can speak, before hesitation can take hold. The rain lashes over them, warm droplets dripping down their faces and blurring the world around them. He doesn't think about the consequences—only about the way his chest is so full of emotions he can't begin to put into words. His eyes flutter shut. His lips press gently as he kisses Phainon—tenderly, lovingly.

Mydei doesn't know what he expects—maybe to be pushed away, maybe a shocked expression. Perhaps even a final sentence to their healing friendship. This crosses a line, and they both know it.

He's braced for anything, really—but definitely not for Phainon pressing his lips back against his, their hands finding anchor in one another's waists like they've been afloat the sea, lost for too long and finally finding their way back home.

Because it’s what it feels like to kiss Phainon—home. A place he wants to return to every day, not just once in a fleeting moment.

Their drenched bodies press together, and for a moment, it’s as if the rain itself melts away. Phainon’s hands trace up Mydei’s back, sliding to the nape of his neck with a touch so full of charge it has Mydei inhaling softly, tilting his head to deepen the kiss, desperate to absorb everything being given to him.

Phainon is warmer than the rain. Warmer than the sun. Evernight was right—he’s the dawn itself.

Maybe Mydei should have declined the offer to turn this into a date from the beginning.

Because after a day so perfect, after feeling Phainon’s tender touches, hearing his sweet words, and tasting those impossibly soft lips, he’s almost certain he can’t call it a simple crush anymore.

Thankfully, the rain hides his thundering heartbeat and washes away any trace of tears. In these last moments, all he can do is hope for a miracle only a Titan could grant.

*If Oronyx hears prayers…*

*Please, let this moment stretch into eternity.*

Chapter End Notes

I spent my entire birthday wondering if I should split this chapter into two. The original cut was around the date thing reveal, but I thought it might hurt the scene in it's entirety.

So here we are, with the longest chapter.

It was a really fun and hard write. I hope you enjoyed it! Though the ending is more on the bittersweet side, it's more because there's still too much to be said between those two.

On another completely unrelated topic; I just discovered that magic button that sends comments to your inbox. It's now way easier to reply to them! (and I'm so sorry to those I don't, sometimes I feel too shy to reply once some days have passed)

Next chapter, there will be more Phainon POV... We are nearing the end, but there's still much to solve!
See you ~

# Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

After their kiss, Phainon is left do deal with the confused mix of emotions that settles over his friendship with Mydei.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

One day. One day would be everything he had to date Mydei—even if it was a pretend one.

Phainon figured that, since Mydei was already in a relationship, he would never agree to something like that unless Phainon pushed a few buttons. If Phainon could guarantee that it would be harmless and entirely born out of his need to put an end to the Fig Stew rumor, then maybe he could finally have Mydei to himself for an entire day.

And if, by any chance, what Evernight implied turned out to be true—that she planned on ending their relationship in a few weeks—then perhaps Phainon could use this date as a trial, a chance to prove himself as a worthy boyfriend candidate to Mydei, if he even managed to get the Kremnoan to entertain the idea.

It had still been a hard task to keep his jealousy in check. Phainon made sure to insist that Mydei have lunch with him alone on the rooftop—bless Ms. Tribios—all week long, solely for the sake of keeping him away from the pale pink-haired girl.

Thankfully, Mydei didn't question anything, too focused on paying his debt off.

Which was honestly kind of weird.

Of course, Phainon knew he had won it two years ago. Mr. Ratio himself had proudly shown Mydei's exam scores and congratulated them on the success of the tutoring. Phainon was glad he had been able to help, but even more so that he would get to taste the Kremnoan's cooking.

However, since *that* incident, he has chosen not to mention it again, burying that bet in the depths of his mind.

One could imagine his surprise when Mydei decided, completely out of the blue, that he should pay his debt.

And, coincidentally, it happened just when Phainon needed it the most.

Talk about fate.

Needless to say, Phainon felt like he was in heaven during that particular week they were able to spend together.

They went back to talking casually and even shared some friendly banter. It rekindled Phainon's hope, flickering back to life after so long. Although he forced it down and told himself to be satisfied with Mydei's friendship, there was still that egregious voice in the back of his head, stirring up that ugly feeling every time Phainon remembered Evernight's existence.

He wasn't sure why they were keeping their relationship a secret, but he knew Mydei was a very private person when it came to his personal life. Even learning about his hobbies beyond cooking had been a tiring quest two years ago.

As such, Phainon chose not to question it. The less they mentioned Evernight, the better for his own sanity.

Mydei was finally back in his life—as a friend—and Phainon couldn't risk losing that over a feeling like jealousy, something that could never change the fact that Mydei already had a girlfriend.

However, that didn't mean Phainon refrained from trying to cater to the Kremnoan's tastes, if only to make it seem more authentic.

Researching "emo" and gothic fashion was an… experience in itself. Evernight was always dressed in edgy clothes, black accessories all over her uniform, and even carried a large black umbrella on sunny days, as if she were allergic to sunlight.

While it was a bit weird, it wasn't like he could judge her fashion sense—his friends often said he dressed like an uncle in his forties, all plaid shirts and button-downs. Either that, or the usual secondhand embarrassment whenever he wore his favorite yellow T-shirt with Droma's purple pants—an outfit Cyrene had made him promise never to show Mydei, if Phainon didn't want to traumatize him.

So if Evernight's style was what caught Mydei's attention, Phainon was determined to dive right into it.

He picked up the only black clothes he owned—remnants from one of Cyrene's shopping sprees she loved dragging him into—along with a black choker Cipher had given him as a joke during an uneventful Secret Santa. He styled his hair to a more edgy shape, letting it look spikier than usual.

If his research was anything to go by, makeup would also be required. Phainon wasn't fond of the idea of painting his nails black, so he asked his mother to lend him her eyeliner. She kindly offered not only the eyeliner but also to apply it herself, lest he end up looking like a panda.

There's a mischievous hint to her expression as she applies it, as if she knows far too much about what this is really about, even though Phainon only said he was going out with a friend.

"Will they be coming for dinner, sweetheart?" she asks midway through it.

Phainon does his best not to blink, the sensation around his eyes feeling a bit off. It almost feels like a thin layer of clay has been applied.

"I don't think so, Mom," he replies. There are no plans to keep the pretend date going outside the park, so he hadn't even considered the possibility.

Audata hums, unconvinced. "If they change their mind, dinner's at seven. If your charm doesn't win them over, my cooking surely will."

She winks at him, and Phainon can't help but feel flustered.

If only his mom knew how good a cook Mydei is, she would most likely fall for him just as easily as he did.

He hadn't told anyone about his intent to turn this hangout into a date—not even Cyrene. Somehow, he had the feeling she would give him an earful the moment she found out, but what else could he do?

It was almost a desperate measure, and the Fig Stew excuse fit like a glove. He would apologize to the poor mascot for using them like that when the time came.

Any explanations he might owe could wait until tomorrow.

With his mind set, Phainon walked to the bus stop, joy and anxiousness tangled in his gut. If everything goes wrong, Mydei could very well punch him and snap the fragile strings their friendship was balanced on.

Yet the moment Phainon's eyes found Mydei's figure at the park entrance… he knew he would give anything to be on an actual date with him.

So he pressed forward with his plan, forcing himself to swallow the bitterness tied to Mydei's obvious hesitation about Evernight finding out. She wasn't even that serious about their relationship, so why did Mydei care so much?

Still, it wasn't his place to question it—partly because he feared the answer.

Phainon was relieved that Mydei didn't show the same disgust he had two years ago at the mere suggestion of pretending to date him—perhaps because the terms made it clear this was just a fake scenario meant to help a friend.

Yet there was still that flicker of hope, burning a little brighter.

Although a few suspicious fans followed them for a while, they grew bored within minutes

after the pair joined their first queue, which meant Phainon could have put an end to it at any moment.

As if he would ever do that.

Phainon had spent years daydreaming about going out with his crush, and the only thing that could put an end to the experience was Mydei himself, if he eventually grew annoyed by it. So long as Mydei kept playing along and seemed to be enjoying himself, Phainon would indulge in it completely.

Some things were kind of hard to ignore, though.

*Mainly those pants.*

Phainon didn't think it was possible to feel both gratitude and anger toward a piece of clothing at the same time. Because holy fuck, did Mydei actually look in a mirror before going out? He had never taken the Kremnoan for a show-off, but now he had doubts about the rest of Mydei's wardrobe.

The small thorns would have been harmless on anyone else's legs. But on him, Phainon could catch tiny glimpses of red beneath the fabric—the same shade as Mydei's tattoos—and it sent his mind on a completely different trip than the park.

*His tattoos go all the way down there.*

And boy, didn't this realization make his thoughts run wild.

Phainon's saving grace was that they were in a public place, which allowed him to keep his arousal in check by channeling his frustration toward the not-so-subtle onlookers whose curiosity had also been piqued by that incriminating piece of clothing.

Who would have guessed that his first move would be driven by possessiveness over his pretend date? If Phainon couldn't hide Mydei from those thirsty gazes, then at the very least, he would make it clear that this beautiful young man was his—even if only for a day.

That thought alone gave him enough courage to engage in a more intimate setting, ignoring even the fear of the upcoming rollercoaster ride. And to say he was surprised at how receptive Mydei had been was an understatement.

At some point, everything began to flow so naturally that Phainon himself started to get carried away. Mydei not only looked like he was having fun—he looked truly happy, perhaps for the first time since they had known each other.

Every time they held hands sent a jolt of electricity through Phainon's body. Mydei kept allowing Phainon's touches to the point that he grew greedy. Letting go was becoming harder and harder, each touch lingering a little longer than it should. And when Phainon hugs him, he's carried back to those peaceful days of their tutoring two years ago.

After all this time, they still fit perfectly together.

It's enough to make him forget about the world outside the park—about Evernight, graduation, and even the fact that he still hadn't managed to introduce Mydei to his favorite mascot chimera.

The only thing that really matters is at this exact moment in his arms, as they queue for an attraction Phainon hasn't even been paying attention to.

When it starts to rain, that's when the realization that their date is coming to an end finally sinks in. Needless to say, Phainon wishes it could last longer. But how could it? Mydei is already taken—he can't just steal him away, even if he wants to.

He starts to worry about the time. His phone reads almost six p.m. If they leave soon enough, maybe they could make it to the dinner his mom had suggested earlier.

Would it be too weird to invite Mydei after everything they had done in the park? Nothing so far suggested their friendship would be damaged by it, so perhaps it could be understood simply as a way of thanking the Kremnoan for playing along.

Phainon doesn't get much time to dwell on the thought because soon after, Mydei's hand finds his, dragging him into the heavy rain.

Though baffled by the audacity, Phainon can't help but find the smugness in Mydei's features utterly adorable. And so he lets him have his way, each step a ripple across the few remaining minutes they still have together.

What would Mydei say if he knew Phainon hadn't been pretending at all during their date? If he discovered that Phainon had set this up out of jealousy—resenting his girlfriend, wishing he were the one in her place, and hoping that if they ever broke up, Mydei would turn to him simply because he was happy beside him, even for a fleeting moment.

It sounds so stupid, yet it gnaws at him from the inside out.

But… what if it wasn't only a single moment? What if he could stretch it, just a little longer? Whatever might happen, Phainon doesn't want to part ways just yet. Here, with Mydei's hand in his, only one thought repeats itself in his mind:

*Mydei, I don't want this to end.*

As he squeezes his palm, Mydei comes to a stop. The words tighten in Phainon's throat the more he tries to force them out.

*I wasn't pretending.*

All he can feel are the droplets of water against his skin and the frantic rhythm of his heart when Mydei's fingers brush his face. Phainon doesn't even remember he's wearing makeup until Mydei gently rubs away some smudges. He doesn't even care if he looks like a panda,

just as his mother warned him that morning.

His focus is entirely on those shining golden irises—a beacon of light beneath the summer rain.

Phainon doesn't understand the melancholy etched into Mydei's features, even as he smiles at him. How could he make it go away? Mydei's smile softens as he leans into Phainon's palm, as if using it as an anchor to this moment where only the two of them exist.

*I like you.*

Phainon's words are cut short when Mydei kisses him.

The world comes to a halt as the realization sinks in: *Mydei is kissing him.*

And suddenly, there are no more thoughts in his head, not when Mydei's lips fit perfectly against his, warm and soft enough to push all confusion aside. Phainon can't dwell on why his friend, who never showed any romantic interest and agreed only to a fake date, would kiss him.

All he knows is that this is something he has yearned for so long that there's no way he's going to just stand still.

So he returns the kiss with fervor, as if it were the first and the last—Titans forbid it should be the last, but what if it is?—and when Mydei melts into his embrace, when their lips move together with so much heat, Phainon realizes there's something slipping through the cracks of this situation.

How can they still call themselves friends after such a mind-blowing experience?

Phainon doesn't know how long it lasts—though he wishes it were forever—but eventually they part, the rain still tickling their faces.

Mydei's eyes are half-lidded, clouded with an underlying emotion Phainon's dazed mind almost wants to label as affection, while his gaze remains fixed on Phainon's lips as if he hasn't had enough yet.

Titans, how Phainon wants more too. But something holds them both back, even as they cling to each other as though they would fall if they let go.

Under the rain, with his hair damp and his slightly parted lips rosy and swollen from their kiss, Mydei is breathtaking. It isn't fair. How could Phainon ever think of giving up on this crush?

If Mydei harbors even the slightest feelings for him, Phainon wouldn't hesitate to steal him away from Evernight.

The moment slowly begins to crumble when he notices Mydei trembling slightly in his hold.

“Mydei… you’re shivering,” Phainon isn’t sure how his voice sounds—probably too strained—but he hopes the rain masks it to some extent.

He caresses Mydei’s cheek, and Mydei shuts his eyes tightly at the touch, his brows creasing. His feverish skin is starting to cool, and Phainon’s stomach twists wildly.

*Please don’t say you’re sorry.*

If Mydei admits the kiss was a mistake, that he somehow got carried away during their fake date, Phainon doesn’t know if he’ll survive.

*Don’t give me hope and then take it away.*

“Mydei—”

“We… should go.” Mydei says, his small voice nearly lost to the sound of the rain. His eyes open again, and the moisture there is impossible to read under the storm.

*Why do you look like you’re about to cry?*

Seeing Phainon frozen in place, he adds softly, “I’m getting cold.”

Even if the rain had been warm at first, the constant exposure to it, paired with the fierce wind, was bound to lower their body temperature.

“R—right…” Phainon stutters, slowly stepping back to give him space.

Mydei wraps his arms around himself, averting his gaze in an almost guarded way. Phainon knows it might not help much in this situation, but his jacket shields against the rain better than a soaked T-shirt.

He swiftly takes it off and drapes it over Mydei’s shoulders before the other can react or find an excuse.

“What—”

“Don’t worry about me,” Phainon assures with a smile. “I don’t get cold easily.”

On the contrary, Phainon still feels like a burning sun after everything that just happened. His heart continues to plummet wildly, his emotions scattered as though he might burst at any moment.

Mydei studies him for a second before giving a small nod, as though he doesn’t have it in him to argue. He buries himself in the jacket, and Phainon nearly breaks down over how cute it looks—a funny thing, because although they’re about the same size, the clothing around his shoulders somehow makes him seem smaller.

"… Thanks."

They walk back to the park's entrance in silence, each lost in their own thoughts. Phainon keeps stealing glances at Mydei the entire way, desperate to grasp anything that might reveal the meaning behind that kiss.

How he wishes he could read minds, just this once.

He's dying to ask about it, yet equally terrified of what Mydei might say. What if he feels guilty about betraying his girlfriend during a fake date? Or worse—what if he didn't enjoy it at all? Is Phainon a bad kisser? It was his first time, and he only did what felt natural—or…

Does Mydei really feel anything for him?

"I had fun today," Mydei says, his voice pulling Phainon back to reality.

Phainon blinks, realizing they've already reached the park's station. Mydei will be taking the subway home, while Phainon will have to wait for the next bus, since his neighborhood lies on the outskirts of Okhema.

At least the station has a wide roof they can use as shelter from the rain. Phainon avoids thinking about how Mydei is still holding onto his jacket tightly, even now that they're out of the downpour.

"Oh—uh, yeah. Me too," Phainon stammers, cringing at how awkward he sounds.

It's almost annoying how composed Mydei looks while he's very clearly having a mental breakdown.

Mydei gives a small hum, his lips faintly curving upward.

"You should look into a mirror when you get the chance," he says softly.

Phainon can only imagine the disaster around his eyes if the kids at the station, gaping at him, are any indication of how bad it is. At least the adults pretend not to notice before turning away to giggle.

*And you kissed me when I looked like that*, Phainon thinks, biting the inside of his cheek to keep himself from saying it out loud.

This elephant in the room needs some time to cool down before he can talk about it without having a heart attack.

Mydei's subway arrives soon after. He's already moving to return the jacket when Phainon holds it firmly over his shoulders.

"Keep it," he says. "It will help warm you up until you get home."

Mydei stares at him with widened eyes, his arms slowly slipping out of the jacket. There's a hint of frustration as he fidgets slightly.

"… I'll give it back tomorrow."

For all Phainon cares, he can keep it forever if he wants. Knowing Mydei is taking something from him home makes Phainon's insides flutter.

"Mhm." Phainon nods with a half-smile. "Get home safely, Mydei."

Mydei hesitates for a second before boarding, lips parted as if he still has something to say. When the subway's departure chime rings, he snaps out of it.

"You too," he says, stepping into the subway car.

Phainon waves as the subway propels forward on the rails, receiving a contained wave back before the vehicle disappears from his field of vision.

The way to his own home is a blur. He somehow manages to get on the right bus and step off at his neighborhood stop in full automatic mode.

Phainon still can't believe everything that happened today.

When he opens the front door, the smell of something delicious makes his stomach growl almost instantly. His parents are watching TV in the living room, and his mother is the first to greet him.

"Welcome, sweetheart," she chirps, but her smile quickly fades when she takes in his state. "Oh dear, what happened to you?"

She's off the sofa and reaching for him in an instant.

"And what kind of witchcraft is that on your face?" his father asks.

Audata immediately slaps his arm, earning a mumble of "kids these days" as he turns his attention back to his favorite show. Phainon can't help but chuckle at the scene.

"I got caught in the storm," he explains. The rain has stopped now, and though his hair and skin are nearly dry, his clothes remain drenched, clinging uncomfortably to him.

Audata cradles his cheeks with her palms.

"And what about your friend? Didn't they come to dinner?"

Oh, that. Phainon had wanted to invite Mydei, but he ended up far too confused about their actual relationship to ever remember.

"Not today, Mom," he says, trying to sound composed, though he's still too shaken to really

keep his tone steady. “But I’ll invite them next time.”

Audata frowns, but she knows her son too well to press him about it right now. She lets him off the hook with an exasperated, “You better,” and tells him to take a bath and eat before going to bed.

That’s exactly what Phainon does. And oh boy, he looks like he’s wearing that cartoon superhero mask—what was its name again? Batcake? It’s something to laugh about, and certainly not a face anyone would normally consider attractive enough to kiss.

*What did Mydei even see in me?*

The memory of their kiss makes his body heat up, and he quickly hops into the shower before he gets too excited about it.

Washing the eyeliner away is a battle in itself, but he emerges victorious after twenty minutes and with slightly swollen cheeks.

Back in his bedroom after dinner, he sits on the bed and picks up his phone. Luckily, the case kept most of the wetness away, and the device seems to be working properly now that he’s finished drying it.

Finally, alone in the quiet of his room, Phainon has time to think as he opens the messenger app to a very familiar chat. His thumb hovers over the keyboard, but he’s out of words as he glares at the screen.

There’s a growing restlessness at his core as he replays their date over and over in his mind.

*What if Mydei uses this day as an excuse to distance himself from me again?*

Honestly, Phainon had thought their friendship was untouched—at least until the kiss. They’d both had fun at the park, even if things had been more intimate than strictly necessary, and Mydei hadn’t seemed bothered by it the way he had two years ago.

What changed? Phainon has no idea. But hey, he’s not complaining. Not when Mydei is more at ease in his presence, to the point of actually enjoying it.

Everything had been fine. He’d gotten close to his crush again and managed to earn his friendship back—and then Mydei kissed him.

Titans above, he still can’t believe it. Even after dinner, after washing away the rain, it lingers. His mouth tingles at the mere memory of Mydei’s lips against his. An electric sensation floods his entire body with ecstasy as he recalls the touch.

Phainon’s fingers hover just above his bottom lip.

It felt *real*. As if Mydei truly wanted this.

Still, Phainon can't be entirely sure. And he doesn't know how he could confirm it without asking Mydei directly—and the thought terrifies him. He might finally face rejection, whether because Mydei already has a girlfriend or because Phainon is hallucinating some hidden meaning that isn't there.

He runs a hand through his hair in frustration, letting out a loud groan.

For Titans' sake, friends don't kiss each other!

What even are they now? How can he swallow it all down and greet Mydei tomorrow without combusting on the spot? There's no way Phainon trusts himself to act normally around him anymore.

Above all else, he can't bear the thought of Mydei already being taken.

No matter how he looks at it, it means Mydei cheated on Evernight. Honestly, Phainon doesn't care what the girl thinks—but how does it weigh on *Mydei*?

Will he tell her? Is he regretful? Was that the reason he looked on the verge of crying?

Phainon squeezes his phone tightly as that bitter feeling threatens to consume him.

What if they're texting each other right now, trying to make amends? What if Mydei was simply too determined to help his pathetic friend and took a step farther than he should have? Is Phainon at fault for suggesting something that might have blurred their judgment?

Only when his phone vibrates does he realize he's on the verge of snapping it in two from the force of his grip.

Phainon turns his attention to the screen, his breath catching.

**Mydei:** Still awake?

The surprise nearly makes him drop the device. Phainon blinks, as if the message were some divine signal from the Titans themselves. It's past ten p.m. He replies instantly.

**Phainon:** Yep. Fell out of bed?

**Mydei:** I was having tea. My throat feels raspy.

Phainon's heartbeat races so fast it feels like it might burst from his chest. Mydei is talking to him casually, as though they hadn't shared a kiss under the rain just hours ago.

**Phainon:** Oh? Getting sick?

**Mydei:** As if. There's no word for "sick" in the Kremnoan dictionary.

Phainon groans, pressing his phone against his forehead. Even in the midst of panic, how can he still find this guy so unbearably adorable?

**Phainon:** Hm…

**Phainon:** Does that mean Kremnoans have an amazing constitution, or is that just you?

*Stop it, you idiot. Stop flirting with him—he's your friend, your former pretend date, and he already has a girlfriend. And he kissed you, but we're still not talking about that.*

**Mydei:** *HKS*. I should known better than to text you.

Phainon can't hold back his smile.

**Phainon:** But you still did.

He chews on his bottom lip, taking a leap of faith with the next message.

**Phainon:** Missed me already? :^)

Mydei's reply takes so long that Phainon is perched at the edge of his bed, anxious, watching the three dots appear and vanish on the screen.

What finally comes through makes his mind stall.

**Mydei:** Your jacket will have to suffice.

He rereads it so many times his glasses nearly slide all the way down his nose.

**Phainon:** What do you mean?

No reply comes, even after several minutes.

**Phainon:** Mydei????

**Phainon:** Mydeiiii? Answer me pleaseee (T⌓T)

**Phainon:** …good night, then. :((

Kephale spare him. How could Mydei drop this and go to sleep peacefully afterward? Now Phainon can't shake the image of him cuddling his jacket to sleep. He never imagined he would feel so much jealousy over his own piece of clothing.

Do friends sleep with each other's clothes?

The answer is rather obvious, but Phainon's brain is too fried to think rationally at the moment. It was just something Mydei implied—it's not as if he's actually hugging the as he dozes off this very moment. It shouldn't even be dry yet!

…Right?

Someone please slap him already.

Though this conversation erased any chance of Phainon getting sleep tonight, at the very least it reassured him that Mydei wasn't planning to shut him out of his life again. That alone feels like a victory.

Still, there are so many things they need to talk about. Phainon needs to understand what really happened today—and what these flirty interactions are doing to their friendship, if it can even still be called that.

Rolling onto his bed, he sighs. Is it too much to dream that Mydei is doing all this because he actually likes him too?

Despite having a girlfriend, despite ignoring him for two whole years… none of it really matters if that's true.

So late into this starless night, Phainon's hope, for once, burns as bright as the sun.



On Monday morning, Phainon discovers he's still been left on read, with no reply in sight.

That's fine. He'll meet Mydei at school and ask about it.

He totally can do it without fumbling anything. The trembling in his hands and his left leg twitching the entire way to school are clear signs that he's not nervous at all.

Titans help him.

He needs to talk to Mydei about their date. He can't keep bottling everything up and pretending they're just friends anymore. Phainon wants to understand what Mydei really expects from him, instead of maintaining this awkward wall between their unspoken feelings.

It sounds easier in his head.

By the time Phainon settles into his desk, he's still trying to figure out a good way to start the conversation.

Phainon received a few curious glances as soon as he arrived. No student asked about his involvement with the Fig Stew curse, which must be an aftereffect of his announcement during Lilgui's livestream. Even Castorice is staring at him from behind her notebook.

Well, he's almost used to being talked about by now. As long as nobody bothers Mydei about it, there's no reason for him to care.

That being said, he can't hide his disappointment when the minutes tick closer to the start of class and Mydei still hasn't shown up.

He's not known for being late—that's Cyrene's specialty—so there must be a good reason.

Could it have something to do with yesterday?

Phainon gulps as another wave of anxiety washes over him.

Phainon pulls out his phone and quickly types a message, trying not to seem too desperate.

**Phainon:** Hey. You coming today?

**Mydei:** No. I'm sick.

Phainon exhales a breath he hadn't realized he was holding. Mydei is still clearly ignoring his last messages from yesterday, but given the circumstances, he can let it slide for now.

He also knows he shouldn't find this funny, but it's stronger than him.

**Phainon:** What happened to the Kremnoans don't get sick discourse?

**Mydei:** Shut up.

**Mydei:** My head already hurts. I'm not dealing with you right now.

Fair enough. At least Mydei didn't skip for a reason outside his control.

**Phainon:** Get well soon :)

Phainon lets out a relieved sigh.

"You alright, Phai?" Cyrene asks curiously at his side.

Phainon has been keeping her in the dark about his recent endeavors with Mydei, mostly because he knows she's endured enough of his suffering over that crush through the years. Apparently, she's still unaware of what happened yesterday—good. He'll explain everything eventually.

Still, her expression clearly shows she knows exactly what he's thinking about.

"Yeah. I just found out Mydei isn't coming today. He's sick."

Cyrene's mouth forms a little 'o'.

"And why are you so smug about it?"

Phainon averts his gaze, scratching the back of his neck. He has no intention of telling Cyrene how Mydei actually got sick.

"Let's just say it was his own doing," Phainon replies vaguely. While he was an accomplice, it was Mydei who dragged them into walking under a storm.

Cyrene narrows her eyes at him.

"Why do I feel there's much more to it?"

Phainon only answers with a half-smile. She shakes her head in resignation.

"You'll tell me sooner or later." She props her chin on her hand, her voice softening. "Still, at least you finally seem happy again. That's the power of lovesickness, huh?

"Rene…" Phainon mutters in frustration, fighting back the heat crawling up his neck.

His friend lets out a delicate laugh at his doom, the bell ringing and saving him from his own embarrassment.

Phainon may have developed the bad habit of expecting Mydei to always be there for lunch since last week. Even without his cooked meals, he thought they'd had a pretty fun time together.

Now that the Kremnoan is staying home, he can't help but feel a little empty as he leans against one of the windows in the third-floor hallway. Cyrene is already on her way to meet Stelle, and he's not in the mood to chat with Castorice and the girls.

Shit. Is he having separation anxiety?

Phainon considers sending a message to check on how Mydei is doing, but thinks better of it. If he's sick, staring at a phone screen probably won't help soothe an aching headache.

The only way he can think to ease his longing is to see his face—even just for a little while.

His fingers swiftly open the gallery app.

Phainon had managed to take several photos during their date. If he'd known Mydei liked keeping pictures enough to spend a small fortune on them, he would have offered earlier to snap some.

He can already feel a smile tugging at his lips as he scrolls through the images.

There was one photo he took when Mydei got an Oatmeal-themed waffle and Phainon snatched a bite without warning. He had already prepared to capture Mydei's reaction, so the picture ended up showing him both annoyed and frustrated at the camera.

How cute.

Phainon had also tried very hard to get them to take pictures wearing the chimera-ear tiaras they handed out at the park, but Mydei was so adamantly against it that he eventually had to give up.

Sadly, they never took a proper couple photo. Phainon had felt too insecure to ask.

He lets out another sigh, resting his chin in his fist. He scrolls some more—there are a few blurry photos he snapped during the rides, some of the dromas and chimeras in the animal area, one of Mydei reading a stall's menu out loud for him since Phainon had left his glasses at home…

The last photo of the day was taken just minutes before the storm. The sky was already darkening with heavy clouds, and Mydei stood at the center of the frame, a few lamps casting a warm glow across his face. His expression was soft, and he glanced at the camera—or was it at Phainon?—with tender golden irises.

He looked happy.

Phainon's chest tightens. Titans, he misses him.

He stares at the photo a while longer, committing every detail to memory. It was taken after they exited the Master Cat-Thief Ghost Tower, where Mydei had kept him close the entire route after Phainon whined about being scared. The attraction is still visible in the corner of the frame.

Most guests had already retreated to the restaurants and game booths, so there were only a few people scattered in the background. Phainon isn't sure why he's suddenly paying so much attention to it, but something keeps tugging at his focus the longer he looks.

He adjusts his glasses, narrowing his gaze. Why does that particular figure seem so familiar?

When he finally notices the two pale-pink strands of hair peeking out from beneath a large black umbrella, it clicks.

Evernight was there.

His thoughts grind to a halt as the realization sinks in.

The girl wasn't looking in their direction—she seemed to be heading somewhere else. As if she wasn't bothered in the slightest that her boyfriend had been within reach all this time.

Why was she at the park?

Mydei said their plans had been cancelled. Could she be there with someone else, a friend perhaps? Phainon doesn't recognize anyone near her.

Did she see them?

If she did, she chose to stay quiet and not approach them. Why? Phainon had been far closer to Mydei than any friend should be. There's no way she didn't notice that.

Does Mydei know about it?

Phainon doubts he would have agreed to their fake date if he knew she was there. He already seemed worried she might find out.

The questions keep piling up, one after another, until Phainon feels like he's about to have a meltdown. But more importantly—

What in Kephale's name is happening?



Phainon can't concentrate on any of his remaining classes for the rest of the day. His thoughts keep circling back to Evernight's suspicious presence at the park yesterday.

The more he replays it in his mind, the less sense it makes.

In the end, he decides that maybe Mydei's absence today is a blessing. Because the moment the final bell rings, Phainon heads straight to the second-year floor, beating even Cyrene to it.

Most students are already crowding the hallway on their way out. Among them is Evernight with her small group of friends: the one tall dark-haired guy he recalls as Dan Heng, the look-alike who might be her twin sister, Stelle, and her brother Caelus.

It's Stelle who spots him first.

"Oh hey, Kevin. What brings you here?" she asks lazily as he approaches the group.

"It's Khaslana, Stelle…" Evernight's sister corrects with a reprimanding frown.

Phainon isn't in the mood to play along, and his expression probably shows it.

"Hey. I was looking for Evernight." His eyes lock onto her figure. She stares back at him with an unbothered expression, as if he were nothing more than a minor inconvenience. He adds, "Can we talk?"

The group exchanges silent glances, all eyes turning to Evernight, waiting for her reaction.

"Oh, my," she says, feigning surprise with a palm over her mouth. "Go ahead, guys. I'll catch up soon."
"What did you do this time?" her sister asks in a tired tone, while Dan Heng gently guides her along the group with a hand on her back.

"Eve's been really close with the third-years lately, huh…? Think she can set me up with Castorice?" Caelus says dreamily as they leave the corridor.

"In your dreams… Castorice is already dating," Stelle mocks, ignoring her brother's loud "What!?" as she focuses on her phone. "Oh, I have to go meet my dear wife. Bye!"

The last thing Phainon sees is Dan Heng rubbing his temple in silent suffering.

A small chuckle from Evernight pulls Phainon's attention back to her.

"My, my. What a scary face, Mr. Class Rep." Her lips curve into a smile. "What did I do to deserve such hatred?"

Phainon can feel the scowl etched into his features. He flexes his fingers, trying to keep himself calm. If he messes this conversation up and actually insults Mydei's girlfriend, he

might as well say goodbye to their friendship.

Thankfully, the hallway is empty now. It's just the two of them.

"I need to ask you something," he begins. "Why… were you at the park yesterday?"

Evernight tilts her head slightly. She holds her signature umbrella in one hand, while the other comes to rest against her jaw.

"That sounds more like…" she muses, blood-red eyes glinting, "…you want to know whether I saw the two of you."

She doesn't bother hiding her amusement when Phainon visibly flinches.

Why does she seem so comfortable with this?

"Doesn't it bother you?" he asks, his tone sharper than intended. "I roped Mydei into a pretend date."

Evernight blinks at him, clearly confused for the first time.

"Pretend?" she echoes. "Everyone seems rather convinced it was real. Even I have to admit—it was kind of cute."

What?

Phainon must be misunderstanding something.

"You think me going on a date with your boyfriend is cute?" he deadpans.

A long silence follows as Evernight studies him, her blood-red irises narrowing by the second.

Why is Phainon suddenly starting to feel stupid?

"…I see," she finally says, nodding as if everything has just clicked into place. "As you may have witnessed, I'm used to stupidity. But this?"

She scoffs lightly.

"This is a whole new level."

Phainon is certain that if he still had the same mindset he did a few moments ago, he'd be fuming. But now, he has absolutely no idea what he's supposed to feel.

Evernight hums, tapping her chin.

"Whatever you think that big boy and I have, let's just say our relationship is… *strictly professional*."

Phainon stares at her in stunned silence, absorbing each word one by one.

“You two aren’t dating?” he repeats, voice tight, desperate for confirmation.

“No.” Evernight shakes her head slowly. “Yesterday, I was simply attending my shift.”

She pauses, and a mischievous glint flashes in her eyes.

“Can’t say the same for our big boy, though.” Her grin widens. “He dumped all his workload on us—”

“—just to go out with you.”

Phainon’s hands are trembling for an entirely different reason now. He tries to steady his voice as he continues.

“Y—you two… Work at the park?” he asks in shock, because that’s what she seems to be implying.

That means whatever he thought he understood weeks ago from her conversation with Dan Heng was completely wrong. She wasn’t talking about a secret relationship.

She was talking about work.

A job that both she and Mydei had been keeping secret.

Evernight chuckles.

“To think that poor big boy had to lose his voice just to hide his identity.” She sighs dramatically, fully aware of how her words are pulling the rug out from under Phainon’s feet. “A rather cruel fate for such a cute chimera, don’t you think?”

*No.*

*No, no, no…*

Phainon feels dizzy as the pieces finally click into place. A headache blooms behind his eyes, and he presses a hand to his forehead. Since the very beginning, he had thought Evernight’s voice sounded far too familiar—despite having never spoken to her before.

And suddenly, he’s dragged back to the park’s opening day, when Cyrene had accompanied him for a while.

The day he met Fig Stew.

The day that the black-and-red chimera, Gummy Roll—*Evernight*—told those kids about the curse.

So the person who had been comforting him these past weeks—who took care of his arm, who hugged him when he poured his heart out…

The friend he wanted Mydei to meet.

The one who was absent yesterday.

They were the same person.

All this time, he had been heartbroken and suffering over something that wasn't even real. And worse—he had been venting to his own crush about losing him forever.

Evernight was being humble in calling him stupid.

"I—… just, why?" he mumbles, stunned. "Why would he hide it from me?"

Why had Mydei comforted him when they still weren't talking? Did he know Phainon liked him and do it out of kindness? No, that was impossible. The girls would never betray his trust.

None of it adds up.

Did Mydei really have a sudden change of heart just because they met while he was dressed as Fig Stew? There's no way. He deliberately chose to hide his identity by staying mute, even playing dumb every time Phainon brought the mascot up.

There's more to it. There has to be.

But no matter how hard Phainon tries, he can't grasp what that missing piece might be.

Evernight crosses her arms, a hint of pity softening her expression.

"I'm sure you will find your answer, Mr. Class Rep." Her tone is uncharacteristically gentle, as if she were dealing with a child. "After all, chimeras have their own way of conveying their emotions—even when they can't talk."

When she notices Phainon's frozen state, she smiles.

"If that's all, I'll be taking my leave…" She walks past him, but not before adding one last remark over her shoulder. "It's been fun… but I fear it's about time this curse ended."

Phainon is left speechless, alone in the hallway as the afternoon slowly bleeds into evening.

If what Evernight said is true, then Mydei isn't just Fig Stew—he's been keeping far more secrets than Phainon ever imagined.

He remembers how Mydei compared himself to a cat yesterday, when Phainon asked what Fig Stew's *awoo* meant.

And then it hits him.

He wants to scream.

Because by Kephale—Mydei *awooed* at him.

Phainon buries his face in his hands. His cheeks burn so hot he thinks he might actually combust.

Is it possible to die from cuteness aggression?

Not only that—but if the metaphor really does apply to what Fig Stew was trying to convey that day… Phainon's pulse races so fast he can hear it pounding in his ears. He might finally have an idea of the true meaning behind that small *awoo*.

However…

If Mydei went to such lengths to hide this from him, Phainon can't just bring it up out of thin air. To find out what Mydei's feelings really are, he might need to approach this the same way one would approach a feral cat—with patience and caution.

Taking a deep breath, he forces himself to calm his frantic heart as a plan slowly begins to take shape in his mind.

Well.

Two can play this game.

Phainon pulls out his phone, determined to contact the other chimera experts he knows besides Mydei.

In the end, maybe he's more inclined to play the role of Fig Stew's crush than he had initially thought.

Chapter End Notes

:)

It wasn't so bad, was it?

Phainon needs to be away from Mydei so he can put his braincells to do some work for once.

Erm, I might have been a little distracted with Endfield, along with a little piling of work. Sorry for the slightly late update!

If you're still reading this, you don't know how much that means to me. I hope I can keep bringing you some fun in the upcoming chapters!

See you~

# Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Mydei is staying home a few days to recover from his sickness. He notices Phainon is behaving oddly lately and starts wondering if their date might have anything to do with it.

Chapter Notes

No warnings for this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Being sick sucks ass.

Mydei can't remember the last time he fell ill. He had always taken good care of his health, prioritizing a balanced diet along with regular exercise. One could say that getting sick was something that should only happen to him once in a lifetime.

Well, he had also never deliberately spent so much time under heavy rain and stormy winds with almost no shelter. It didn't help that his body had burned in Phainon's embrace as they kissed, only to cool down immediately after they parted.

There was also the detail that dwelling so much on what he had done was the initial cause of his headache.

If it were two years ago, Mydei would probably have buried himself in a hole and never come out. What the hell was he thinking, kissing Phainon? He knew better than anyone how this would affect their friendship, and yet he did it simply because he couldn't bear to hear Phainon saying things that weren't meant for his ears.

Worst of all: Phainon kissed him back.

It was most likely because he got lost in their pretend date. Phainon had seemed very confused until they parted ways. Who could blame him, really? It was surprising enough that he managed to keep his cool at all, still sweet enough to lend his jacket amidst everything.

Mydei knew he was at fault for wishing for something unattainable; yet he couldn't resent kissing his crush. In truth, he was glad he had been able to share his first kiss with Phainon.

Even if it never happened again, at least he had gotten a taste of what it feels like to kiss the person you like. He could only hope it hadn't meant the same thing to Phainon; Mydei would hate to steal the guy's first kiss over his own selfishness during a fake date.

His heart stings at the thought that someone like Cyrene had everything within her reach and still chose another. The world isn't fair.

There is something Mydei does resent, though—he doesn't want to go home. The moment he steps onto the subway is the moment everything is finally over. It's wishful thinking to believe he could find a way to prolong their day together, since not even Oronyx answered his prayers. So, with a heavy chest, he boards, and with it, his heart shatters silently.

Mydei spends the entire ride home replaying their date in his head—the day he and Phainon belonged to one another. It already almost feels like a dream.

His clothes and hair are still drenched, so he refrains from taking a seat and ruining another passenger's day later. Leaning against one of the car's windows, he clings to the jacket draped over his shoulders. Though faint, Phainon's scent still lingers. He can see his face in the glass reflection—a bit too flushed for his own liking, and he suspects it may not be due to the feverish state he's feeling.



After getting ready for bed, Mydei acknowledges that he's getting sick. The insistent pulsing in his head is developing into a headache, and his throat protests at anything that goes down.

His mother had been curious about his condition—her son isn't known for being careless like that. After he insisted that the storm had caught him and his friend by surprise, she sighed and brewed some tea to soothe his raspy throat.

As he sips it, Mydei stares at his phone screen. How should he approach Phainon from now on? Treating that day—and especially that kiss—as an accident induced by their roleplay doesn't seem like a good idea. No matter how you look at it, no one would normally kiss their friend under any circumstances.

Yet, Mydei doesn't want to treat it as if it never happened either.

Kremnoans are not cowards. He decides he won't run away from it—if Phainon happens to bring it up. Mydei has no idea what he would say to justify it, but as long as he refrains from saying the real motive—that he likes Phainon far too much—there may still be hope that their friendship will last until graduation.

After all, Phainon chose to kiss him back. He's just as guilty as Mydei is. Or at least, that's what Mydei keeps trying to convince himself of.

So he fires the first shot by messaging Phainon, gauging his reaction. From the way their conversation goes, it almost feels like everything might end well, even if they never touch on the subject.

But when Phainon asks if Mydei misses him, he freezes.

*Yes.*

He types it instinctively, then frowns and deletes it just as fast.

*I would never.*

It's a blatant lie, and it shows. He doesn't want to commit to it right now. He presses one hand to his forehead as he erases it again. His headache worsens by the minute.

*I miss y—…*

No. He can't say it directly, but he doesn't want to lie either.

Mydei glares at his Fig Stew charm. Somehow, letting his emotions show feels easier inside a mascot suit. He sighs and rubs his temple.

When his eyes catch a glimpse of black in the corner of his room, he stops.

He has already cleaned it by hand and dried it as much as he could without damaging the leather. He resents a little having washed Phainon's scent away, but there is no way he is handing it back tomorrow in that state. It is still not fully dry and hangs from his office chair for now.

Just looking at it conjures the image of Phainon in full black attire, and Mydei's body grows hot despite the fever.

He gulps, forcing his attention back to the screen. He types a message that feels far too honest, fully aware that the piece of clothing will do a very good job of keeping its owner on his mind tonight.



On Monday, Mydei feels like he's going to turn into a puddle of goo.

The aching in his head grows into a full-blown headache, breathing becomes painful with such a sore throat, his nose runs endlessly, and his muscles seem purely decorative.

"You're not going to school in this state," his mother says after taking his temperature. It's not bad enough to truly worry her, but she still insists he stay home, rest, and eat well.

Not like he can argue back, honestly.

She calls the school to explain the reason for his absence. Before leaving for work, she prepares some meals early in the morning that he can heat when he feels hungry, though Mydei doubts his stomach will ask for anything in this condition.

Was rain his weak spot or something? It doesn't feel natural to be so affected by it.

Phainon will probably laugh his ass off when he discovers Mydei actually got sick.

Just thinking about the menace is enough—his phone vibrates almost instantly.

It takes a lot of effort to send two messages informing of his condition before letting the device fall back onto the bed. There. Now he can have his fun.

Mydei buries himself in his sheets, almost glad he's being spared from seeing Phainon today. He doesn't know how it would feel to see him back to his normal routine of crushing on Cyrene after yesterday.

Luckily, the fever prevents him from thinking too much. He falls back asleep rather quickly, exhaustion winning out and pulling him into a dreamless rest.



On Tuesday, Mydei feels more functional.

With only a slight fever now, his headache is manageable with some medicine, though the sore throat and runny nose remain annoyances he can't avoid. To prevent him from spreading the flu to his classmates, he stays home again, as his mother instructed.

He can eat without feeling like his stomach is about to dissolve, and even watch some TV in the living room to pass the time.

Which means he can also use his phone again.

He lets Phainon know he won't be coming in today, just in case the guy is still worried he might steal the jacket. Surprisingly, there's no teasing this time; Phainon replies with a simple, "Okay. Rest well :)."

Huh. He's being easy for once. Well, Mydei is grateful, so he's not going to pry. There are other things he needs to take care of.

And if there is something he's been wanting to see, it's the discussion of Lilgui's last livestream on Sunday.

He opens his social media and immediately searches for the "Chimera Park" tag.

**Lilgui:** Fig Stew was absent today!! Is this part of the marketing?

**_seaofbutt3r:** guys the mascot is a real person can't he be like sick or something? Oo

**Silvermane.Captain:** They shouldn't promote something that isn't in the park. My little sister went just to see Fig Stew.

**LynXtremeChannel:** omg shut up brother!!! I was there to vlog the extreme coasters!!!

**_Pela_:** Can confirm. I was there to accompany her.

**RedHerring:** can we talk about the real thing, though? that Khaslana guy was a sight for sore eyes

**CloudsKnightBeauty:** Finally something we agree on RedHerring!

**RedHerring:** his date isn't half bad, too

**notrashnogain21:** whoa this is so weird when you actually know them

**cutestofall✿:** what do you mean? They look so cute together! I even got my sister to agree.

**Lilgui:** … erm, I feel like we're losing focus here, guys!

**Lilgui:** The fact is that Khaslana had nothing to do with the Fig Stew curse, and Fig Stew was not present.

**ClousKnightBeauty:** Neither of the mascots knew anything about it, too. We checked!

**Lilgui:** We'll have to pray for something big next week!

Mydei glares at the screen, his eyebrows arching. He doesn't know what's more baffling: that Phainon's plan actually worked, or that the general public finds them a cute couple. His insides flutter at the thought that, in the eyes of strangers, they were dating for real.

If only they knew the truth behind it all.

As he sighs, a new notification pops up. He opens it when he sees the sender.

**Castorice:** Hi, Mydei. How are you?

**Mydei:** Still recovering, but feeling better. Thanks.

**Castorice:** That's great to hear!

**Castorice:** Mr. Anaxagoras gave an important assignment today. It's due Thursday.

**Castorice:** Do you mind if I drop it off at your house on the way back home?

Mr. Anaxagoras and his dozen-page assignments. The thought alone spikes Mydei's headache. Sadly, it's painful even to attempt rolling his eyes.

**Mydei:** Sure. I'll be waiting.

**Castorice:** Alright! See you.

As he closes the chat, Mydei glances at the clock at the top of the screen. It's past lunchtime, so there's still plenty of time before Castorice arrives. He flops back onto the sofa and grabs the remote, stopping on one of the Black Swan detective episodes.

After two episodes, Mydei gets up and goes to the kitchen to brew some tea for his guest. Halfway through, he hears the front doorbell ring.

"—ut what if it's suspici—"

"Shhh! We already rang the doorbell."

"O—oh…"

The blabbering is cut short when Mydei opens the door with a frown. Castorice visiting him isn't really that unusual—they live in the same neighborhood. Sometimes they even walk to school together.

But as he stares at her companion, he can't shake the feeling that something fishy is going on.

“H—hi, Mydei!” Castorice greets him, her expression a bit too panicked as she glances between him and the other girl.

“Hey there, little lion!” Cipher chirps, her tail wagging happily as her grin widens. “That nose of yours makes you look like a reindeer.”

Despite the pain, Mydei rolls his eyes.

It’s no secret that Cipher and Castorice are dating. They are just very reserved about it, mostly because Castorice is too shy. But she could have warned him that Cipher would be coming, too.

Dealing with extroverts when sick is double the annoyance.

“Come in,” he says tiredly, guiding the duo to the kitchen.

They take up the stools at the kitchen island as Mydei starts looking for cups in the cabinets.

“So, little lion…” Cipher begins, and her tone already tells Mydei he knows exactly what she’s hinting at. “We heard something very interesting about you and our Golden Boy…”

Mydei lets out a heavy breath as he pours tea for them.

“What is it?” he humors her, since there isn’t much else he can do. He knew he’d have to explain sooner or later what had happened on Sunday.

“We—well…” Castorice fidgets timidly, her voice tinged with curiosity. “You… went on a date with Phainon…?”

For a brief moment, Mydei wants to ask whether they saw it at the park or through Lilgui’s stream. Instead, he holds back, crossing his arms as he leans against the counter, careful not to get too close to the girls lest he get them sick too.

“It was a fake date,” he says matter-of-factly, because there’s no need to hide it from them. Cipher and Castorice exchange shocked looks as he continues, “Phainon used it as an excuse to shrug off his involvement with the Fig Stew’s curse.”

“*What?* That’s not what—” Cipher starts, only to be silenced almost immediately by Castorice’s palm over her mouth.

*What the fuck are those two up to?* Mydei can’t help but wonder as he arches an eyebrow at their odd behavior.

“I—I see! It’s, uh—… unexpected, that’s all.” Castorice stutters, lowering her hand once she’s sure Cipher won’t pry any further.

Mydei remains suspicious, but he doesn’t want to dig too deeply into the matter. The mascots are off their shift at five p.m., and by the time the rain started, it was almost six. It’s unlikely either of the girls witnessed their kiss, but there’s always room for doubt since it happened in a public place.

And that's the only thing he truly hopes he won't have to explain.

"Did Mr. Reca give trouble to you guys?" Mydei asks, touching on a subject he isn't very eager to deal with. He still doesn't know if being absent for one day will affect the exclusive merch prize.

"No, the man was just worried about guests complaining on social media too much," Cipher says as she takes a sip of her tea, immediately making a face as her tail frizzes. "Ew. That's sour."

Mydei scoffs, grabbing the sugar jar and sliding it over to her. She chants, "Now we're talking," as she buries the spoon in it and adds sugar to her cup. No wonder she's so hyperactive.

"Indeed. Besides a few sad kids, there was nothing out of the ordinary," Castorice nods, holding her cup delicately between her hands. "However, he's still really worried about wrapping up the rumor for marketing reasons."

Considering that next Sunday is their last day as mascots, it does make sense. Still, that's a problem for the studio to solve if they're so set on adapting it into a special.

"Yeah, and about that," Cipher says, eyes glinting with mischief. "You're the Fig Stew expert between us. Don't you have any idea which chimera he should like?"

Huh. Mydei hadn't actually stopped to think about it—the rumor was so silly that he never imagined it would catch the writer's attention in the first place.

But he does love Fig Stew as a character. The little chimera has been part of his life since childhood—back then, it was rare to find any Kremnoan cartoon character that didn't fit the usual brute stereotype. Fig Stew broke that mold by having a multifaceted personality. The little chimera was valiant and fierce, but also had a side that cared deeply for its companions and never bowed to public expectations. It's only natural that the character grew so dear to him.

So if it were up to him, which one would he rather see paired with it romantically?

Or rather, based on Fig Stew's relationships with the others, could he even say the little chimera has a crush on anyone?

The fans defending Butterfly Cake aren't too far-fetched. They do sustain a cute friendship, but it never seems to go beyond that. Fig Stew is somewhat introverted, so it's not like he goes out of his way to spend time with the others very often.

There's only one chimera who insists on pestering him despite Fig Stew's reclusion: the gray-and-white chimera with big blue eyes, Vigethos.

Mydei remembers when Fig Stew and Vigethos were introduced as rivals; they fought for ten days and nights before finally calling it a tie. From then on, they treated each other with mutual respect, and as the seasons went on, Vigethos began clinging to Fig Stew more and

more. The menace of a chimera would pester it into bathing together several times a day and even nip at Fig Stew lightly just to get its attention.

Fig Stew grew attached to Vigethos as well—the blue-eyed chimera was the first to befriend it, despite Fig Stew being from Kremnos. Though it enjoyed spending time with Vigethos, it never admitted it out of pride. Mydei can easily see it developing into a relationship if the writers choose to go that route.

Thinking back, it feels obvious which chimera should be Fig Stew's love interest if they're adapting the story. Still, there's no Vigethos mascot in the park, so whatever character they choose in the end will be different.

Why does this bother Mydei so much all of a sudden?

"Mm," he grunts, trying to shake the uncomfortable feeling away. "Vigethos seems the more accurate choice for me."

"Oh! You think so too?" Castorice's expression brightens as she smiles. "I've always shipped them together…"

"Well, duh. They totally have a married aura, what did you expect?" Cipher teases, sticking out her tongue. "That's like saying water is wet."

Is that so? The girls were always more creative in this "shipping" aspect. He never gave it too much thought until now.

"Enough about that," Mydei says, already feeling the exhaustion settling back into his muscles. He really should rest soon. "Didn't Mr. Anaxagoras give an assignment today?"

"Ah, right…" Castorice finally seems to remember why she was there in the first place. She rummages through her bag until she pulls out a thick stack of papers and places it on the island.

*Holy shit.*

How it even fits in her bag is a mystery. He'd better start reading as soon as they leave.

It doesn't take much longer. After finishing their tea and chatting a bit more, Cipher and Castorice bid their farewells. Mydei is relieved he can finally blow his nose in peace.

He tries to get started on Mr. Anaxagoras' assignment, but the moment he reads the first words, his headache flares up again. Well, he'll deal with it tomorrow.

Once night falls and bedtime approaches, Mydei is surprised to see that Phainon still hasn't texted him. Perhaps he's respecting his need to rest, but something feels off. Could he be thinking twice about keeping their friendship intact after Sunday?

Regardless, Mydei isn't in the best condition to dwell on it. Whatever happens tomorrow, he'll face it head-on.

But if Phainon really wants to put an end to it…

He gulps down the bitter taste in his mouth. His eyes drift to the jacket he's supposed to return tomorrow. If this is the last time he'll get to hold onto something that belongs to his crush, is it really wrong to indulge a little?

Maybe he's still not thinking straight because of the fever. Or maybe it's just easier to find an excuse as he picks up the clothing and brings it close to his less-runny nose. There's almost no scent left, but it's still there. Mydei would recognize it anywhere.

Sitting back in bed, he clutches the jacket against his chest as he lies on his back, staring at the dark ceiling of his room. Though the jacket soothes his longing a little, he can't help but wish it were its owner who lulled him to sleep like two years ago.



Something is definitely off.

First, both Castorice and Cipher were behaving oddly when they visited his house yesterday. Now, arriving in the classroom on Wednesday and catching Castorice and Phainon chatting quietly—low enough that their voices are drowned out by the other students' blabbering—gives him an unsettling feeling.

They both nearly jump out of their skin when they notice Mydei staring at them with his arms crossed.

"M—morning, Mydei!" Castorice greets, her eyes widening as her face flushes slightly.

"Hey. Feeling better?" Phainon asks, awkwardly scratching the back of his neck.

Mydei narrows his eyes, looking between the two of them.

"Morning. I'm fine, thanks," he replies flatly.

"That's great!" Castorice exclaims before quickly excusing herself and heading to her seat. Phainon, however, keeps looking at him strangely, which makes Mydei grunt.

"What?"

More composed now, Phainon offers him a half-smile.

"Just glad you're finally back," he says sheepishly, making Mydei flinch at such unwarned honesty. To his dismay, Phainon adds, "Now I understand why you're so afraid of the rain…"

"HKS, shut up," Mydei snarls—not only because he's already acknowledged his weakness to rain, but because of all the memories that come with the mention of it.

Deciding he won't extract whatever this is about from Phainon right now, Mydei finds his seat in quiet annoyance. He can hear Phainon laughing as the bell rings.

When lunch arrives, Mydei is surprised that Phainon still seems set on spending it with him.

With the rooftop no longer available, they buy their meals at the canteen and decide to sit on the stairs leading down to the courtyard. Mydei notices a few students throwing curious glances their way, and he suspects it's mostly because of Lilgui's stream. Strangely enough, Phainon hasn't brought it up yet—and neither will Mydei, for as long as he can help it—but it also seems that the model student didn't go out of his way to explain that it had all been a fake date to anyone.

And that includes Cyrene.

The pink-haired girl is cheerful as ever, talking with Phainon as if she doesn't care in the slightest that her childhood friend is supposedly dating Mydei. Does she not know? It's odd that she hasn't heard about it by now. Mydei is certain that neither Castorice, Cipher, nor Hyacine would keep it a secret from her.

Is Phainon truly alright with hanging out with him when everyone still believes they went on a real date? By the way he keeps dragging Mydei along, he seems unbothered—but a small question keeps tugging at Mydei's attention:

*Why?*

Mydei knows he should ask about it. And he will—eventually. But somehow, it feels as though their day together changed something. Something unspoken. And he isn't sure he wants to break this strange spell, where there are still no consequences to being perceived as a couple—at least not yet. Still, the knowing glint in Phainon's blue irises makes him feel a little too exposed.

Even so, though they're not acting intimate like they did at the park, having Phainon beside him, smiling at him, is enough to make his insides flutter.

He gets so distracted by it all that he only remembers he's supposed to return Phainon's jacket when he starts packing his belongings and spots it folded neatly inside a plastic bag. The class rep is summoned to one of the teachers' offices once the bell rings, so Mydei decides to head to the school gates to wait for him.

There are still a few students spilling out when he catches a glimpse of silver amidst the crowd. Phainon's neutral face morphs into a bright smile the moment he notices the Kremnoan standing there.

Titans spare his heart.

"Were you waiting for me?" Phainon asks as he approaches, blue irises glinting.

Mydei clears his throat, suddenly feeling it a bit too constricted.

"Yeah," he says casually, holding the plastic bag out between them. When Phainon tilts his head at it, he adds, "It's your jacket."

Phainon's lips form a small 'o' as he regards the bag. He frowns, pouting slightly as he grabs the straps—letting his fingers hover just above Mydei's for a moment before the Kremnoan lets go.

"Right… my treacherous jacket…" he mutters. Cute expression aside, the comment makes Mydei's eyebrows shoot up.

"Your what?"

“Never mind.” Phainon shakes his head, dropping the bag to his side. He’s back to his usual cheerfulness. “Just thinking out loud.”

“If you say so…” Mydei shifts awkwardly, still lost on the meaning of it. He’s about to say his goodbyes when Phainon steps closer and, without any warning—

—kisses his cheek.

“Thank you for taking care of it, Mydei,” Phainon says in a sweet tone against his skin.

Did Mydei die sometime during those days he was sick?

Because he certainly feels like he’s about to now. His heart rate spikes so fast it nearly makes him dizzy. He feels all the blood rush to his face as he processes what just happened. Phainon is still wearing a smug grin as he steps back, watching Mydei’s cheeks bloom into a deep red.

“You…” Mydei begins, baffled, lifting a hand to cover the spot he’s just been kissed as if it were some kind of burning wound. “Are you out of your mind?”

Phainon’s eyes spark with mischief. It’s almost like he’s savoring this.

“I thought you were fine with kissing…” He pauses, letting the words sink in before delivering the final blow.

“You know—after that.”

Holy shit. There must not be any blood left in his body—it’s all concentrated in his face.

That was payback for *him* kissing *Phainon*? And what the hell is that way of bringing up the subject? Are they just going to ignore the fact that friends normally don’t do things like this?

Moreover, he’s certain some of the students must have seen it. If anyone still had doubts, they’re now convinced that their date was real. He can already hear a few girls giggling nearby.

“*HKS*…” is all Mydei manages to get out, too shaken to come up with a better insult.

Phainon still has a satisfied aura until Mydei is feeling steady enough to go on his way home. Mydei can only hope this doesn’t turn into a regular thing—otherwise his heart really might give out.



As the week goes by, at least one thing is certain: Phainon no longer has that heavy aura around him ever since he found out about Cyrene's girlfriend. Mydei wants to believe he may have come to terms with it while still liking her, but part of him thinks he might have played a small role in that.

After all, Phainon seems to be enjoying himself far too much, teasing him at every possible opportunity.

Fortunately, there haven't been any more surprise kisses—and Mydei certainly isn't hoping for any—and they're back to their usual banter in no time. Still, some suspicious things are going on, the most obvious being that Phainon has apparently been vanishing after school lately.

Although Mydei tries to message him once he gets home, when Phainon should supposedly still be on the bus, he only replies much later at night. It's kind of unusual for someone who never wastes a minute replying to him.

But hey, asking about that would be prying into someone's privacy. It's not like he's doing anything illegal by becoming unavailable for a few hours a day.

Mydei isn't curious as hell, no sir.

So when Saturday comes and he's playing Chrysos War 2 with his friends, he does a very good job of not making it obvious.

"What are you sighing over again, dude?" Leonnius asks over the mic, unable to take it any longer.

"I'm not sighing," Mydei counters with a frown. He hadn't even noticed until now.

"No shit, Dei," Ptolemy says with a sneer.

"You're playing with your ass today, too," Perdikkas adds. How dramatic. He just let their party wipe twice.

"Can I ask why you're being so quiet today, Heph?" Peucesta asks suspiciously.

Mydei suddenly wants to drop the call.

"Well… I suppose Mydei's just thinking a bit too much about someone," Hephaestion drops the hint, and all his friends' voices instantly clash over the call.

"Shut up," Mydei mutters, rubbing a hand against his temple, already feeling a headache coming on. "I'm just wondering what a friend of mine has been up to."

A collective “ooo” echoes through the call.

“A *friend*? You never think about your friends’ whereabouts. You don’t even message us during the week,” Leonnius teases.

That’s not true. Mydei knows his friends are always in Kremnos doing… whatever it is they do; there’s no need to check up on them that often.

“If Leonnius is being reasonable, there’s a good chance you’re screwed, Dei,” Ptolemy says, his smirk almost audible.

“Yeah… what did this *friend* of yours do to earn your precious attention?” Perdikkas presses.

Damn. Well… he’s already too deep in this hole. Might as well suck it up and try to get something out of it.

“He’s been behaving oddly,” Mydei begins casually. “Like, totally off the charts for a while after class.”

“Huh. When did this start?” Peucesta asks, sounding genuinely interested.

Mydei stops himself before he can say *their date*. He clears his throat.

“After we hung out last week.”

The sound Hephaestion makes is almost like a restrained laugh.

“You two went out… and after that he’s ghosting you?” Perdikkas asks, clearly baffled.

“I’m sure he’s not ghosting Mydei,” Hephaestion adds. “I fear he isn’t being completely honest about this ‘hangout.’”

Mydei and Hephaestion would have a lot to discuss once he’s back in Kremnos. Okay, he might need to be a little more honest if his friends could actually help him with this, though he seriously doubts it.

“At some point during our hangout—” Mydei inhales deeply, bracing himself. “—we kissed.”

Contrary to his expectations, the silence that settles over the call cuts like a knife. Mydei starts to feel nervous as he goes on.

“Just to be clear, we’re still only friends; he already likes somebody else,” he says a bit too quickly. “But after that, he started acting odd. And on Wednesday, he kissed my cheek too.”

After a few more beats of silence, Leonnius is the first to speak.

“Holy shit.”

“Dei… did you leave your brain back in Kremnos?” Ptolemy asks in what can be only interpreted as suffering.

“What the hell does that mean?” Mydei asks, baffled by the audacity.

“It means why are you still here with us when you could be cuddling your boyfriend?” Hephaestion explains. Mydei tries not to let the comment get to him, but the heat creeping up his face betrays him.

“As I said, he likes—”

“Somebody else. We’re not deaf,” Perdikkas cuts in. “Still… Mydei, my liege, think for just a second. Would you kiss Leonnius? Or any of us, for that matter?”

“Never,” he replies without even needing to think it over.

“Ouch, my heart,” Leonnius jokes as Mydei rolls his eyes.

“Then, at least to me, it looks like you have him wrapped around your finger,” Perdikkas concludes in a soothing tone.

“Go for it, tiger,” Leonnius adds.

Huh. Is that really how it looks to an outside observer? What his friends are saying makes sense—he would never kiss them because Mydei doesn’t have a crush on any of them. But does the same apply to Phainon? He never had a crush on Mydei, so why is he still so comfortable with the idea of kissing him when he already declared that he’ll always like Cyrene, no matter what?

“I can hear you overthinking from here, Mydei,” Hephaestion sighs over the mic.

“When you two are officially together, remember to bring him to play with us,” Peucesta says lightly.

Mydei wants them to be right. Still, he finds it hard to believe that Phainon suddenly became infatuated with him after their date. Was it really just because of Sunday? Were a pretend date and a kiss enough for Phainon to shift his attention away from Cyrene?

It doesn’t feel right at all—something is missing in the bigger picture.

The talk does help ease his worries a little, though. They resume their play session, and while Mydei does a better job pressing his buttons this time, his gaze still flickers to his phone every now and then, waiting for a certain someone to answer his messages.



It's the final Sunday of his part-time job as Fig Stew, and Mydei feels a bit anxious for reasons he can't quite place. He didn't hate the job. Though dealing with the show's fanatic fans was exhausting and the costume a bit too hot, it was a rather unique experience.

More than that, working as Fig Stew had given him the chance to mend his relationship with Phainon. If not for the job, he might never have thought of repairing their friendship, which would soon lead to their date at the park.

Funnily enough, his happiest memories always seem to be linked to Fig Stew in one way or another. First, there was the phone charm that Phainon returned to him after weeks of tutoring; then, befriending his crush while wearing the mascot costume; and finally, the Fig Stew rumor being used as an excuse for their date.

That little chimera had practically become a guardian angel at this point.

He won't miss the job, but the sweet summer moments it provided will be etched in his mind forever.

As he enters the staff room, Mr. Reca is far too happy to see him. He doesn't mention the sick leave, only urges Mydei to get dressed alongside the others and prepare for the show.

"I can't believe it's our last day already," Hyacine says, already inside her Krenabis costume. "It flew by so fast!"

"I'm glad it's finally over," Cipher mutters, tugging at the costume tail as she tries to fit it around her own properly. "Having only one day of the week available sucks."

"It was fun, though," Castorice says. "We should enjoy it until the very last minute, right?"

Mydei is still quiet when he hears a familiar chuckle.

"Even at the last minute…" Evernight muses from inside her Gummy Roll costume. Mydei has the distinct impression she's staring at him through the mirror she sits before. "…there's still time for an unexpected climax."

Mydei isn't sure why her words give him such an unsettling feeling. Then again, coming from Evernight, it shouldn't come as a surprise. When a staff member enters the room and asks the mascots to grab their instruments and get ready to head out, Mydei crouches to pick up his toy guitar—and freezes.

He had thought the costume would have been stitched up once they noticed the rip on Fig Stew's arm. It was from when he collided with Phainon. The same chimera-printed Band-Aid was still plastered over it, as if not a single day had passed.

The same day he also said *“awoo”* to him.

His face flushes at the memory. He hurries to follow the other mascots, relieved that at least this is a secret he’ll be able to keep.



The first thing Mydei notices is that the plaza is crowded—far more than usual. He chooses to believe it's because this is the last chance to see the mascots' show, and perhaps his absence last week added to the anticipation. Still, the presence of those oversized TV microphones around the plaza feels like an exaggeration.

The show unfolds as always. When the happy song begins, the fanfare swells and the mascots dance, playing their instruments in cheerful rhythm. Mydei won't miss the state the performance leaves him in—drenched in sweat and desperate for a cup of water.

By the end, the mascots form a line to greet and thank the crowd, waving to the guests as the announcer cuts in.

"Thank you for your presence! The chimeras are delighted to spend the day with you!"

It's the same script as always. Mydei waits for it to finish so he can catch his breath before attending to the guests.

"Remember to greet them as you visit the park! We wish you a happy—…"

The announcer trails off, and the crowd stirs in confusion. Mydei glances toward the massive speakers around the plaza. Did they break?

"Wait a second." The announcer's voice returns, startling everyone. "I'm seeing something over there."

As if anyone could pinpoint where a voice is looking. Mydei almost wants to ask what the hell is going on, but he's supposed to stay silent. The girls beside him remain quiet, except for a small giggle from Hyacine.

*Weird.*

While the crowd scans the plaza, a guest suddenly shouts:

"Over there!"

Every gaze follows.

And Mydei's jaw nearly hits the ground.

"Is that… a chimera?!" the announcer exclaims, his surprise clearly played up for entertainment, because there's obviously another mascot slowly making his way through the crowd.

"It's Vigethos!" a kid shouts excitedly, and in an instant, everyone steps aside as the chimera

approaches the center of the plaza.

Up close, Mydei can take in the full costume. The person inside is tall—maybe as tall as he is—and Vigethos's white-and-gray fur, small horns, and big blue eyes are recreated to perfection. It's clearly an official park costume. Instead of an instrument, however, he carries a giant cardboard replica of the Dawnmaker sword, strapped across his shoulder and down his back.

"What could the Deliverer be doing in the park?" the announcer asks in a mysterious tone, lowering his voice as ambient music begins. "Let's hear it…"

So that's why there are so many microphones around.

Vigethos halts just before the group of chimeras. It seems to regard each one in silence before turning toward the crowd of guests.

"For an entire month, I've been hunting a very bad witch."

Mydei feels his blood turn to ice.

*No fucking way.*

He would recognize that voice anywhere. His heart rate picks up as he silently panics and still tries to get a grip on what the hell is happening.

The chimera spreads its arms wide, recounting its journey with dramatic flair.

"She tricked me into believing her hideout was at the very edge of the galaxy," it continues, maintaining a theatrical intonation. If this were a real stage play, Mydei could almost imagine a spotlight shining down on the chimera. "But it was all a plan to keep me away from my companions."

"With the help of a benevolent knight, I found my way back… only to discover she had placed one of my friends under a spell."

Some kids in the crowd begin to stir.

"It's Fig Stew!"

"She cursed Fig Stew!"

"They can't talk anymore!"

Vigethos gives the crowd a moment to settle before turning back to the chimeras.

"So tell me, everyone—how do we break that spell?"

"The spell can only be broken with a kiss," Butterfly Cake declares, clutching her chest.

“But there’s a catch,” Master Cat-Thief snorts. “It only works if Fig Stew actually likes the one giving it.”

“And we have no idea who that might be,” Krenabis adds, though her tone suggests the opposite.

Mydei is on the verge of an out-of-body experience as he watches the little play unfold before his eyes. He’s so shocked he can’t even begin to think about how it came to this. All he knows is that the chimera standing before him—the person inside the mascot costume who appeared out of nowhere and now plays the hero—is the only one who can truly lift the curse.

Vigethos places a paw against its chin, pacing in circles as if deep in thought.

“Such a complicated situation,” it muses, finally stopping to nod to itself. “Fig Stew, do you mind if I try anyway?”

Mydei hears an “oh my gosh!” that sounds strangely similar to Lilgui’s as the chimera speaks. What is he even supposed to reply? Even though no one warned him about Vigethos’s participation, it seems everyone has already decided that Fig Stew should go along with it.

And for once, Mydei has never felt more in sync with the chimera’s feelings.

Silently, he gives a shy nod. He’s grateful for the costume, because he’s sure his face is burning the moment Vigethos steps closer and gently takes Fig Stew’s chubby paws in theirs. Mydei isn’t sure how Vigethos is supposed to mimic a kiss when their heads are so big, but he gets his answer when the white-and-gray chimera presses its plush snout against Fig Stew’s in a soft nuzzle.

Mydei can’t hear the crowd’s reaction over the pounding of his own heart. It’s far from a real kiss, yet somehow it makes him feel as if he’s receiving an overwhelming amount of affection, his chest swelling with emotion.

“Did it work?” he finally hears someone ask.

Then that all-too-familiar chuckle carries through the air.

“Of course,” Gummy Roll says, as if she’d known all along. “Any spell goes both ways. Meaning you only need one chimera to be in love for it to dispel.”

Mydei doesn’t have time to dwell on her words. Because the next thing he knows, Vigethos is whispering to him—as if they weren’t standing in the middle of hundreds of people, being broadcast live, their voices echoing across the park:

“That’s right. I’m sure it worked. After all—” The chimera pauses, and Mydei can hear the tremor and relief woven into its next words.

“—I “*awoo*” you, Fig Stew.”

Chapter End Notes

I had so much fun writing this chapter!

We're almost there folks :´) Next chapter *should* be the last, but there are some things I want to address still so if it gets too long I may split it into two. Can't help it, I'm a yapper. Shaoji would be proud.

I also added their dynamic on the tags because, uh, who knows what will happen when our boys are finally together? ( ͡° ͜ʖ ͡°)

Thank you so much for reading it until now. It's time we reap the rewards after so much drama *throws confetti*

Gotta go check my factory on Endfield now. See you soon ~

# Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Mydei panics when he realizes Phainon knows about his Fig Stew persona. Unable to hide it any longer, they finally are obliged to talk about their feelings.

Chapter Notes

Hey guys,
We are tipping our toes in horny teenagers territory. While this doesn't have anything explicit, keep in mind the rating of the fic. It's mostly meant for the next part.

Another important note:
Yeah... it ended up getting way too long. I had to pull one or two all-nighters, but the final part is fully written. I split it mostly because I'm slow as fuck to format, and I spend an entire day per chapter proofreading with a translator open in a tab. ;')

That said, I posted this today so I could finish formatting the final part tomorrow. Hope to see you there!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon knows.

For fucking Titans' sake, Phainon *knows*.

That's the only thought looping in Mydei's mind as he stares in mute shock at Vigethos' oversized plush head. Under no other circumstance would that "*awoo*" have come up.

How? How did he figure that Mydei was Fig Stew? And since when?

"Is Fig Stew alright?" he hears someone ask nearby.

No, he's not. If he felt faint before, now he's on the verge of blacking out from sheer nervousness.

"Fig Stew?" Vigethos calls, stepping back just a little to give him space—like it would be possible to take a deep breath inside a mascot costume.

He needs to say something. *Anything*. They're in the middle of hundreds of guests, and this is

supposed to be work. Even if it doesn't feel like that anymore.

"I—…" Mydei starts, but there are no words left. His mind grinds to a halt, caught on the fact that Phainon *awooed* at him from inside Vigethos' costume—just like Mydei himself had done weeks ago. And just like what Mydei had wanted to convey…

It feels far too much like a confession.

The crowd's murmurs grow louder, and with them, Mydei can't bear the thundering rhythm of his heart, the heat flooding his entire body, and the tremor settling into his shoulders and legs.

"I—I…" he tries again, but falters. He can sense not only Vigethos' concern—the other chimeras shift uneasily, as if worried about what is happening to him.

"Did we break him?" Master Cat-Thief wonders quietly, her voice stripped of its usual playful lilt.

"Wa—was it too much? Oh dear…" Butterfly Cake whispers nervously.

Kremnoans are not cowards. But feeling seen like that—and having literally no room to breathe inside that costume—is not helping. He needs a break. He needs to get away somewhere quiet, even if only for a minute, to collect himself before dealing with whatever is going on.

His brain then blurts out the very first thing that comes to mind. Something that can give him an excuse to retreat.

"—I need to pee."

The crowd and the chimeras fall into stunned silence at the declaration. Thankfully, the costume's narrow field of vision spares him from most of their baffled expressions, but one thing is certain.

The staff restrooms are just behind one of the plaza's buildings.

And before anyone can say another word, he bolts.

Mydei isn't sure how his legs don't give out as he reaches it in record time and slams the door behind him, locking it. There's a faint noise from outside—the reverberation against the walls suggesting the announcer is covering for his abrupt exit. The cheerful music starts again, muffled by the restroom door.

Finally alone, he rips off Fig Stew's headpiece and lets it drop to the floor, inhaling deeply as air fills his lungs for the first time in what feels like hours. He lowers the costume to his waist, clutching his chest as he struggles to steady his heartbeat.

Did Phainon and the girls set him up to be confessed to during their part-time job? Is that

why they were acting so strangely?

Mydei feels foolish for not realizing it sooner. And yet, he's still trying to understand why Phainon would go so far as to *awoo* back at him. Had he realized it was a confession all along?

If he did, then…

Does that mean Phainon likes him, too?

Instead of calming, his heart surges faster as his face burns.

"—Mydei?" a familiar voice calls from the other side of the door, and Mydei almost jumps out of his skin.

"Hey… Are you alright?"

His feelings are on the verge of bursting out of his chest. What the hell is this? Shouldn't he feel… happy? If Phainon is returning his feelings, it means they can be together. For real. However, his treacherous mind still lingers on a single thought:

*What about Cyrene?*

"Mydei—" Phainon's voice reaches him again, strained this time. "Please. Let me in? I can explain…"

Can he bear to face Phainon right now? There's a real chance he might black out for good. He doesn't want to—but what good would avoiding it do, when they'll inevitably have to face each other anyway?

"Mydei…" There's a thud on the other side, as if something collided with the door.

Amidst the panic and confusion, Mydei is scared. Scared that if he chooses to avoid this confrontation now, it might as well be the last chance he'll ever have with Phainon.

So, for once, he shuts out his thoughts—and listens to his heart.

Slowly, he lifts his hand and unlocks the door with a soft *click*. It creaks open as Phainon pushes it forward almost immediately. He's still dressed in the full costume, save for Vigethos' headpiece, which he's holding in one of the suit's paws.

Mydei doesn't know what he expected, but Phainon's expression is clouded with worry as he takes in the state the Kremnoan is in. Mydei can't even bring himself to look at the mirror, afraid of what he might see. When Phainon finishes looking him over, he lets out a heavy exhale, his features softening slightly. He steps inside and closes the door.

"Must you always run away from me?" Phainon says, a half-smile on his lips that isn't cheerful at all.

What is he even talking about? Unable to avoid him now, Mydei struggles to find his voice, buried somewhere deep inside his own body.

"…Since when did you know?" he asks in a small voice, flicking his gaze away from those impossible blue irises.

"Know what?" Phainon pauses, considering. "That you were Fig Stew? Or… why you *awooed* at me?"

Mydei wants nothing more than to crawl into a hole. He folds his arms defensively across his chest, still refusing to meet Phainon's eyes.

"Both," he mutters.

Phainon stays silent for a while, then lifts his free paw to comb his slightly damp bangs back. Mydei notices he's without his glasses again.

"Is it really important?" he asks. "We have both been hiding things from each other for a while. I thought… maybe I could come clean for once."

Mydei swallows hard, forcing down the bile rising from sheer nervousness. There's no way out of this conversation. He tentatively lifts his gaze.

"Why would you… set up such a stage for this?"

"I wanted to let everyone know," Phainon says, sweetness seeping into his tone, "but especially you, Mydei—that I like you."

A lump suddenly forms in Mydei's throat. He wants to say it too—that he likes Phainon. Always has. But he needs to confirm that this isn't something born from the absence of his true crush, that Phainon didn't just get carried away by their fake date.

"You like me… because of what we did at the fake date?" His voice sounds strained, even to his own ears. His chest feels unbearably heavy as he adds, "Or… because your real crush is with someone else?"

Phainon's expression shifts into one of pure confusion.

"*What?*"

Is he really going to make Mydei explain it? There's no way he doesn't know what he's talking about.

"Your real crush, Phainon," Mydei snaps, annoyance bleeding into his words. "The one you keep blabbering about at every opportunity to Fig Stew—to me."

Phainon's mouth hangs open, and Mydei takes the cue to press on.

“It’s a little too convenient that she starts dating someone else, and suddenly I’m the next option.” Bitterness seeps into his tone—he’s had enough. He refuses to think of himself as a replacement. “Since our fake date went well, maybe you thought you should give it a try? As if I—… Hmph!”

Mydei’s monologue is cut short when, in the very next second, Phainon kisses him. It does a remarkably effective job of shutting him up.

Phainon closes the small distance between them, pressing close and pinning him lightly against the sink with the bulk of the fluffy costume as the headpiece slips from his grip. Mydei squeezes his eyes shut on reflex, overwhelmed by the sudden intensity of it.

Phainon’s insistent lips move against his, and Mydei’s mind goes blank when a tongue brushes his bottom lip in a plea for entrance.

He gasps, parting his lips slightly, and Phainon swallows the sound as he licks into his mouth. The sensation sends sparks racing down Mydei’s spine, his whole body flaring with heat as he tilts his head to deepen the kiss, meeting Phainon’s tongue with his own. His legs tremble, threatening to give out—thankfully, Phainon notices and steadies him, gripping his waist before lifting him in one swift motion onto the edge of the sink.

The lower half of the costume still separates them with layers of plush, but it’s enough for Phainon to settle between his legs.

Oh, Titans, such a kind reminder of how strong Phainon is doing things to his already mushed brain. He can feel the smirk in their kiss as his hands slide to the back of Phainon’s head, tugging at silver strands of hair while he melts completely into the embrace.

When they finally part for breath, hot puffs of air mingle between them, lips swollen and glistening. Half-lidded golden irises meet bright cerulean.

“You…” Phainon breathes, his plush paws still holding Mydei firmly in place. His cheeks are flushed, chest heaving, pupils wide as he plants a quick peck on Mydei’s parted lips. It tingles.

“Are the most thick-headed…” Another peck, and Mydei can’t stop the smile tugging at his lips.

“…infuriating…” A third peck, and Mydei scoffs lightly, resting his arms over Phainon’s broad shoulders.

“…and beautiful person in this whole world.”

Last remark aside, yeah—Mydei probably deserved the rest.

“What a sequence of compliments,” Mydei says, huffing out a quiet laugh, enchanted by the way Phainon gazes at him with unrestrained adoration. He absently toys with the ends of his

silver hair.

“Are those your pickup lines?”

“They’re custom-made just for you.” Phainon grins smugly, his plush paws circling soothingly around Mydei’s waist. The sensation is oddly funny, given how soft they are.

“Do you feel calmer now?” he asks quietly.

Mydei nods slowly. His pulse is still racing and his whole body feels warm, but the edge of panic is finally starting to fade.

“Good,” Phainon sighs softly. “I hope I got my point across. I like you, Mydei. No one else.”

It almost sounds like he’s being scolded—like a stubborn child who wouldn’t listen. Yet Mydei can’t stop the way his heart skips at those words. He stays silent as Phainon continues.

“I think you misunderstood something,” Phainon says, shaking his head. “But we’re not having this talk inside a toilet. Do you think you can wait until our shift ends?”

That snaps Mydei out of his dazed stupor.

For the Titans’ sake. They’re at their part-time job.

And they were just making out in the middle of it.

As embarrassment crashes down on him—holy shit, what was he thinking, bolting out of the plaza like that—he feels himself flush all the way to the tips of his ears.

“Right… We should go back…” Mydei admits in a small voice, anxiety creeping in as he realizes he’ll have to slip back into Fig Stew’s character once they step outside.

“Hey, relax,” Phainon says, releasing him so he can climb down from the sink and stand on his own. “I’ll be there with you.”

Before Mydei can even think of a reply, Phainon adds cheerfully;

“After all, we’re a couple of mascots now, too!”



When the duo returns to the plaza in their full costumes, Mydei realizes that some of the guests are still lingering around. The girls had been doing some damage control, mostly keeping the more fanatical fans busy while they were gone.

“Took you two long enough!” Master Cat-Thief scolds as soon as it spots them, planting its paws on its hips. The group led by Lilgui immediately turns in their direction like a pack of hawks.

“Are you feeling better, Fig Stew?” Krenabis asks worriedly as they approach. Mydei grimaces—his panic attack must have been frightening for all of them.

“I’m fine,” he assures them. Both Krenabis’s and Butterfly Cake’s posture visibly relax.

“Fig Stew! Please, we would love an interview with you and Vigethos!” Lilgui pleads once she’s sure she can have both of their attention.

Well, there’s nowhere to run now. Mydei agrees, giving the girls some breathing room as they retreat to the staff quarters.

Once it’s just him and Phainon, Lilgui points her phone toward the duo, the crowd behind her falling into attentive silence.

“So, tell me—how did it all start? When did you two realize you liked each other?” she asks bluntly.

Mydei winces inside the suit. Are they even allowed to make shit up during a streamer’s interview?

Phainon, however, seems unfazed. He places a paw on his chin, striking a theatrical pose as if deep in thought. Since when was he so comfortable with theatrics?

“For me, ever since our first spar,” he replies smoothly, without missing a beat—surprising both Mydei and the gathered group.

“Ooh, so it was love at first sight!” someone says.

“More like love at first bite…” another adds.

They turn toward Fig Stew, who’s still recovering from the question.

*Shit.* He’s not being paid enough for this.

“…The same for me,” he says a bit timidly, crossing his paws over his chest.

He can hear Phainon chuckle beside him.

“I have a question too!” Lilgui’s brunette sidekick raises her hand. The duo waits for it. “If it were another chimera who lifted the curse, how would you react, Vigethos? Let’s say… Butterfly Cake, for example.”

That girl is really dead set on her ship, huh.

“Well…” Vigethos trails off, but his tone is anything but friendly. “I would never harm Butterfly Cake. But I might need some time away on a mission, just for safety.”

Mydei stares at Phainon in disbelief at how naturally that rolled off his tongue. The crowd erupts in murmurs as the brunette pales slightly.

“Uh… this reminds me of the Flame Reaver arc…” someone whispers.

“Perhaps there’s some leftover of it?” a girl wonders.

Why the fuck is he being possessive even dressed as a chimera? No, screw that. Thinking twice, it’s probably perfectly in character for Vigethos.

“Oh! Uh, such a display of loyalty to its partner!” Lilgui tries to sugarcoat it, though the threat had been crystal clear.

She goes on to ask a few more questions about how being together might affect their relationship in the cartoon, but Phainon smartly dodges them, saying they can’t reveal any upcoming plots beyond the special. Finally, Lilgui leans forward eagerly:

“Can you please say *awoo* to each other, then? I need it for my VOD!”

*For the Titans’ sake.*

He’s paying the price for running away earlier, isn’t he?

“Of course,” Vigethos says a bit too cheerfully, and Mydei can practically hear the smirk in his voice.

Turning toward him, Vigethos takes his paws again in a reprise of the play. Without a moment’s hesitation, he declares,

“Fig Stew, I *awoo* you.”

Mydei is grateful for the cover of the costume. His face burns as he clenches his teeth and swallows the lump in his throat. He tries to say it loudly, but it comes out as little more than a murmur.

“… I *awoo* you, too.”

Lilgui squeaks, and some guests echo an “aww” as they snap pictures of the moment. Great. Now, if anyone besides the mascots ever finds out about his part-time job, he’ll have an endless supply of blackmail material.



Focusing on his work actually did Mydei good, pulling him out of his spiraling thoughts. Once they're free from the fanatics, Mydei spends his time entertaining the kids, with Phainon by his side the whole time. Most just ask for pictures, though every now and then someone wants to see them holding paws or even "kissing" chimera-style for the camera. Vigethos, of course, obliges every time.

Some also asked what *awoo* meant, and Phainon had apparently already added it to his dictionary. Each time, he answered: "It's a word for when you like someone."

It spreads surprisingly fast, and by the end of their shift, couples and even parents are playfully saying "*awoo*" to each other.

Mydei even finds himself wondering if it'll reach the Kremnoan language someday.

"Cinema! Simply cinema!" Mr. Reca exclaims excitedly once all the mascots are reunited at the staff headquarters. Fig Stew and Vigethos are the last to arrive.

"The curse's conclusion was a huge success with the fans!"

Mydei is somewhat relieved that his panic attack didn't affect the outcome after all. Still, he's surprised he isn't being scolded for it.

Mr. Reca turns to Castorice.

"My dear, your idea was brilliant. Getting someone to play Vigethos was the last piece we needed!"

Mydei stares at her, dumbfounded. They're all still in costume, minus the headpieces. Castorice is sitting beside Cipher, and she blushes deeply at the praise.

"I—I just thought Vigethos would be a perfect fit…!" she says as if she needs to justify herself, gesturing toward the chimera in question. "A—and Phainon also offered to play it…"

Mydei narrows his eyes at him. There's definitely more to that story. Phainon lets out a soft huff of laughter.

"It was fun. Thanks for having me on such short notice, Mr. Reca," he says, wearing that charming half-smile.

"Regardless! I'm sure the writers will be delighted by the outcome. We're already trending on socials," Mr. Reca declares, throwing both hands up as if envisioning a billboard. "I can already imagine the special '*I Awoo You*' topping the charts later this year!"

Mydei winces. Are they really going to name it like that?

“That title sounds so cute,” Hyacine giggles.

“What about our payment, boss?” Cipher asks from her chair.

“Credits should arrive by tomorrow. The exclusive merch will take a little longer to manufacture,” Mr. Reca clarifies. “They’ll be sent to the address you listed in the contract.”

Cipher whistles. “Sounds good. Can’t wait to get my hands on it.”

Castorice frowns in reproach. “You’re selling it again…”

Cipher shrugs.

The conversation is cut short when Mr. Reca’s phone rings. The ringtone sounds suspiciously similar to the park’s background music. Is the man really *that* obsessed with his job?

“My, I need to take this,” he says, practically vibrating with excitement. “My dear mascots, it was a pleasure having you. The *Awoo* studio won’t forget your contribution!”

The manager bows before hurrying out of the room, already speaking rapidly into the phone until his voice fades down the hall.

Mydei still doesn’t know what to make of all this. It’s hard to believe such a silly rumor ended up adapted into his favorite show.

“Well, then,” Cipher says, rising from her chair and stretching with a groan. “Work’s done. Don’t know about you guys, but I’m spent.”

“Yes, and it’s getting late. We should clean up and head home,” Hyacine agrees, glancing at the clock. If Mydei remembers correctly, both she and Cipher live quite far from the park—just like Phainon.

“Right…” Castorice glances guiltily at Mydei, clasping her paws together nervously. “And Mydei, I… um, sorry for overwhelming you earlier. The play was indeed my idea.

Mydei sighs. He isn’t angry at her for setting it up—it wasn’t her fault she couldn’t predict how it would turn out. His retreat may not have been graceful, but it was strategic. At least he didn’t hit the ground.

“It’s fine. I’m still alive.”

Phainon chuckles.

“Barely.”

Mydei elbows him, though with the costume’s thick plush, it barely registers. Castorice visibly relaxes. The trio exchange knowing looks before saying their goodbyes and heading

to the baths to change.

Mydei gathers his belongings and sets the Fig Stew headpiece on the central desk. When he lifts his gaze toward the mirrors, he notices Evernight. She's been sitting at the back the entire time, quietly scrolling on her phone. When the room falls silent, she finally looks up.

"Oh. We're already done?" Evernight asks, as if she hadn't heard a single word since Mr. Reca's reunion speech. Mydei has no idea why she even works as a mascot, given her immense lack of interest in the cartoon.

"Yeah. We're dismissed," Phainon says casually. "You coming too, Evernight?"

The pale pink-haired girl flicks her gaze between them before grinning.

"Go ahead. I fear I've already meddled enough with you two," she chuckles. "And some things certainly aren't meant for my ears, right, Mr. Class Rep?"

Phainon shifts awkwardly as he nods. Mydei squints at her. Since when have she and Phainon talked like they've known each other?

Phainon doesn't let him dwell on it. He wishes Evernight a good night and drags Mydei toward the staff baths.

The baths are private—thank the Titans—so they take one each, and Mydei is finally relieved to be free of the stifling costume for good. He forces himself to focus on nothing but washing up, for the sake of his own heart. He doesn't want to address their earlier talk just yet.

But for Phainon, one thing seems clear: he really expects them to date. He's confessed twice already. Meanwhile, Mydei has been so caught up in his own spiraling thoughts that he hasn't even properly returned those feelings.

Well.

He will. Soon.

Anxiety settles in as he changes into clean clothes and slings his bag over his shoulder. When he steps outside, he almost chokes.

Phainon is already waiting for him. And he's wearing a fucking *suit*.

It's deep blue and fits his form perfectly, leaving no suggestion about the defined muscles underneath it. A white dress shirt peeks out from underneath, paired with black slacks. Thankfully, there's no tie otherwise, Mydei might think he'd stolen Mr. Reca's wardrobe. But the black choker from their date rests snugly at his neck, like a deliberate reminder of that day.

Phainon catches him staring, obviously. A smirk tugs at his lips.

“Like what you see?”

Mydei wants to slap himself.

*Get a fucking grip*, he scolds internally. Clearing his throat, he does his best to act normal about his crush looking that good.

“What’s the occasion?” he asks as casually as he can manage—poorly.

“Well,” Phainon begins, a mischievous glint in his eyes, “today’s a special day. There’s someone I’ve been wanting to ask out for a long time.”

Mydei can already feel his insides flutter, warmth creeping up his chest. He decides to humor him, crossing his arms.

“And who’s that?”

Phainon rolls his eyes, though a soft laugh escapes him.

“I’ll show you. Come with me?”

He extends a hand. Without a second thought, Mydei takes it.



"*Mnestia's Tunnel?*" Mydei reads the big neon sign aloud, baffled.

Phainon has guided them to one of the park's attractions. There was nothing in the contract about mascots being allowed to ride after their shifts, since they were technically still inside the park—but Mydei had never even considered it. Usually, he was far too exhausted to think about rides once he got out of costume.

"Yeah. Can we ride it?" Phainon asks in an expectant tone, eyes sparkling as if it's the most entertaining thing ever.

The attraction, as the name suggests, is aimed at couples. It's a slow ride along a calm river through a dimly lit track themed around Cerce and Mnestia's love—passing through a recreation of the Titan of Wisdom's tree trunks, decorated with Mnestia's golden nymphs to create an intimate ambience. It's one of the few attractions that stays open until nightfall.

Does Phainon want to ride it that much with him? The thought makes Mydei a little nervous, but he doesn't see a reason to refuse. They're… well, practically an official couple now.

Mydei gives a small nod, and Phainon smiles brightly as he pulls them toward the empty queue. It's close to park closing time, but there's still enough room for one last ride. The employee in charge doesn't look thrilled, yet dutifully guides them to an empty cart.

They take their seats on the leather bench, a bit too small for two tall, grown teens. Mydei slides his bag under the seat as they wait for the ride to start. Their shoulders and thighs touch in the secluded cart, their hands still linked.

As expected, it moves slowly. Soft ambient music plays while the track carries them up the river, golden nymphs projected along the way, their glow illuminating the dim tunnel. Mydei has to admit—it's cozy.

"Mydei," Phainon calls, almost startling him. His thumb rubs gently over Mydei's palm, a quiet gesture meant to keep him calm. "About earlier…"

He trails off, seemingly unsure how to continue. His bright blue eyes search Mydei's golden irises as he speaks with measured caution.

"What did you mean… about my real crush?"

Mydei's jaw tightens. He expected the question, but answering it is an entirely different matter. Still, even if he wanted to run, there's nowhere to escape unless he's willing to dive into the river. And he already learned his lesson after going home in drenched clothes last week.

Still… it shouldn't be news to Phainon. So why does he feel so hesitant?

His gaze drops to their linked palms. Mydei remembers how he once thought his crush's hand was meant for Cyrene's alone. But now, looking at them together like this, fingers laced so naturally… it feels almost like a perfect fit

His chest tightens at the thought.

"I was talking about her," Mydei says quietly, the words coming out small and defeated. He'd spent far too long resenting what she could have while he couldn't. "…Cyrene."

A beat of silence. Phainon's thumb stills, as if struck by some sudden revelation. After what feels like minutes, he finally echoes:

"*Cyrene?*"

Mydei nods slowly, the familiar bitterness resurfacing at the mere mention of her.

"You thought I had a crush… on Cyrene?" Phainon repeats, incredulous. Mydei grows annoyed and turns his gaze to the glowing scenery instead.

"You're always close to her. You two seemed… happy together. Since the very first day," Mydei vents, lost in the memory of the pink-haired girl's arrival. "And… one day, you told Fig Stew you would never give up on your crush. That was right after she showed up dating that girl."

He can feel Phainon's stare piercing through him.

"Oh…" Phainon finally says, his brilliant reply sounding more bewildered than anything else. The surprise in his tone makes Mydei wonder why it shocks him so much.

"Titans," Phainon says slowly, his voice wrecked. "Mydei… you assumed I had a crush on Cyrene all this time?"

Is it so fucking hard to understand?

"Are you denying it?" Mydei snarls. It's hard to believe otherwise, not after everything he's seen day after day at school.

"Mydei, look at me." Phainon lifts his free hand, cupping Mydei's chin and gently guiding his face toward him. There's pain written all over his expression, and Mydei can't fathom why.

Phainon takes a deep breath, rolling the words out with heartfelt honesty.

"Cyrene is a very dear friend to me. But that's all. I've never had any romantic interest in her. All she's done these past years is support me—encouraging me to ask you out."

*What.*

It doesn't make sense. And yet… it doesn't sound like a lie. If that's true…

"Then… who…?" Mydei trails off, as if the ground beneath him has vanished

Who had Phainon been talking about all this time? If not Cyrene, then who had he been suffering over?

Phainon lets go of his hand, reaching instead into his pocket and pulling out his phone.

"I'm afraid you won't believe me unless I show you," he says, already opening his gallery.

From his position, Mydei can't help catching glimpses of the screen. He doesn't want to pry into Phainon's privacy—but that's hard when it's right there. The most recent photos are from their date. Phainon scrolls quickly, images blurring past until the timestamp at the top reads: *two years ago.*

Mydei starts to feel faint again, but for an entirely different reason. When Phainon taps the photo and expands it to full view, Mydei stops breathing. Phainon draws the device closer to his face as he speaks, voice fraying at the edges.

"This person is my real crush."

The photo shows a younger Phainon, his expression utterly radiant—cheeks faintly flushed, smile bright, as if he were the luckiest person alive. Leaning against his shoulder, fast asleep, is another boy: golden bangs dipped in red framing his face softly as Phainon holds him close at his side. Cherry petals scatter across the desk above their tutoring notes, frozen in the image like a memory of spring.

Mydei's eyes burn as he stares at the picture—at the sweet memory it summons.

"It has always been you, Mydei. Only you," Phainon mutters, his voice trembling. Mydei can't stop the small sob that escapes him as his vision blurs.

Mydei lifts his gaze to Phainon, unable to look at the picture anymore—it pierces straight through his heart. Phainon's deep blue irises are glassy, though a small smile still clings stubbornly to his face.

Shame presses down heavier than ever. Shame for assuming something that never existed, simply because he couldn't believe that someone like Phainon—so sweet, so gentle—could ever feel the same way about him. He can't even begin to understand what could have led someone so warm to look at him with such tenderness.

In the end, the person who had everything within reach and still denied it wasn't Cyrene.

It was himself.

"W—why…" he manages through the lump in his throat, the sobs refusing to stop. He lifts a

hand to rub at his eyes, fully aware that the tears are already spilling freely. Drawing in a shaky breath, he forces himself to continue. “Why… why didn’t you ever say anything?”

Phainon leans forward until their foreheads touch. He lets the phone rest against his thigh and cups Mydei’s cheek, carefully brushing away the tears as his brows knit together.

“I thought you hated me,” he says softly—and the words cut deeper than anything else could. “You were always running from me. Like my presence bothered you.”

Mydei squeezes his eyes shut, shame pressing down harder in his chest. His behavior must have hurt Phainon continuously, and for so long. He thought he was protecting his own heart, but in truth, he’d been driving Phainon away—cutting him with every retreat, every cold shoulder. His chest aches as he recalls each flicker of pain he’d seen in Phainon’s features.

It had been because of him.

“I didn’t hate you,” Mydei whispers at last, his voice breaking. “I was just… scared. I didn’t think I was someone you could ever choose.”

Phainon exhales shakily, his thumb still warm against Mydei’s cheek.

“I already did,” he says. “A long time ago.”

The words sink into Mydei like a lifeline.

“I’m sorry…” he sniffles.

“Don’t be,” Phainon whispers, his breath warm against Mydei’s skin. “As much as you pushed me away, you—well, Fig Stew—brought us closer again. If anything, I’m grateful.”

Mydei’s golden irises lift to meet cerulean blue. Phainon’s hand finds his, squeezing gently to ground him. With a soft exhale, he continues:

“Fig Stew gave me the courage to do this.” His fingers trace down Mydei’s cheek, hovering just above his bottom lip, as if memorizing every detail. “So, let me ask, just this once…”

Mydei’s heart soars in anticipation as Phainon leans back slightly, taking a deep breath like he’s finally releasing a weight he’s carried for years.

“Mydeimos… Will you be my boyfriend?”

Mydei’s vision must be playing tricks on him. Surrounded by glowing golden nymphs, the light reflecting in Phainon’s expectant blue irises is breathtaking. The dim glow gives him an almost angelic radiance. As his breath catches and his heart yearns, Mydei can’t contain what he’s held back for so long.

Here, with Phainon’s feelings laid bare—just as Fig Stew had once done—Mydei finally finds the voice that had been locked away in the depths of his heart, bound by a self-inflicted

curse. And like a broken spell, he whispers:

“Yes,” he says shakily. If tears are still flowing down, they’re not from shame anymore.

Because for once, he loses himself in the fullness of his own feelings as he says:

“I like you, Phainon.”

The reaction is immediate. Phainon’s mouth falls open, as if he’s been struck speechless. For a heartbeat, he can only stare, trying to process the words. And then his cheeks flush, his glassy eyes finally giving in—like Mydei’s, his tears are born of happiness. His lips curve into a smile so radiant it makes Mydei’s chest lurch with adoration.

As the track nears its end, they close the small distance between them. The kiss they share is gentle and unhurried, so tender it sets their hearts fluttering like Mnestia’s nymphs themselves—a silent blessing. The warmth that had sprouted two years ago is finally allowed to bloom, unfolding into a delicate blossom.



The Mnestia's Tunnel employee looked rather curious about why the duo left the ride with visibly puffy eyes. Somewhere along the way, they managed to stop the tears, but the same can't be said for Mydei's racing pulse as he walks to the park's station, hand in hand with his boyfriend.

The thought alone makes him giddy.

He knows he still has much to reflect on—he can't even begin to imagine how to make up for two years lost to his own choices. But right now, he is happy. And nothing can take that away.

"Say, Mydei…" Phainon says once they reach the station. He seems a bit nervous as he glances at the subway itinerary, adjusting his collar. "Would you like to have dinner at my house?"

Mydei's thoughts freeze. He stares at Phainon, dumbfounded.

"We've been together for ten minutes, and you're already inviting me over?" he says flatly, making Phainon wince.

"It's nothing like that," he says quickly, frustration clear as he waves his free hand in denial.

Mydei can't resist the smirk tugging at his lips.

"Really? Shame," he teases, fully aware of the implication of his words.

Phainon's face flushes red as he frowns back at the Kremnoan.

"My mom wanted me to invite you over since last week," he explains. "She's very eager to meet you."

Mydei blinks, studying him for a moment. Well, he supposes he will meet Phainon's parents sooner or later. He just doesn't expect it to be this soon. But if you take into account how much time they've already lost, maybe it isn't that strange. Perhaps he can start compensating by accepting it.

It certainly has nothing to do with him not wanting to leave Phainon's side.

"Sure," he agrees with a soft sigh, pulling out his phone. "I'll just let my mother know I'll be arriving late."

Phainon stops him with a hand hovering over the screen, his tone decisive.

"I live almost an hour away, Mydei. If you're coming home with me, you're staying there

until tomorrow."

*Oh.*

Now it's Mydei's turn to feel flustered. He swallows, trying to come to terms with the fact that this is, indeed, an invitation to sleep over.

It's fine. He can totally sleep in the same house as Phainon without being weird about it. His parents are there, too. And he surely must have a guest room or a sofa in the living room.

Nothing can go wrong, right?

"Okay…" he mutters, still a bit bewildered as Phainon finally lets his phone go, satisfaction radiating from him.

They shift from the subway station to the bus stop. After a few minutes, they board, and Phainon insists on paying for the ride until Mydei rolls his eyes and lets him have his fun.

Once the engine starts, they're already seated at the back, with Mydei by the window. There's still a long way to go, so he takes the opportunity to bring up a few things he's been curious about, hoping to soothe his restlessness at the thought of spending the night.

"How did you get Vigethos' character so well?" Mydei asks. The question has been lingering at the back of his mind since Phainon appeared dressed as the chimera. If not for the initial shock of hearing his voice, he would have been impressed by the portrayal.

Phainon sheepishly scratches the back of his neck.

"Oh, I did a bit of research at home," he explains. "I watched some scenes and trailers. I also read their profile on the official site…"

Mydei hums. He's impressed that Phainon managed to grasp so much from just that, but he's not about to admit it out loud. Instead, he says, "Castorice did well choosing them for you."

Phainon flicks his gaze between the view outside and Mydei in an almost guilty manner. Mydei tilts his head in silent question.

"Well, uh… It's actually me who chose Vigethos," he admits, and at first Mydei doesn't understand why that would be so shocking. That's until Phainon adds, "I asked Castorice to scout which chimera you thought Fig Stew has a crush on. I would play any chimera you chose."

Oh. So that's why Castorice and Cipher were all over the place when they visited him.

Mydei averts his gaze, feeling funny. That is… unexpectedly cute. He absent-mindedly plays with his braid to distract himself.

"Then all that setup came from you?" he asks.

“Most of it. I reached out to Castorice when I decided I wanted to confess to you as Fig Stew’s crush,” Phainon replies. “She did suggest doing it through a play, though. After asking Mr. Reca about it, he seemed thrilled by the idea and included me as a mascot.”

Phainon shifts in his seat a little as he continues.

“I have to admit I was kind of surprised when Castorice revealed that not only she, but also Cipher and Hyacine, were mascots. I felt a bit stupid for not noticing it sooner.”

“So you were off the charts this week because…” he trails off.

Phainon nods, offering him a half-smile.

“I was researching the character and practicing the script with the girls,” he says softly. “I also had to go to the park a few times during the week to take measurements for the costume. They got it ready almost at the last minute.”

Mydei blinks a few times as he pieces it together. Then he looks back at him, a sudden realization dawning.

“How did you know Evernight?” he asks, remembering how Phainon had referred to her so casually before. They must have told her about the play sometime during the week, but Mydei is certain it wasn’t at school.

To his surprise, Phainon hesitates, his body tensing.

“Uh—” He scratches his chin, suddenly finding the bus aisle very interesting to stare at. Mydei arches an eyebrow, waiting. “When you were sick, I sought her out… about you.”

“What?” Mydei asks, not grasping what he means.

Phainon hunches forward, elbows on his knees, hiding his face in his hands.

“I… thought you two were dating,” he says in a tight voice. Mydei stares at him, wide-eyed, trying to process the words.

“...*What?*” he repeats, completely lost.

Phainon takes a deep breath, sliding his hands down from his face and combing his bangs back.

“You were being all secretive with her at school. I thought—” His jaw tightens as he stops himself, brows creasing. Just the mention of it seems to make him uneasy. “It was easier to imagine than the two of you being park mascots, honestly.”

Mydei stares at him in silence, bewildered. Phainon’s usual gentle expression is shadowed by something darker—the same flicker that had crossed his face briefly during their date. Mydei

thinks back on it, on how he had kept Phainon at a distance while suddenly seeking out the pale pink-haired girl, seemingly out of the blue. The more he dwells on it, the heavier the guilt gnaws at him.

So that day Phainon went to the park, heartbroken…

"You were jealous of her," he concludes aloud, his chest feeling heavy.

Phainon lifts his gaze, a pained smile tugging at his lips.

"I guess we're both fools."

Mydei's heart stings. How could he have been so blind all this time? His friends were right—he really had left his brain back at Kremnos. Is it truly all right for him to allow himself to be happy after making Phainon suffer so much? His shoulders draw inward as he chews on his bottom lip.

"It's all my fault…" he murmurs, his voice nearly drowned out by the bus's engine.

"Hey," Phainon's soothing tone cuts through as he inches a little closer, their shoulders brushing while he cups Mydei's cheek. Though Mydei flinches out of reflex, the touch is warm, and he finds himself leaning into it. "It doesn't matter anymore. We're together, Mydei. I would slay a thousand witches and dress as a chimera every single day if it meant I could be by your side."

The image makes Mydei's lips curve up involuntarily. Silly as it is, it makes him feel cherished. Phainon's cerulean eyes shine again, though a tender emotion lingers in their depths.

Titans, Mydei wants to kiss him. He refrains, though, afraid he won't want to stop on just that. And there are plenty of passengers around. Instead, he scoffs lightly.

"That sounds like a lot of effort…"

Phainon only shrugs, a mischievous glint flashing in his eyes as he grins.

"Yeah," he says, and the way he looks at Mydei has him squirming a little in his seat. It seems Mydei isn't the only one holding back. Phainon takes his hand and presses a kiss to the back of his knuckles. "But you're worth the effort."

*By Nikador, I'm not surviving until tomorrow.* Mydei thinks as warmth rushes to his face, unsure whether being able to openly flirt like this is a blessing or a curse.



Mydei is surprised by how warmly he's welcomed at Phainon's house. Not even a second after Phainon opens the door, his mother is already on her way to greet them, gasping when her cerulean eyes land on the Kremnoan. The woman is petite, having to crane her neck slightly to look up at them.

"Oh my Kephale, you're *gorgeous*," she says, clapping a hand over her mouth in shock, and Phainon shifts awkwardly beside him.

"Mom…" he pleads, but she only frowns at him before ushering them inside.

Mydei watches the scene unfold, amused. He's glad to have made a good first impression, even if it's only because of his looks. Not everyone in Okhema would refer to a Kremnoan with so many piercings and tattoos as gorgeous first and foremost.

Well, like mother, like son.

When they enter the dining room, a delicious smell hangs in the air, making Mydei's stomach growl. The longer trip means it's already past his usual dinner time. Phainon's father sits at the head of the table, regarding the trio. His fluffy white hair matches his son's. Unlike Phainon's mother, however, he doesn't look particularly thrilled by Mydei's presence.

"Dad, Mom… this is my boyfriend, Mydeimos," Phainon says, a hint of pride in his voice as he rests a hand at the small of Mydei's back.

Nervousness surges through him, and he fights the flush creeping up his cheeks at being introduced so openly.

"Pleasure to meet you…" he says stiffly. Phainon's father rises and extends a hand, which Mydei takes almost on autopilot.

"Strong grip," he comments, apparently satisfied before letting go. "I'm Hieronymus. Nice to meet ya, kid."

He pauses, then sits back with a low growl. "Thanks for putting up with my son. He can be a handful sometimes."

"Dad!" Phainon whines, blushing in embarrassment as his father tsks. Mydei can't hold back a chuckle.

"And I'm Audata. Welcome, dear," Phainon's mother says warmly, stepping forward to wrap him in a hug. The gesture catches Mydei off guard, leaving him frozen until she pulls back. "Don't be shy, take a seat. I'll have dinner ready in just a minute."

He nods timidly as she heads back to the kitchen.

One thing is clear: this place is far livelier than his own home. Don't get him wrong—Mydei loves his mother, and she's wonderful to him. But she's almost always at work, coming home only at night, when she isn't away on business trips that last for days. And when he visited his father… well, it was like stepping into a museum. A mansion full of expensive furniture and almost no human warmth.

Most of Mydei's hesitation about the dinner melts away once they sit at the table. He quickly learns that Hieronymus is rather hard-headed, rolling his eyes every time Audata gushes about how her son brought home such a beautiful young man. Audata, on the other hand, wastes no time inviting him over again, insisting that the house is always open to him.

Her food is delicious. She explains that it's a family recipe from when they still lived in Aedes Elysae, and Mydei commits it to memory as she describes the ingredients. When Phainon brings up that Mydei is an amazing cook himself, it's almost as if her eyes light up with glee.

"Hiero, he's perfect," she sighs dreamily, her eyes misting as her husband groans.

"Get a hold woman, stop drooling over your son's boyfriend."

Audata turns to him, her expression shifting into a smug grin.

"Aw, are you jealous?" she teases, poking his arm. "You know you're still number one in my heart, darling."

"Tsk," Hieronymus snorts, taking a mouthful of food all at once. Mydei notices the faint hint of red on his face and can't hide his smile. He imagines it must be nice to grow old with your partner and still be so clearly in love with each other.

Mydei's gaze shifts to his side almost unconsciously. His heart skips a beat when he notices Phainon is already watching him with an unreadable expression.

"What?" he whispers, since his parents are still lost in their own little world.

Phainon's lips curve up slightly, though he remains silent. Mydei nearly jolts when he feels Phainon's hand settle over his thigh beneath the table, giving it a light squeeze in a gesture that says only one thing:

*Mine.*

For Titan's sake, he can't possibly be jealous of his own mother… can he? Maybe Mydei has underestimated just how possessive his boyfriend can be.

"Nothing," Phainon finally replies, feigning innocence as he drinks in Mydei's bewildered look. Mydei tries to ignore it and focus on his plate, but the scoundrel keeps his hand there, tracing small circles against his thigh even when his mother turns her attention back to them.

Thankfully, Mydei's rising panic keeps things from escalating any further. He makes a mental note to scold Phainon about it later, but manages to keep his composure throughout dinner.

When he offers to wash the dishes, Audata insists on treating their guest fully tonight. Still a little flustered, Phainon seizes the chance to show him where he'll be sleeping, while his parents wish them a good night.

And just like that, Mydei forgets he's supposed to stay mad when Phainon leads him into his own room.

"You can take the bed. We've got a spare mattress," Phainon says casually as Mydei lingers at the doorway. The room is on the first floor—small and cozy, with a large study desk neatly organized in the corner.

"… I can sleep on the couch," Mydei suggests.

Phainon is already pulling sheets from his wardrobe. He peeks through the door, blinking at his boyfriend through his glasses—the first thing he grabbed after coming in.

"Huh? No way," Phainon disagrees with a frown. "Besides, my dad likes watching TV in the living room until he falls asleep. Mom has to drag him to bed almost every night."

*Titans spare me.*

Seeing him still hovering at the door, Phainon sets the sheets on the bed and steps closer.

"Mydei… are you uncomfortable sharing a room with me?" he asks gently, without any edge to his voice.

Mydei swallows. It feels a little silly, but he can't help being nervous. They've been officially dating for less than a day; his heart can only take so much at once.

"… I'm fine," he lies. Phainon studies him for a moment.

"We're both tired from work. Don't overthink it, let's just rest," he says with a soft sigh, rolling his shoulders.

Rich, coming from someone who had very clearly tried to stir him up during dinner. Maybe he's decided to be considerate for once.

Regardless, now that he's said it, Mydei realizes just how exhausted he is from their part-time job. He had pushed the fatigue to the back of his mind with everything else that had happened earlier. His eyes flick between the bed and Phainon before he finally agrees.

"Okay. But I'll take the spare mattress," he says firmly.

Phainon tilts his head with muted curiosity but doesn't press. He drags the spare mattress over, and Mydei helps him set it up. Luckily, Mydei has his own hygiene items tucked in his bag, so he's able to brush his teeth and get ready for bed without trouble.

Phainon offers him sleep clothes, but he refuses. The outfit he's wearing is comfortable enough—and besides, there's no way he'll get any rest if he's wrapped in Phainon's sweet

scent all night in those conditions. It already lingers in the room, and it's the main reason he's avoiding the bed.

Phainon changes a little later, now dressed in a loose blue shirt and sleeping shorts. He sits at the edge of his bed, watching Mydei from above as he pulls the sheets over himself.

"Were my parents too much?" he asks.

"They were fine," Mydei scoffs, fluffing his pillow. "Unlike their son, they're cute."

Phainon pouts.

"Hey, I'm cute too…"

Mydei lets out a small laugh. It's a ridiculous statement coming from a grown-ass teen. Even if he agrees, it's not something he's about to admit.

He's just starting to relax under the covers when Phainon speaks again.

"Mydei, I was thinking…"

Mydei shuts his eyes with a sigh. It's already hard enough to focus on sleeping under these circumstances, and his boyfriend isn't making it any easier. He hums softly, signaling that he's listening.
"We should fulfill that promise we made two years ago…" Phainon says, his voice hesitant. "You know, about watching *The Awoo Firm* together."

The words make Mydei halt mid-breath. He opens his eyes, meeting Phainon's expectant gaze.

"Why bring that up now?" he asks quietly, brows lifting.

"Well…" Phainon scratches his chin, his tone softening. "You love that cartoon enough to dress as one of its characters. I want to learn more about it… and about you."

While Mydei stares at him in bewilderment, Phainon adds sheepishly,

"And Vigethos seems like a cool character. That sword is dope."

The tender comment from before is quickly derailed, and Mydei rolls his eyes.

"Seems like someone already has a favorite," he teases.

"No way, my favorite is still Fig Stew," Phainon replies playfully. "They're the only chimera I would kiss."

Mydei throws his pillow at him, but Phainon laughs, catching it effortlessly.

"Just get to sleep already, dumbass."

“Alright, alright…” Phainon chuckles, handing the pillow back before turning off the light. “Have a good night, your highness.”

“’Night.” Mydei says, turning onto his side as his thoughts linger on the offer. He would gladly watch his favorite cartoon with his boyfriend anytime. It was what had kept him so eager for the day it would happen two years ago. He’s surprised to find the feeling still alive, thinking he had buried it deep enough never to resurface. That small flutter over something so mundane.

But sleep refuses to come. Maybe it’s because it’s been so long since he last stayed over, or maybe the floor feels too cool beneath the mattress. Even under the sheets, the chill seeps in.

He doesn’t know how much time has passed since the lights went out. Only a sliver of moonlight filters through the curtains, not enough to tell if Phainon is asleep. His breathing is steady, a sign that at least he must have been dozing off.

Mydei turns again, memories stirring. He recalls the day he fell asleep on Phainon. If only he’d had the courage not to run off afterward—would things have been different? If he had been braver to ask about his thoughts on his relationship with Cyrene… Or if he had allowed himself to think he was worthy of Phainon’s affections…

Those last two years could have unfolded in an entirely different way.

He wants to be happy and forget about everything else, but there’s still an insistent sting in his heart. One that slowly reminds him of how little time they will have to enjoy together before they have to part ways.

Only five months until graduation. And then it’s over. Phainon had told him back when they were still in tutoring that his goal was to go to Jarilo to attend the Belobog Institute’s engineering program. That’s the reason he studies so hard and maintains such high grades. But… it’s literally on the other side of the planet. Even if they try to stay in touch, the different time zones combined with the immense physical distance are bound to drift them apart. His own dream of coming back to Kremnos, studying gastronomy, and opening his own business now seems a little dull.

The sting deepens into a pulsing ache as the cold settles in. It feels like too much, like he should know better than to suffer over a fleeting relationship in his youth.

And yet, he does.

Because he knows there isn’t a single person on the planet he could ever imagine *awooing* to instead of Phainon.

Mydei sits up on the mattress, the sheets slipping from his shoulders. He glances toward the bed, catching only the faint silhouette in the darkness. His body moves before his mind can catch up.

He climbs onto the bed, finds the edge of Phainon’s sheets, and slips beneath them.

“Huh…? My—” Phainon’s voice is slightly raspy, a hint that he’s been fast asleep. He’s still half-unaware of what’s happening when Mydei shifts closer and buries his face against his chest.

“Not a word about this,” he mumbles, voice muffled against Phainon’s sleepshirt, his pulse quickening in a mix of embarrassment and fear of what he might say. His fists clutch the fabric of his boyfriend’s shirt tightly. There’s no plush armor to shield him, no excuse for exposing his heart so openly. It should be alright, though—they’re in a relationship now, right?

He feels Phainon stir as he becomes aware of their position. Mydei half expects teasing, but instead Phainon’s arm slides beneath his side, pulling him close.

“…You’re freezing,” he murmurs, worry edging his voice as he wakes a little more. His other hand finds Mydei’s hair, combing through the wild bangs in gentle strokes.

Mydei replies with a sound that’s half agreement, half grunt. He focuses on the steady rise and fall of Phainon’s chest, his heartbeat a steadfast rhythm against his ear. On the overwhelming, familiar scent of his skin and clothes that wraps around him like a second blanket.

Phainon’s warmth seeps into him; his embrace begins to thaw the cold dread that had settled in his bones.

*I like you,* he thinks. *I don’t want to lose you.*

Phainon remains silent as instructed, and when he kisses the top of Mydei’s head, Mydei lets out a small, surrendering breath, his muscles going slack. It feels cozy—so cozy he never wants to get up.

He lifts his face only slightly, enough not to suffocate against Phainon’s sleep shirt. His cheek rests against his ribcage, and somehow it feels nicer than the pillow from before. His fists unclench, hands settling lightly over his boyfriend’s body.

Gazing at the dark wall, he sighs in quiet contentment.

“…Talk about something nerdy,” he mutters.

Phainon chuckles, his chest vibrating beneath Mydei’s cheek.

“Really?”

Mydei stays quiet. He doesn’t want to explain that he likes being lulled to sleep by his voice. He almost doesn't believe Phainon will oblige until he hears a soft, considering hum.

“Did you know a dromas scale color can change based on their diet?” he begins. Mydei can’t contain the soft hum that slips out, urging him on. Phainon’s voice trembles as if he’s smiling when he continues. "Though they prefer redsoil, they can digest almost any regular food. For instance, if you feed them enough golden apples, they might eventually develop golden

scales. Mr. Anaxagoras is fascinated by it; he even offered to sponsor the dromas at the zoo to study the possibilities—"

Mydei has to admit that mentioning Mr. Anaxagoras is a brilliant strategy for inducing sleep. He feels his eyelids growing heavy as Phainon keeps talking about dromas scales pigmentation, the gentle combing through his hair never ceasing until, finally, he is freed from his own thoughts.

Chapter End Notes

Before grabbing your pitchfork, please note that I included the "Happy Ending" tag. ><

There was literally no other place I could cut this part. Sorry.

I felt like I couldn't finish this properly without addressing the future of their relationship regarding graduation. Don't worry, the ending is near and it's very sweet. Pinky promise!

See you tomorrow ❤

# Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Have you ever wondered what '*awoo*' truly means?

Chapter Notes

Hey guys :)
As promised, here is the last part.

**NSFW warning:** While not totally explicit, there are clear implications of NSFW content in this chapter. I put the "Softcore Porn" tag mostly for safety, but I chose to maintain it very subtle since I think it would fit more the overall lighter tone of the fic.

I hope you have fun!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That morning, Mydei learns that both he and Phainon are messy sleepers. When they wake, Phainon has half his body dangling off the edge of the bed, while Mydei is completely tangled in the sheets, face buried against his chest, one arm flung above Phainon's head. He might have been more embarrassed about the little trail of drool on his boyfriend's shirt if not for the fact that Phainon woke with strands of Mydei's hair stuck in his mouth.

Sure, the single bed being far too cramped for two didn't help, but Mydei wonders how it would go if they ever shared beds frequently—not that he wants to, of course. It's just a passing thought.

Hm… perhaps he should start to tie his hair before sleeping, just in case.

The morning sheds light on another problem:

They're about to head to school, and Mydei realizes he doesn't have his uniform with him. With no other choice, he accepts the spare Phainon proudly insisted on offering. Though they're about the same size, the shirt fits a bit on the tighter side around his chest.

Phainon studies him with a hand on his jaw, frowning.

"Actually, maybe we should ditch today…"

"*HKS*, shut up and get ready," Mydei retorts. He's not about to skip school over his boyfriend's over-the-top possessiveness, even if he secretly enjoys the attention.

They share breakfast before heading to the bus stop, and Mydei has to promise Audata he'll visit again soon. Watching her beam, he can't help but think he's found the source of Phainon's clinginess.

Since Phainon usually arrives at school early, they end up with plenty of free time before classes begin. They settle into the back of their classroom, sharing Mydei's earbuds while watching videos on his phone and swapping songs they like on the Memify app.

"You like Luofu pop?" Mydei asks with arched brows when Phainon chooses the next track. A catchy song from a boy band he never cared much about starts playing.

"Well, Cyrene always loved dragging me to watch L-Dramas, so it kind of grew on me," Phainon explains sheepishly. Mydei decides he might need to convert him to some rock and metal later.

Slowly, the room fills with students, most of whom are surprised by their obvious closeness —Phainon's hand had found its way around Mydei's waist somewhere along the line—and Castorice flushes deeply the moment she sees them.

"G—good morning…" she stammers in a high-pitched tone, hands clasped over her mouth as if she's witnessing a miracle unfold before her eyes.

"Hey, Cas," Phainon greets easily, while Mydei mutters a quiet good morning back. He had kind of expected that reaction.

She hurries to her seat, already pulling out her phone and typing furiously, no doubt spreading the latest gossip.

"We should tell the girls during lunchtime," Phainon suggests.

Mydei hums, but he's not thrilled about the idea. Mostly because he owes one of them an apology. While he never roasted the girl to her face, he had resented her unfairly in his thoughts many times. And if what Phainon said was true, she was also one of the reasons he hadn't given up on asking him out.

No wonder she had been fuming at Mydei the day Phainon had his breakdown. She was just being protective, knowing the only person who could have put him in that state was the Kremnoan.

The memory turns his stomach into knots.

"Can you ask Cyrene to come, too?" he asks in a small voice.

Phainon smiles at him fondly. "Of course."



The group gathers at their usual spot in the courtyard. Phainon had mentioned that Cyrene would drop by a little later after meeting her girlfriend, so for now it's just Castorice, Cipher, and Hyacine.

"Damn, just looking at you guys is giving me a toothache," Cipher teases from her spot on the grass, leaning back on her elbows.

They're only sitting side by side, but the radiant aura emanating from Phainon is unmistakable. Mydei feels a little self-conscious, knowing he's the one responsible for making him look so happy. He secretly wonders how he must look to them, too.

Obviously, the girls already know about their relationship. Still, they seem genuinely thrilled by it.

"I'm so happy for you!" Hyacine says excitedly. "We were worried you two might end up never confessing to each other…"

From what Phainon had told him, the girls were apparently always cheering them on silently. It must have been torturous to endure their strained dynamic for so long.

"That was almost the case," Phainon says with a playful glint in his cerulean irises. "Luckily, Fig Stew was there to open our eyes… right, Mydei?"

Mydei rolls his eyes, a faint blush dusting his cheeks.

"It almost sounds like a fairy tale, being reunited like that…" Castorice muses, her hands clasped together dreamily.

Cipher snorts.

"Looks like I'll be beta-reading another fanfic…"

Castorice flushes scarlet, hiding her face in her hands. Both Hyacine and Phainon laugh, while Mydei is left wondering what the hell she meant by that.

The chatter goes on until a very familiar voice chirps from behind.

"Hey guys," Cyrene says as she approaches, sitting delicately on the grass to complete the circle. Her orchid eyes scan the group, flickering briefly between Phainon and Mydei with a questioning glint. "Phainon was practically on his knees begging me to come earlier. What's the big news?"

*What the hell? She really doesn't know yet?*

The girls fall silent, leaving the reveal to them. It's Phainon who takes the lead.

“Rene,” he begins, finding Mydei’s hand and squeezing it lightly. Cyrene’s eyes widen in recognition. “We’re officially together.”

“Oh my Titans,” she gasps, covering her mouth with her hands. “Is that for real?”

“…It is,” Mydei says in a small voice, receiving a fond smile from his boyfriend. Cyrene is still recovering from the shock, staring at Phainon in disbelief.

“Why haven’t you told me anything, Phai!?” She puffs out her cheeks, earning a hearty laugh from him.

“I was planning to, but you’ve been so entertained with Stelle lately, I kind of postponed it…”

She flushes, caught off guard at being called out so openly.

“That’s right. You’ve been so glued to that raccoon we barely see you anymore,” Cipher teases, her tail wagging lazily. “Otherwise, you would’ve noticed all the gossip about our lovey-dovey couple here.”

“…!” Cyrene seems on the verge of combusting. Huh. Mydei never figured her for someone who would get so wrapped up in a relationship that she wouldn’t notice the rest of the world —even her childhood friend.

Maybe they had more in common than he had thought.

“Don’t worry, Rene. Phai and Dei only made it official today,” Hyacine comforts her. “But the shift in their behavior did start a few weeks ago.”

Cyrene slowly composes herself, flicking her long ponytail over her shoulder.

“It was about time, wasn't it? I’ve spent so much time lending Phai a shoulder to cry on over his Kremnoan baddie. I was worried he might end up single and caring for thirty cats.”

“Hey! That didn’t happen,” Phainon protests, flustered, as the girls laugh. Mydei stares at him, bewildered.

“'*Kremnoan baddie*?'”

He repeats it like an uncle who doesn’t understand the slang. It’s Phainon’s turn to flush, while Cyrene smirks at them.

“Would you like to know, Mydei?” she teases, inching forward provocatively. “What has Phai said about you during those endless nights on the phone?”

Mydei’s brows shoot up. Why the hell had he been resenting this girl? She suddenly seems like a very entertaining person to be around.

Phainon whines, desperately trying to shift the subject. Castorice and Hyacine giggle, while Cipher mutters, “Glad to be on your good side, Peach.”

It's… kind of fun, sitting here and enjoying time together with all of them like this. Another thing Mydei realizes he almost missed entirely, thanks to his stubbornness over the past few years.

Before leaving for class, Cyrene tugs Phainon's ear, making him promise to keep her updated on everything she missed. Then she turns to Mydei, her expression softening into a gentle smile.

"I'm glad you two solved this," she says earnestly.

Mydei shifts awkwardly, burying his hands in his pockets. He tries to gather the courage to say what he needs to.

"…I'm sorry," he begins in a small voice. Cyrene tilts her head curiously. "All this time, I had been avoiding Phainon…"

He swallows, feeling pathetic for admitting it out loud.

"…Because I thought you two were together."

Cyrene's mouth forms a little 'o' as she studies him. Somehow, there's no judgment there, just pure disbelief.

"Me and Phai? That would never be possible—he's like a brother to me," she argues. "Besides, ever since he first laid eyes on you, he's been long gone."

Mydei wants to hit his head against a wall. How had he never noticed any of that?

Phainon approaches, having lingered behind to give them privacy. When he stops at Mydei's side, he places a hand gently on the small of his back, his smile soft and reassuring.

"Do you want to know the first thing Cyrene said to me when she saw you in person?"

Mydei recalls the day he first saw the pink-haired girl. It was when she transferred back to Okhema, walking with her hands looped through Phainon's arm as if they were in their own little world. Back then, she had whispered something in his ear, making him blush—and the last thought that crossed Mydei's mind was that they were just friends.

As he drifts into the memory, it's Cyrene herself who answers, hands on her waist, her smile bright.

"I remember it clear as day," she says happily, her gaze tender as it settles on the two of them. "I said: Phainon, marry him."

*What?*

"I'm working on it," Phainon teases lightly, but Mydei is already red to the tips of his ears, burning with a mix of shock and embarrassment.

“You better,” Cyrene agrees, her voice softening as she winks at Mydei. “We have a lot of catching up to do, though, Mydei. You don’t know how much I wanted someone to vent to about Phainon all these years. Have you seen his wardrobe? We need to do something about it.”

“Hey, my clothes are perfectly normal!” Phainon protests, and the banter eases a bit of Mydei’s embarrassment.

He clears his throat, lips twitching.

“I may recall seeing a horrid sponge-yellow T-shirt at the park once…”

As Phainon whines and Cyrene laughs, Mydei is certain he’ll bond with his childhood friend in no time.



As the days pass, Mydei decides that he has never been happier. Though the dread of how little time they have still creeps in sometimes, Mydei tries his best to make the most of every moment. During the week, they're inseparable at school, and on weekends Phainon insists on showing him around Okhema—something the Kremnoan had never bothered with before.

He meets the dromas Mr. Anaxagoras sponsors at the zoo, goes to see countless movies with his boyfriend—though they always argue, since Phainon is a romcom enthusiast while Mydei prefers action—and discovers new flavors in cafés and restaurants along the streets, some of which he mentally notes to recreate later in the quiet of his home.

Sometimes they also hang out with the girls, going on group outings like karaoke. It surprises him when Cyrene invites Stelle and her chaotic group of friends—between Caelus and March's high-pitched, out-of-tune singing, Evernight seems to be enjoying herself as she taps her finger against the table to the rhythm, even if she doesn't participate much, always quiet in the back.

The girl had always been a mystery to Mydei. However, had she not started the Fig Stew's curse rumor, he might never have tried to amend his relationship with Phainon. While everyone is distracted by the singing, Mydei approaches her.

"Oh, big boy. Long time no see," she says casually as he leans against the counter with a small grunt.

"Not interested in singing?" he asks.

Evernight chuckles. "I'll leave that to those who actually enjoy it." Her blood-red eyes glint at him. "But if you pick another song, I'm afraid your little Dawn might try to steal you away."

By now, Mydei understands most of her riddles. His face flushes slightly as he recalls Phainon's gaze toward him when he sang earlier. He clears his throat.

"…I wanted to thank you," he says. "For coming up with that silly curse."

It was what had given him the courage to face Phainon again while wearing the Fig Stew mute plushie armor. Evernight tilts her head.

"No need to get sentimental, big boy," she says, resting her chin on her hand. "All I did was give a little push to two very oblivious teenagers."

Though it's embarrassing to admit, Mydei can hardly deny it. Evernight grins at him, her expression surprisingly gentle.

"Now, go on. Chase your happiness." She waves him off with a dismissive flick of her hand, though a mischievous glint sparks in those blood-red eyes. "If you stay here even one more minute, I fear Mr. Class Rep might have another breakdown."

Before he can even process her words, Phainon appears at his side as if summoned, startling Mydei and nearly making him spill his drink. Without hesitation, Phainon wastes no time meddling in the conversation, greeting Evernight while simultaneously stepping between them.

Evernight doesn't bother to hide her amusement. It seems that even after the curse's conclusion, some things remain entertaining.

With four months left until graduation, Mydei invites Phainon over to watch *The Awoo Firm* at his house one weekend. The silver-haired student meets Mydei's mother for the first time, and it's rather adorable how much he stutters while introducing himself. When Gorgo calls him "her son's cute boyfriend," it's as if Phainon is about to combust, his glasses clouding up from the heat.

After giving him time to recover, Mydei guides him to the living room, where they spend the evening watching the cartoon together. He even brings out his favorite Fig Stew plushie, proudly admitting he's had it since childhood. They sit close, the Kremnoan offering remarks about most of the episodes, and Phainon listening with affectionate attention, as if every word matters.

With three months left, Mydei introduces Phainon to his friends on a Saturday night during their gaming session. The group teases them mercilessly, playing sound effects of trumpets and clapping to congratulate the couple on finally making it official. They also make sure to let Phainon know he's dealing with a very temperamental prince, wishing him good luck as Mydei rolls his eyes. They invite Phainon to join them, but despite Mydei showing him the controls, he ends up dying at almost every boss.

"How the fuck is a nerd that bad at gaming?" Leonnius asks, baffled.

"Phainon is the other kind of nerd," Hephaestion explains matter-of-factly. "You know, the kind that actually studies."

"I feel attacked," Ptolemy sighs dramatically.

By the end of the session, Phainon is already practically part of the group. It warms Mydei's heart to see how almost everything in their lives is falling into place, one by one.

With only one month left in the semester, final exams are drawing near, meaning Phainon has to double down on his studies to recover from his disastrous summer results. Because of this, Mydei knows they won't be able to spend as much time together until finals are over, so he takes whatever moments he can get.

Phainon stays in the library for a while after class, and the Kremnoan accompanies him, even if only to kill time. He doesn't want to be a distraction again, since he was the cause of Phainon failing so badly before.

"What are you staring at?" Phainon asks, catching his gaze.

Normally, Mydei would entertain himself with his phone or review some of his own notes. This time, however, he's resting his head on his arms atop the desk, observing the cute frown on his boyfriend's face as he scribbles in his notebook, completely concentrated.

"Just watching my nerd boyfriend in his natural habitat," he teases with a grin.

Phainon lets out a small laugh, reaching over to ruffle Mydei's unruly strawberry-blond bangs. Mydei scoffs, but doesn't pull away.

It's comfy. He's so used to being around Phainon now that it feels almost wrong when they part ways after school. Mydei tries his best not to dwell on how much time they have left, but alone at home, he often finds himself opening his calendar app and counting the days, as a sense of dread settles in his chest.

He has tried thinking of ways to get around it. Maybe they could make it work somehow, with visits on holidays and video calls. For a brief moment, he considered the possibility of going with Phainon to Jarilo, but it was wishful thinking. He had next to zero chance of being accepted into any university there, and their gastronomy programs are nothing like what he wants to study. Besides, the idea of Mydei following him felt like a bit too big a step, even if they like each other a lot.

Above all, he doesn't want to tie Phainon down. Yes, the guy makes him impossibly happy right now, but there are billions of people in the world, and Mydei is just one of them. Once in Jarilo, there's a big chance he'll move on. His heart stings painfully at the thought.

Then, after exam week ends, the results are finally released. To no one's surprise, Phainon got near-perfect scores. His acceptance to Belobog IT is practically guaranteed. Though Mydei's heart aches, he congratulates him earnestly.

Phainon's bright smile makes it all worthwhile.

Only two weeks left.

Mydei starts to become clingier than usual. During lunchtime, his head constantly finds Phainon's shoulder. After class, his hand grasps Phainon's as he guides them to an empty stairway and kisses him with a hint of desperation.

It doesn't taste like goodbye—not yet. But the yearning grows.

They don't always get the chance to sleep over. With their parents around, it feels uncomfortable to visit too often. When they do, though, it takes only the faint background noise of the TV or desktop before their hands begin to wander. At first, timid touches and light caresses—testing, hesitant. It makes whatever is on the screen fade into the background. It doesn't matter who starts it; it always ends the same way, with heated kisses and curious touches beneath the fabric of their clothes. Never too much, but never enough.

If Phainon notices the shift in his attitude, he says nothing, instead indulging in Mydei's advances with almost no restraint. They stop before things get too heated, but even after they part ways, the warmth lingers.

It translates into late-night calls, when neither of them can fall asleep without hearing the other's voice. Mydei listens to Phainon talk about anything and everything, and it soothes his heart a little. But when Phainon's voice drops an octave, raspy at the edges as sleep clouds his judgment, he murmurs:

"Wish I could touch you right now,"

The warmth turns into a deep burning, consuming Mydei as his mind pictures those words becoming reality.

One week left.

*The Awoo Firm* special premieres on Friday. Mydei's mother is going on a business trip for two days, so at school, he invites Phainon to sleep over. Mydei busies himself with plans for what to cook, and it helps ease the dread of counting the days. It also makes him totally unaware of the way Phainon is watching him, a tender, endearing look in his eyes.

Graduation is next week. After that, Mydei will still have a few days in Okhema to say his goodbyes to his friends and mother. His trip back to Kremnos has already been planned since the beginning of the year, giving him enough time to settle back in the city before university starts.

But as Friday approaches, none of that matters. He's walking back home, hand in hand with his boyfriend. Okhema is painted in orange hues by the time they enter his neighborhood.

"Man, I'm gonna miss Okhema," Phainon says, his tone a bit too forced in its cheerfulness. "I've spent almost ten years here. It'll be hard to readjust."

Mydei hums. He knows Phainon will do just fine in Jarilo.

"Remember to not eat only salads," he teases.

Phainon pouts. "Hey, I know how to make other things!"

"But will you?"

"…Well, I'll never be able to cook like you, so it's not very enticing…"

Mydei rolls his eyes. He would gladly cook for him every day if he could.

He refuses to be sad about it today, though.

A little after they arrive, the day slowly bleeds into night. Mydei had already planned dinner: a honey carrot pie. Phainon offers to help as he gathers the ingredients from the fridge, and a warm, domestic feeling settles over them as they finish putting the meal in the oven.

It gives them enough time to shower and change out of their uniforms.

About an hour later, Phainon is setting the table while Mydei serves the portions.

Phainon leans in, catching the scent. “This smell would make even the Titans hungry,” he says earnestly as Mydei takes his seat in front of him.

“What a flatterer,” he scoffs lightly, making Phainon’s eyes crinkle with amusement.

“You love being praised for it, though.”

Mydei frowns as his cheeks flush, unable to deny it.

They eat in a surprising silence, as if lost in their own thoughts. When Mydei’s plate is finally empty, he notices Phainon staring at him with a peculiar glint in his eyes.

“What?” he asks, crossing his arms over the table.

“Mydei…” Phainon begins, and somehow his tone unsettles him. Mydei’s brows crease as Phainon continues, voice steady but weighted.

“I’ve been wanting to talk to you about something.”

Mydei swallows. It’s strange for Phainon to beat around the bush like this. He nods slightly.

“Go on.”

Phainon’s lips curve up ever so slightly. He slides his hand over the table, holding his palm open for Mydei to take. When the Kremnoan reaches out, Phainon intertwines their fingers. There’s a hint of nervousness in his posture—if the way his palms are sweating is any indication.

“About us…”

Mydei’s pulse quickens. Could it be? Could he be wanting to end things now, so they won’t have to deal with slowly drifting apart? The thought claws at him, sharp and unbearable.

Phainon squeezes his hand, as if pleading for him to stay with him until he finishes. Mydei fights back the trembling of his shoulders, dropping his eyes to the table, unable to hold his boyfriend’s gaze.

“I decided that I’m not going to Jarilo.”

What?

The silence that follows is heavy, stretching long enough for Mydei’s pulse to thunder in his ears. His golden irises widen as he slowly lifts his gaze, locking onto Phainon’s deep blue.

“…What do you mean?” His voice is small, tight, as though the words themselves are fragile. He struggles to understand, to believe what he’s hearing.

Phainon’s expression softens, but the nervousness lingers in the way his thumb brushes

against Mydei's knuckles. It's clear he's been holding this in for a while, waiting for the right moment.

"I've also applied to Kremnos University," he says softly.

Mydei feels the words echo inside him, almost too heavy to process. His chest tightens, breath caught somewhere between disbelief and hope. He replays the phrase again and again, as if it might change meaning with repetition.

"Why?" he manages, voice thin, fragile.

Phainon smiles guiltily at him.

"There's someone I like way too much going back to Kremnos soon," Phainon says, and Mydei feels the corners of his eyes beginning to burn. Phainon keeps going, a bit more lightheartedly now. "And I thought that maybe Kremnoans could use new engineers, too. Have you seen how unnecessarily big their buildings are? Talk about a waste of space."

Mydei's laugh comes out pathetic, tangled with a sniffle.

"Phainon…" He lifts his free hand to rub his eyes, catching the tears before they fall.

The emotions swirl too fast—joy, disbelief, fear, longing. It's overwhelming. Mydei can't blindly accept this reasoning, even though he wants to. He had seen the acceptance letter Phainon received from Belobog—they were practically begging to have him. Phainon can't throw his future in the bin because of him.

If Phainon sacrifices Jarilo for his sake, Mydei knows he'll never forgive himself.

"But… what about your dream?" he manages to say, his voice strained and frayed at the edges. "You sacrificed so much to be accepted at Belobog. All those years of staying at the top… was it all for nothing?"

Phainon listens to him in silence, but his soft smile never falters. Then, with deliberate gentleness, he lifts their joined hands and presses a featherlight kiss to Mydei's knuckles.

"I asked myself many times… about what my dream really is. The more I thought about it, the clearer it became: Belobog was my goal, but never my dream," he says, his voice steady, eyes glowing with endearment.

"I'm not giving up on my dream, Mydei. Because—" He pauses, letting the weight of the moment settle between them.

"—you are my dream."

Phainon seems determined to make Mydei cry tonight. His words are laced with so much sweetness that they break through Mydei's defenses, leaving him sobbing. He wants to call him out for being reckless, for throwing away a future that others would kill for over a

teenager who spent two years breaking his heart. It almost sounds like…

"…You talk as if you're in love with me, Phainon," Mydei says quietly, and the thought makes his head spin. It's a feeling neither of them has ever known, and it might be too much right now. "We're too young for that."

Phainon considers it with a thoughtful hum, his thumb still brushing over Mydei's knuckles.

"You're right," he agrees with a short nod. "But what I'm trying to say is… I want to learn what love is, together with you."

The words hang between them, fragile yet full of promise, and Mydei feels the ache in his chest shift—no longer just dread, but something warmer, something that dares to hope.

Phainon's brows crease slightly as he tilts his head, a clear hint of doubt in his eyes.

"Unless… you don't like the idea of me going with you?"

Mydei realizes then that he's fighting a losing battle against both Phainon and his own heart, which is beating wildly inside his chest. All the time he spent lamenting their impending end seems like a nightmare—one he has just woken from. And what he sees in front of him is this person, as bright as the dawn itself, offering a future they can both share.

How could he not embrace it completely?

"I want it," he says in a single breath. He wants to go with him to Kremnos; he wants to build a future with him. And he also wants to learn to love, together. The words erase every lingering doubt. Phainon exhales in relief, his shoulders easing as he waits patiently for Mydei to calm down, their joined hands still warm between them.

They do the dishes together, neither of them touching the earlier subject—the promise is there, but the details can wait. Soon after, Mydei's alarm rings. It's almost time for the "*I 'Awoo' You*" special premiere.

They settle onto the living room couch. Winter has begun to creep in, the chill of the night softened by the sheet Mydei drapes over them and his Fig Stew plushie tucked against his side. Phainon emerges from the kitchen with a bowl of popcorn, triumphant, even though they just had dinner.

"We don't have a big premiere unless it has popcorn," he argues with a bowl in hand. Mydei rolls his eyes, though he reaches for a handful from time to time.

At exactly 8 p.m., *The Awoo Firm* logo fills the screen as the upbeat opening song begins. The script is almost exactly as Evernight had envisioned: Fig Stew has been cursed by an elusive witch, rendering it unable to talk—only "*awoo*"—until it receives a kiss from his crush. It brings together all the little chimeras as they hunt for a solution, from Nouns making Fig Stew drink bizarre concoctions—one of which turns it into a tiny mouse for a few minutes—to Butterfly Cake consulting the dead for alternatives.

After so many failed attempts, Fig Stew begins to think it'll never speak again. Then, Oatmeal announces that Vigethos is back from its mission to hunt the witch, only to find she managed to curse one of its friends in its absence. Vigethos finds Fig Stew sitting dejectedly alone on a rooftop. The little white-and-gray chimera decides to use the curse as a chance to finally let Fig Stew know how he's felt since they first fought. Nuzzling their snouts together, it whispers, "I *awoo* you," to the Kremnoan chimera.

The first thing Fig Stew says when his voice returns is "HKS," which has Phainon laughing and pointing out the obvious similarities between the orange chimera and his boyfriend. Meanwhile, Mydei feels a bit flustered. Then, just before the credits roll, Fig Stew nuzzles back against Vigethos, letting out a small, timid "*awoo*" of its own.

"That was cute," Phainon says softly.

"Mh-hm." Mydei agrees, hugging his plushie just a little tighter.

It was fun to watch. Mydei can sort of understand the appeal of seeing his favorite chimera happy with its crush.

With the popcorn bowl empty, Mydei flicks through the channels for a while until he settles on a culinary show. Ironically, the competition's theme is Kremnoan cuisine. Just as he's about to change the channel again, Phainon stops him.

"Hey, I wanna see what I'm getting myself into. Let's watch," Phainon says playfully. Mydei rolls his eyes. There are plenty of other cuisines in Kremnos, and since he'll be the one doing the cooking, he certainly won't condemn his boyfriend to just one. Still, he lets him have his fun.

Mydei tries not to judge the participants too harshly, but there are so many mistakes in portioning and temperature that his head almost aches. To distract himself, he finds his mind drifting back to their earlier talk. About their future together.

His pulse quickens the more he dwells on it. Sharing a room; coming home every day to Phainon's warm embrace. No more needing to part ways at the end of the night.

He shifts closer under the blankets. His knee comes to rest above Phainon's tight, and the silver-haired teen shifts a little, interest piqued. His hand finds the meat of Mydei's tight muscle, and he squeezes it, fingers teasingly playing with the hem of his shorts. It ignites that burning sensation he's still getting used to.

When Phainon's cerulean eyes meet his golden ones, he recognizes the same emotion reflected there. Their faces are so close, warm breaths mingling in the cool night air. Mydei's chest swells.

*Do you also want me?*

Unable to hold back any longer, Mydei leans in. Unlike their recent make-out sessions, this

kiss carries none of that unspoken urgency—no lingering fear of goodbye. It's slower, warmer. Phainon wraps his small waist with strong arms, and Mydei fully climbs onto his lap, blanket sliding off his shoulders. The Fig Stew plushie is pushed aside, their chests heaving against each other. Mydei deepens the kiss, hands anchoring on silver locks as Phainon pushes him back until he's lying comfortably on the couch, legs parting to allow his boyfriend full access to him.

"Mydei…" Phainon whispers against his lips, a question clear in the haze of his clouded blue eyes. His hands tighten around Mydei's hips, as if he's exercising restraint. With lips still glossy from the kiss, he quietly asks. "…are you sure?"

Mydei cups his cheeks, drawing him down into another chaste kiss as he breathes his reply against Phainon's lips;

"Yeah. I want you."

Phainon doesn't need to be told twice. He's back to kissing him deeply again, and their hands begin to map each other's bodies. Phainon's kisses are like burning wounds on his skin, and even after they're fully exposed, the warmth of their bodies is enough to keep the chill air at bay. It's by no means a practiced act; there's still some shyness and awkward pauses when they think of the next step. Yet they do it together, through trial and failure, amidst laughs and tender touches.

As Mydei had spent so much time imagining, Phainon is gentle and caring, unraveling him slowly until neither can tell where one begins and the other ends—until their tangled limbs become a single body, sharing the same heartbeat. Mydei thinks it feels too perfect to be real.

With Phainon's warmth pressed against him, whispering his name so tenderly and gazing at Mydei as though he were the most precious thing in the world… Mydei realizes he is already beginning to understand what love truly means.



Mydei is staring intently at his laptop when he hears the front door open. He glances at the clock with a frown—had he really spent two entire hours thinking of the dishes for the menu?

“Hey, babe,” Phainon says as he finds him on the couch, kissing his forehead. He hangs up his coat and loosens his tie, looking as though he’s about to burst with excitement. “I have great news.”

Mydei glances up at him with a tinge of curiosity.

“What is it?”

Phainon can’t hold back his smile, though he tries to pause for suspense. He places a hand on his hip, as if preparing to make a grand announcement.

“The project got approved,” he says, and Mydei’s brows lift in surprise.

That means…

“Your restaurant is finally getting out of paper, Mydei.”

“…Oh,” is all he manages to say. He still can’t believe it.

Five years ago, he and Phainon moved in together to attend Kremnos University. They settled into a small apartment near campus, since it was what sharing the rent would allow—Phainon insisted on contributing even after learning about Mydei’s financial situation. Although it had two bedrooms, it was a near-daily occurrence for them to wake up cuddled in one of them. Turns out a bigger bed solved most of their messy sleeping habits.

Through stressful assignments, internships that ate up most of their day, household responsibilities, and even some silly arguments over laundry and groceries, they made it work.

Mydei got the permit for a restaurant not long after graduating. His father, for once, might have helped speed things up. Phainon found a job at one of Kremnos’ largest construction companies, having shifted from robotics engineering to civil engineering when he applied for his degree. The man wasn’t kidding when he said he wanted to change the very core of Kremnos’ architecture.

He insisted that Mydei entrust the project to him. Under normal circumstances, a young engineer would never be allowed to take on such a large-scale project—especially after the company realized that the client was Eurypon’s son. But a single look at Phainon’s stellar academic record was enough to silence the higher-ups.

They moved to a bigger apartment closer to the city center and got down to planning their next steps. Phainon took every observation Mydei made to heart—from the placement of every table to the kitchen’s layout. In return, Mydei used his boyfriend as a test subject for

the menu, which was a bit of a double-edged sword, since Phainon loved almost everything he made.

And now, with Mydei's dream so close to becoming a reality, he can't help but think it would never feel this fulfilling if he didn't have Phainon by his side.

He sets his laptop on the desk, getting up to pull the man into a tight hug. Phainon laughs, hugging him back just as fiercely. They exchange saccharine-sweet words, meant for each other's ears only.

Together, they head to the kitchen, cheerful banter filling the air as Mydei decides what he's cooking tonight. Phainon leaves his phone on the island, just beside Mydei's. The Fig Stew charm is still there, but it has company now—Mydei paid a small fortune to give Phainon the same limited edition charm of Vigethos. Their threads are a little tangled, as if fate itself bound them together.

On the living room wall, two large artworks hang. One is of Fig Stew playing with a small golden nymph, and the other of Vigethos holding Dawnmaker proudly in its mouth. Curiously enough, when put side by side, the artworks seem like a single, complete piece. As it turned out, the special merch consisted of pieces autographed by the writers themselves, alongside a thank-you note and lifelong Chimera Park permits. Phainon and Mydei do plan to return to the park someday—after all, the place holds a special role in their story.

It became a playful ritual, the way Phainon would leave the apartment by saying "I *awoo* you" every day since they started university. Mostly, it was to annoy Mydei, but whenever the Kremnoan was feeling silly or just too flustered, he would throw back an "I *awoo* you, too," much to Phainon's delight.

Somewhere along the way, however, the meaning of the word shifted. As they built their lives and dreams together, it was safe to say now that even the smallest *awoo* could be used as a word for love, too.

Chapter End Notes

I was so anxious to post this. It still blows my mind how much love this silly fic got. All I had when I started was just the park mascot theme and wanting to write about Phaidei learning about love together in their youth.

For everyone who took their time to read this, and even more to those who shared their thoughts or just clicked that Kudo on their exit: thank you. You may not realize how much it means for an introverted, insecure person like me.

If this story brought any fun to you, I believe it fullfiled it's purpose.

This is by no means goodbye, but with 4.0 approaching, I might get some time off to actually play the game and read some other amazing fanfics about our boys. Who

knows, we may meet again sooner than you expect... :)

To everyone in this amazing community: I *awoo* you guys ♥

See ya!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!